

ART RESOURCE GUIDE 26/27

TRAVEL AND TRANSPORTATION IN ART

JOURNEYS OF TRANSFORMATION: AN EXPLORATION OF TRAVEL AND TRANSPORTATION

The vision of the United States Academic Decathlon[®] is to provide students the opportunity to excel academically through team competition.

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Introduction

Travel can serve as a source of enjoyment and relaxation, inspiration, or education about other places and peoples. Travels are also undertaken out of necessity or in search of new routes, materials, or goods. This resource guide will provide background on eighteen works of art made from roughly the eighteenth century to today, all of which illuminate changing ideas about travel, technology, transportation, and tourism. Covering several hundred years and a variety of cultural traditions, these artworks demonstrate how artists have represented travel in their work, both literally and thematically. This art resource guide will show how the arts reflect diverse experiences of travel in the modern world. By understanding more about these works and their contexts, students will learn how travel experiences shape artistic production, including visual styles, subjects, and materials, around the world.

Section I provides a background on methods and terminology needed for the study of art history. It outlines, briefly, a global history of art, including an overview of Western art and brief summaries of key themes and works in Asian, African, Islamic, and Indigenous American arts. This section provides the vocabulary for visually analyzing works of art and for understanding the media and techniques that have been used to produce art.

Section II analyzes artworks focused on navigation, mapping, and orienting oneself in space. It focuses on how oral and visual traditions, including those of the Marshallese people in Micronesia and enslaved people in the American South, helped guide travelers on long journeys without the use of written or printed maps. It then discusses how land artists in the 1960s explored the perceptual elements of walking and how artists have responded to histories of mapping and naming new places.

Section III covers the transnational transmission of ideas and people. The first part of this section focuses

on the legacies of global maritime exploration and British imperial expansion. The second part explores works by artists who traveled globally, bringing elements of their home cultures with them while they studied and worked in foreign cities, blending different cultural inspirations in some of their most important artworks. Finally, this section will conclude with a work that synthesizes both these themes: a painting that reflects on how histories of empire interface with personal experiences of migration.

Section IV addresses modern tourism as a form of “traveling for pleasure,” a concept that was relatively rare before the eighteenth century. This section explains global histories of nature tourism that arose out of modernization and urbanization. City-dwellers increasingly turned to nature as a form of escape and relaxation. This section will also discuss histories of souvenir images, from the Grand Tour of the eighteenth century, an elite ritual for wealthy, educated men, to the rise of snapshot photography. Newly available portable cameras enabled anyone to take photographs of their travels easily and without any technical knowledge.

Finally, Section V will discuss how modern forms of transportation, including trains, cars, and airplanes, produced new experiences of speed and dynamism. Artists from the Impressionists onward tried to replicate the modernity of these modes of transportation by experimenting with visual styles and media. Many artists believed that modern modes of travel required avant-garde visual approaches that pushed the boundaries of traditional representation.

Together, the eighteen works discussed in this resource guide demonstrate the importance of travel for understanding global history, changing trends in artistic production, modern attitudes about technology and the world, and the fundamental human experience of finding our way.

NOTE TO STUDENTS: Throughout the resource guide, you will notice that some terms have been boldfaced and underlined. These terms are included in the glossary at the end of the resource guide. Also, students should be aware that dates in art history, especially early dates, frequently vary depending on

the source and are often highly contested. The dates presented in this resource guide are not necessarily definitive, but are those dates provided by the museums that house the artworks or the sources consulted by the author in writing this guide.

Art Fundamentals

INTRODUCTION TO ART HISTORY

Art history is an academic discipline dedicated to the reconstruction of the social, cultural, and economic contexts in which an artwork was created. The basic goal of this work is to arrive at an understanding of art and its meaning in its historical moment, taking into consideration the formal qualities of a work of art, the function of a work of art in its original context, the goals and intentions of the artist and the patron of the work of art, the social position and perspectives of the audience in the work's original time and place, and many other related questions. Art history is closely related to other disciplines such as anthropology, history, and sociology. In addition, art history sometimes overlaps with the fields of **aesthetics**, or the philosophical inquiry into the nature and expression of beauty; and **art criticism**, or the explanation of current art events to the general public via the press.

This brief introduction to the discipline of art history will help you understand the kinds of questions that one may ask in order to arrive at a deeper understanding of a work of art. We will put these ideas into practice as we proceed through case studies related to the specific topic of the resource guide.

Methods and Inquiries of Art History

Art historians today generally define “art” very broadly and include in their inquiries almost any kind of visual material that is created by people and invested with special meaning and/or valued for its aesthetic appeal. In the past, art historians often limited their focus to what was called “fine art,” which generally included paintings, prints, drawings, sculpture, and architecture, usually produced specifically for appreciation by an audience who also understood these objects as works of art. Today we define art much more broadly, also taking into consideration objects that in the past were dismissed as “craft”: textiles, pottery, and body art such as tattoos,

for example. Art historians also consider objects that might not be considered art by their intended audience, including mass-produced posters and advertisements and even the design of ordinary household items like telephones, forks, and the living room sofa.

Art historians acknowledge that the meaning of a work of art can shift over time, and that an artwork may be perceived differently by viewers who approach it from different perspectives. To give one hypothetical example, Michelangelo's paintings on the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel would have certainly been significant in different ways in the eyes of 1) the Pope, who commissioned the work and who had sophisticated theological knowledge and nearly exclusive access to this private space within the Vatican and 2) a worker who was charged with cleaning the floors of the chapel and whose level of literacy was probably quite low. Differences such as social status, education, physical access to a work of art, religious background, race, and gender have an impact on the construction of the meaning of a work of art. Similarly, the paintings' meaning to a twenty-first-century Protestant, Muslim, or atheist is certainly different from the meaning they had for a practicing Catholic in the sixteenth century, even though the works may be equally admired for their aesthetic value by all of these viewers. In other words, the meaning of a work of art is not fixed; it is sometimes open to multiple interpretations taking into consideration factors such as historical context.

The Nature of Art Historical Inquiry

Art historians generally analyze works of art in two ways that are distinct from one another, but also interrelated. These two modes of analysis are called **formal analysis** and **contextual analysis**. Formal analysis focuses on the visual qualities of the work of art itself. A basic assumption of formal analysis is that the artist makes decisions related to the visual aspects of the artwork that can reveal to us something about its

meaning. From this point of view, aspects of meaning are intrinsic to the work of art. Terms associated with the formal qualities of works of art, or the “elements of art,” are discussed in detail a bit later in this section of the guide. Formal analysis requires excellent skills in observation and description. Beginning our study of an artwork with formal analysis keeps the focus on the object itself, which to the art historian is always primary.

Contextual analysis involves looking outside of the work of art in order to determine its meaning. This involves examining not only the context in which the work was created, but also later contexts in which the work was and continues to be consumed. Contextual analysis focuses on the cultural, social, religious, and economic context in which the work was produced. Art historians may examine issues of **patronage**, viewer access to the work, the physical location of the work in its original context, the cost of the work of art, the subject matter in relation to other artworks of the time period, and so on.

Art history often emphasizes a chronological development with the assumption that within one cultural setting the work of one generation of artists will have an impact on following generations. Art historians often use comparative study. For example, by contrasting a Gothic with a Renaissance artwork, we can understand more clearly the unique features of each and the series of stylistic changes that led from one to the other. Then, we can seek to relate these changes to historical context. Art history provides information and insights that add background to the meaning and significance of the works of art we study. As we place these works of art in their cultural and historical context, they are connected to the long history of events that has led up to our present culture.

Sources, Documents, and the Work of Art Historians

Art historians often begin their analysis with a close examination of a work of art. Direct examination of the work of art is ideal because much is lost when we look at a reproduction rather than an original object. In the case of sculpture, it is often difficult to get a proper sense of the scale and the three-dimensional qualities of a piece from a photograph. We lose the texture and some of the rich colors when we experience paintings in reproduction. Even photographs can appear flatter, lacking their subtle transitions from light to dark

when seen reproduced in books. It is quite common, though, for art historians to settle for studying from reproductions due to practical constraints. In some cases, works of art might be damaged or even lost over time, and so art historians rely on earlier descriptions to aid in their formal and contextual analysis. In addition to examining the work of art in question, art historians will also seek to understand any associated studies (sketches, preparatory models, etc.) and other works by the artist and their contemporaries.

Art historians also use many written sources in the quest for contextual information about a work of art. Often these texts are stored in archives or libraries. Archival sources may include items such as letters between the artist and patron, or other documents pertaining to the commission, and art criticism produced at the time the work of art was made. An art historian might also search for written documentation about the materials used to produce the work of art, such as their cost and source, and about the function of the artwork—how a particular sculpture was used in ritual practice, for example. Art historians also seek to situate the work in the context of the literature, music, theater, and history of the time period.

Art historians may also rely on interviews with artists and consumers of works of art. This is especially the case in cultures that rely more on oral history than on written documents. Guided by the field of anthropology, some art historians also use methods such as participant observation to understand the context of a work of art. An art historian studying masquerade traditions in West Africa, for example, may participate in a performance while carefully documenting the event in order to better understand art traditions.

The Development of Art History

As an academic discipline, art history arose in the mid-eighteenth century. However, we can look at the work of much earlier writers to see how commentary on art has developed over time. The ancient Roman historian **Pliny the Elder** (23–79 CE) sought to analyze historical and contemporary art in his text *Natural History*. During the Renaissance, the author and artist **Giorgio Vasari** (1511–74) gathered the biographies of great Italian artists, past and present, in *The Lives of the Artists*. Vasari’s text provides us with insights into the changing roles of artists in society during this period and the developing concept of artistic genius.



Giorgio Vasari, self-portrait c. 1567.

Modern art history was strongly influenced by eighteenth-century Enlightenment philosophy. **Johann Joachim Winckelmann** (1717–68) was a German scholar who shifted away from Vasari's biographical emphasis to a rigorous study of stylistic development as related to historical context. Through the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, art historians continued to develop approaches that placed increasing emphasis on an understanding of the interrelationship between the formal qualities of a work of art and its context.

When considering contemporary views of art history as well as perspectives on art history from the past, it is important to keep in mind that all histories are individual stories and thus will inevitably reflect certain biases. More recently, art history has been revised, particularly by feminist historians, who have noted that the traditional version of art history has largely focused on white men, whether as artists or as patrons. As a result of such revisions, art history has expanded its scope in recent years and has become a field that is broader, more international, more multicultural, and more inclusive than in the past,

often involving Marxist, feminist, and psychoanalytic methods and viewpoints. Moreover, the concern with great artistic geniuses and masterpieces has lessened as the full range of “visual culture,” ranging from advertisement posters to film to photography and television imagery, has come to view.

BRIEF OVERVIEW OF THE ART OF THE WESTERN WORLD

This brief overview of Western art is intended to provide you with a basic understanding of important art historical periods as they developed chronologically. This abbreviated discussion also covers some key artistic innovations that occurred over time, providing you with examples of artists and works in their historical contexts. This basic information will set the stage for our more in-depth discussion of our case study focusing on art related to travel and transportation. Of course, a brief guide such as this only begins to touch upon the richness and power of the stories that comprise the history of art. You may also enjoy looking at other works from each of the periods discussed, beginning your own exploration of these works in their historical contexts.

Much of what we know of the earliest life on earth has been revealed through a study of the objects or artifacts that remain from early cultures. In many cases, the objects that remain are those made of enduring materials such as stone, metal, or fired clay, as opposed to those made of perishable materials like wood or fibers. Environmental conditions also have a major impact on preservation. The hot dry climate of the desert in Egypt, for example, enabled the preservation of even delicate materials like papyrus, and the sealed atmosphere of Egyptian caves and tombs likewise helped to preserve the objects contained within them for our wonder and enjoyment centuries later. In contrast, the humid climate of West Africa means that objects made of perishable materials have had little chance of survival over the course of decades, not to mention centuries.

This is one reason that the history of art as a discipline has placed greater emphasis on Western cultures, often neglecting to focus on developments in Nonwestern cultures. It is important to recognize that the civilizations that are most often studied in art history courses are not necessarily those where the most or the best art was made. Rather, they are the civilizations whose art has been preserved and whose art has been

discovered. There are, for example, many sites of important civilizations in Central and South America that though known, remain yet unexplored. Too often the story at these sites has been one of exploitation and destruction, as people carelessly take artifacts to sell them on the international market in antiquities.

Ancient Civilizations

Art of the Old Stone Age

Although older cave paintings have been discovered elsewhere, the oldest works of art that we will consider are the cave paintings found in Chauvet Cave in southeastern France. These paintings, discovered in 1994, date from c. 30,000 BCE and thus are placed in the Old Stone Age (Upper Paleolithic Period). It should be noted that art historians use the best available information to date works of art from the distant past. Estimated dates are frequently contested and sometimes revised as new information becomes available.

Except for a minimal use of yellow, the paintings and engravings in Chauvet Cave were created using red ochre and black charcoal and depict animals such as horses, rhinoceros, lions, buffalos, and mammoths. Additional cave paintings have been discovered in other parts of France and in Spain, with those in Lascaux and Altamira being the most famous. The art in these caves takes the form of large colored drawings of animals such as horses, bears, lions, bison, and mammoths, and the paintings include several outlines of human hands. The earliest scholarship on these drawings considered them to be the spontaneous scribbling of primitive cavemen. However, with further study, it became apparent that the various groups of drawings had been created by skilled artists working within an established tradition. The artists used pigments of red and yellow ochre to add color to the elegant black outlines they had created using charcoal. Though we cannot be sure of their original function, it is possible that these works were created as a part of hunting ceremonies or other ritual behaviors.

Another well-known group of artworks from the Old Stone Age are small stone female figures that have exaggerated bellies, breasts, and pubic areas. The best known of these figures is the *Venus (or Woman) of Willendorf* (c. 28,000–25,000 BCE), which is about four and one-eighth inches high. In contrast to the exaggerated female features of the body, the facial features of the statue are undefined, the arms are barely visible, and the feet are missing. Scholars contend that these statues were fertility figures



Painting found in Chauvet Cave.

although it is not known precisely how they were used.

Art of the Middle Stone Age

During the Middle Stone Age (Mesolithic Period) the climate warmed, and a culture developed that produced art similar in some ways to the cave paintings of the Paleolithic Period. With the warming of temperatures during this era, cave dwellers moved out of their caves and began using rock shelters, as evidenced by the various paintings that have been discovered at such locations in eastern Spain. There has been much scholarly debate regarding the dating of these paintings, but it is generally estimated that they were created from around 7000 BCE until 4000 BCE. The rock shelter paintings, like the cave paintings that preceded them, demonstrate the skill of their creators in the depiction of animal figures. What sets the rock shelter paintings apart from the cave paintings is their depiction of the human figure. Except for one human figure found in the paintings at Lascaux, cave paintings did not include any human beings. The rock shelter paintings, however, portray human beings, both alone and in groups, and there seems to be an emphasis on scenes in which human beings dominate animals.

Art of the New Stone Age

The art forms most often linked with the New Stone Age (Neolithic Period) are rings or rows of rough-hewn stones located in Western Europe. These formations have been dated as early as 4000 BCE. The



Photograph of Stonehenge.

Photo by Frédéric Vincent

stones used were often exceedingly large—as much as seventeen feet in height and fifty tons in weight. Indeed, the sheer size of these works led historians to call the stones megaliths, meaning “great stones,” and the culture that created these works is often termed “megalithic.” The most well known of these rock arrangements is the one found at Stonehenge on Salisbury Plain in Wiltshire, England. Stonehenge is believed to have been built in many phases around 2100 BCE. **Stonehenge** features concentric rings made with sarsen (a form of sandstone) stones and smaller “bluestones”—rocks indigenous to the region. The outermost ring is comprised of huge sarsen stones in post and lintel construction—two upright pieces topped with a crosspiece, or lintel. The next ring is composed of bluestones, which encircle a horseshoe-shaped row of five lintel-topped sarsen stones—these are the largest ones used at Stonehenge, with some weighing as much as fifty tons. Outside the formation, to the northeast, is the vertically placed “heel-stone.” If one stands in the center of the rings and looks outward, this “heel-stone” marks the point at which the sun rises on the midsummer solstice.

The works of art and the ideas we have considered thus far have been isolated examples that have survived a very long time. The works and civilizations that we will consider next point to further conditions that allow for the creation of artworks and enable their survival. Usually, art thrives in highly organized cultures with

stable population centers—usually great cities—that house ruling classes who in turn support the work of artists.

Also, if a civilization has a tradition of protecting its art in locations that are largely inaccessible, it is more likely that the works from that culture will survive to a point where they are included in a study of art history. Many extant artifacts have come from burial chambers, caves, and tombs, where they have been protected by being naturally concealed.

Ancient Mesopotamian Art

The civilizations that arose in Mesopotamia in the valley between the Tigris and Euphrates Rivers developed writing and arts in parallel with Egypt (discussed later). Unfortunately, the Mesopotamian civilizations formed in a valley that lacked the natural barriers of deserts and mountains that protected Egypt. This left them vulnerable to invasion, and hence, the history of this ancient region is one of successive conquest and destruction. Moreover, the use of more perishable materials by Mesopotamian civilizations has left us with fewer examples of their arts.

From around 4000 BCE, the Sumerians in Mesopotamia created impressive sculptures and buildings. Religion was a central aspect of Sumerian life, and the Sumerians built massive temples at the centers of their cities. Less complex platform structures evolved over time



The 4,100-year-old Great Ziggurat of Ur, near Nasiriyah, Iraq.

into the stepped pyramids called **ziggurats**. Around 2334 BCE, the cities of Sumer came under the rule of Sargon of Akkad. Although the Akkadians spoke a different language from the Sumerians, they assimilated Sumerian culture. With the Akkadian dynasty, loyalty to the city-state was supplanted by loyalty to the king, and consequently the art of this period tends to reflect an emphasis on the monarchy, with Akkadian rulers depicted in freestanding and relief sculptures. Around 2150 BCE, Akkadian rule came to an end as the Guti, barbarous mountaineers, invaded and took control. About fifty years later, however, the cities of Sumer were able to reassert control, and a Neo-Sumerian ruler was established as the King of Ur. Perhaps the greatest known works of this era were the ziggurats that were built at the city centers. The ziggurats functioned primarily as temples but also served as administrative and economic centers.

The next important civilization in Mesopotamia was that of the Babylonians. For centuries Mesopotamia had witnessed the coexistence of several independent citystates, but around 1792 BCE, Hammurabi, king of the city-state of Babylonia, was able to centralize power. Hammurabi left an enduring legacy in that he codified Babylonian law—the Code of Hammurabi is the oldest legal code known in its entirety. The best-known artwork from this period, preserved in the Louvre Museum, is related to this code of law; it is a [stone stele](#) onto which Hammurabi's code is carved

with a sculpture in high relief at the top that depicts Hammurabi receiving inspiration for his code of law from the sun-god, Shamash.

While the Sumerian, Akkadian, and Babylonian cultures grew in southern Mesopotamia, the Assyrians dominated in the north. From about 900 BCE to around 600 BCE, the Assyrians were the most powerful civilization in the Near East. Among the most notable of Assyrian artworks are relief carvings, which often depict battles, sieges, hunts, and other important events. Throughout the seventh century BCE, the Assyrian hold on power weakened, and from c. 612–538 BCE, Babylonia once again became the dominant force in the region. It was during this Neo-Babylonian period that the famous hanging gardens of Babylon were constructed. Another important construction at this time was the Ishtar Gate, an enormous brick entryway over the main thoroughfare in Babylon. It is considered one of the greatest works of architecture in which figures—in this case animal figures—are superimposed on a walled surface.

Persian Art

The Persian Empire (c. 538 BCE–330 BCE) flourished in what is present-day Iran. The Persians were notable for their impressive architectural achievements, the most important of which was the palace at Persepolis, which was constructed of stone, brick, and wood and reflects the influence of Egyptian architecture.



Burial mask of King Tutankhamun.

Ancient Egyptian Art

Ancient Egyptian civilization is generally dated from c. 3000 BCE, following the predynastic period, through 332 BCE, when Egypt was conquered by Alexander the Great. Recognizable works include the great monuments of ancient Egypt: the Sphinx, the great pyramids at Giza, the larger-than-life-sized statues of the pharaohs, and the portrait head of Queen Nefertiti.

Much Egyptian art emphasizes a style called **hierarchical scale**, which uses the status of figures or objects to determine their relative sizes within an artwork. Hierarchical scale is exemplified in the [Palette of King Narmer](#), a relic from the Old Kingdom. This slab of stone, which may have been used as a ceremonial palette for mixing cosmetics, presents King Narmer centrally, and he is depicted as being considerably larger than the other figures. In the main image on the palette, Narmer is seen holding the hair of a fallen enemy, with his arm raised in preparation for delivering a deathblow. In the lowest section of the palette, below the king and

his enemy, are two smaller figures of defeated enemies. The organization of the figures, their relative sizes, and their poses recurred in most of the ancient Egyptian art that followed. Figures are presented so that each part of the body is shown as clearly as possible, in a technique known as “**fractional representation**.” The head is in profile with the eye in frontal view, the torso is in full frontal view, and the lower body, legs, and feet are in profile. This formula became a standard style that endured for centuries as the typical way of representing people in Egyptian art.

We know a great deal about the art of Egypt because excellent conditions for preservation were present in much of Egypt. In addition, the burial customs of the Egyptians, which decreed mummification and entombment with lavish furnishings, symbolic servants, and jewelry, resulted in rich stores of objects and images. The most famous of the Egyptian tombs is that of the boy king, Tutankhamun. By the twentieth century, most of the ancient Egyptian tombs of the Pharaohs had been broken into and robbed of the materials inside. However, Tutankhamun’s tomb, because it was cleverly hidden, remained almost completely intact until 1922. When it was opened, the excavators found a treasure-trove of objects, all superbly made of rich materials. Among the most famous of the objects is Tutankhamun’s burial mask. This mask, found in the innermost layer of the king’s sarcophagus, rested on the mummy’s face and shoulders. It is made of gold and is decorated with blue glass and semiprecious stones. The mask presents an idealized portrait of the young king.

Nubian Art

The kingdom of Nubia lay to the south of Egypt and covered a large area of Africa. As contemporary historians become increasingly interested in revising and expanding art history, more knowledge about this great African civilization is being uncovered. Indeed, it is now known that there was a period in the history of Egypt when Nubia ruled the area, and the Pharaohs of that era were Nubian. While there are few collections that feature Nubian works, this may well soon change as revisions to the story of art continue.

Greek and Roman Art

Cycladic, Minoan, and Mycenaean Art

The Aegean island cultures were very important as precursors of the Greeks in terms of art production. Three major cultures flourished on the islands in

the Aegean Sea, on Crete, and along the Aegean coast. The earliest of these cultures, the Cycladic culture, flourished from about 3200 to 2000 BCE in the Cyclades, a group of islands in the Aegean. Archaeologists still have many unanswered questions about Cycladic culture, but the simplified, geometric nude female figures from this area are highly appealing to modern sensibilities. In addition to these sculptures, the Cycladic culture produced decorated pieces of pottery as well as marble bowls and jars. Eventually, the Cycladic culture was supplanted by the Minoan culture, which developed on the island of Crete and reached its pinnacle in the second millennium BCE.

The Minoan culture centered around the city of Knossos on Crete, where the legend of the Minotaur—the creature believed to be half man and half bull who devoured those who entered his maze—is supposed to have taken place. The maze was actually the royal palace, a sprawling complex that has since been excavated. The art of these island people depicts sea life and includes statues of a female snake goddess. The Minoans created artworks that were characterized by a naturalistic pictorial style. Their paintings took two major forms: frescoes painted on palace walls and pottery designs. The architectural achievements of the Minoans were also impressive, as they built four major palaces, all completely unfortified and designed in a light, flexible, and organic style.

The collapse of the Minoan civilization coincided with the pinnacle of Mycenaean culture, and as a result, many historians believe the Minoans were destroyed by the Mycenaeans. The Mycenaean culture was centered around the city of Mycenae on the Greek mainland. The Mycenaeans built elaborate tombs, and their burial practices allowed for a large number of objects to be preserved. The objects that are best known are made of gold and show astonishing levels of mastery in goldsmithing. Additionally, the Mycenaeans demonstrated much skill in their use of **relief sculpture**.

Ancient Greek Art

From around 660 to 475 BCE, during the Archaic Period, the Greeks, influenced by the stone sculptures of Egypt and Mesopotamia, created sculptures carved in marble and limestone. These freestanding figures borrowed the frontal pose used in Egyptian art, but were more dynamic and placed greater emphasis on depicting realistic human features. Temples were also built during

this time period using columns in the early **Doric** and **Ionic** decorative styles. Vase painting was another notable art form and was done in many different styles. Some vases portrayed black silhouetted figures, while those in the **Corinthian** style set figures against a floral, ornamented background. Athenian-style vases used black figures, but were more linear and larger in scale. Red-figure vases, with red figures standing out against a black background, were also common.

The best-known ancient Greek art is that from the city-state of Athens from the Classical Period. During the Early Classical Period, temples were typically built with sturdy, Doric columns. Unfortunately, much of the sculpture from this period has not survived, but luckily Roman copies have provided us with a good deal of information on these ancient works. The sculpture of the Early Classical Period was characterized by its solemnity, strength, and simplicity of form and most often focused on a figure or scene either in the moment before or the moment after an important action. Significant advances were made in sculptural techniques, as the stiff frontal postures of the Archaic Period were largely abandoned in favor of more complex and life-like figures and positions.

Greek statuary evolved from a stiff, frontal presentation like that of the Egyptians to an increasingly natural-looking figure. A pose called “**contrapposto**,” or counter positioning, was invented to show the body to its best advantage. In contrapposto, the standing figure is posed with its weight shifted onto one leg, for a more relaxed, naturalistic appearance. Greek sculpture set the model for thousands of years in Western art, and the Renaissance, Baroque, and Neoclassical artists of the fifteenth through early nineteenth centuries aspired to equal the perfection displayed by the surviving Greek statues.

The Middle Classical Period witnessed important advances in architecture as is evident in the temples of this time period. The temple called the [Parthenon](#), restored in 447 BCE after being destroyed by the Persians in 480 BCE, is one of the most admired works of all ages, and the use of columns as exemplified in the Parthenon has been a principal feature of Western architecture for more than two thousand years.

Architecture declined during the Late Classical Period as Athens was defeated in the Peloponnesian War. Temples in this era were still built using simple Doric

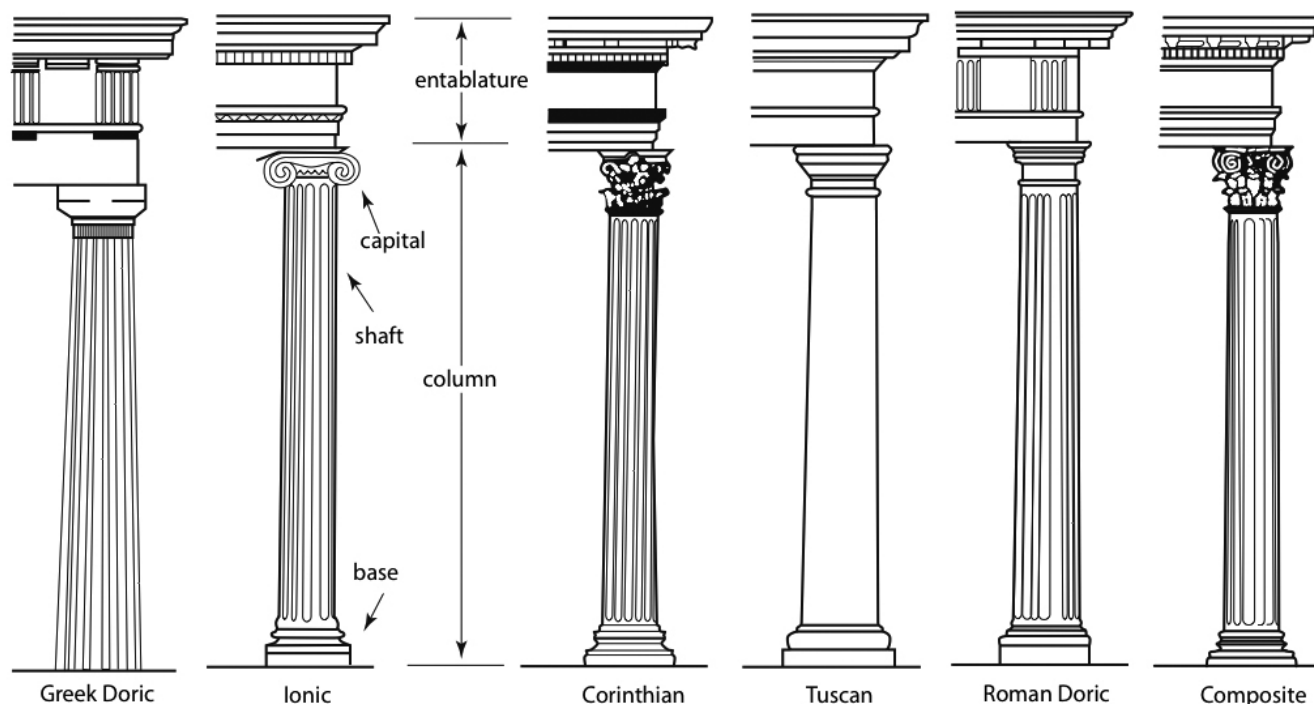


Diagram of Greek and Roman Orders. Classical Greek and Roman columns consist of a base, shaft, capital, and an entablature. Doric, Ionic, and Corinthian orders are differentiated by their degree of ornamentation.

columns, but the use of highly decorative Corinthian columns became more and more popular. The Hellenistic Period saw an increasing influence from Eastern civilizations as Greek styles blended with those of Asia Minor. Notable works of this time period include freestanding sculptures such as the [Venus de Milo](#) and the [Laocoön Group](#), which are masterworks designed to present ideals of beauty.

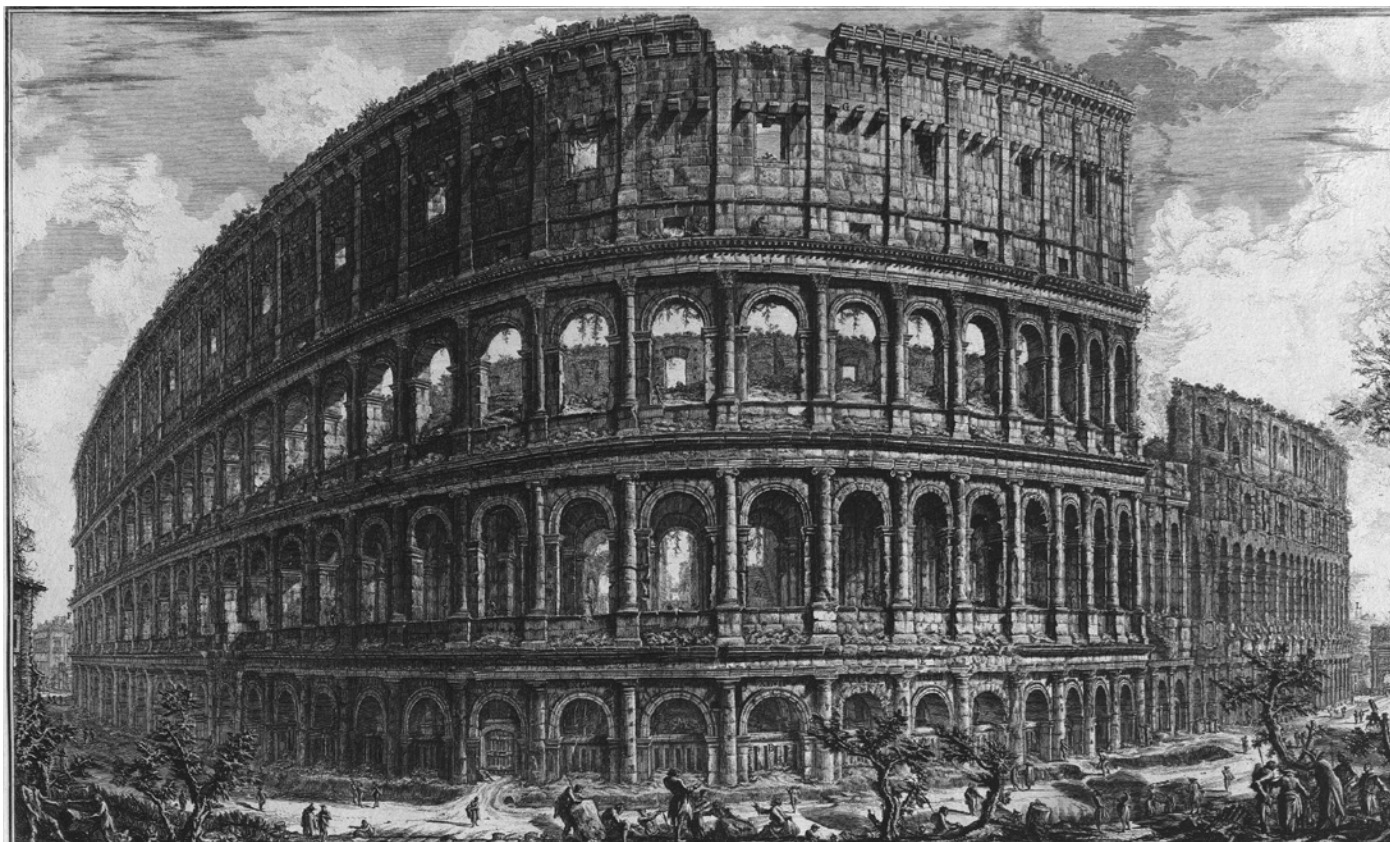
Etruscan Art

The art of the Etruscan civilization is seen as a transition from the ideals of Greece to the pragmatic concerns of the Romans. Etruscan civilization arose in what is now Italy in the first millennium BCE. Like other cultures we have examined, this one is known largely from the arts of tomb decoration. Nothing remains of Etruscan buildings as these were constructed of brick and wood. However, ceramic models depict temples with tiled, gabled roofs supported by columns in the fashion of the Greeks. Extant Etruscan artifacts also include sarcophagus lids and other art forms made of baked clay, as well as objects that display the Etruscans' talent in bronze work. The only paintings that remain from the Etruscan culture are those found on the walls and ceilings of tombs. These were done in bright,

flat colors, and they show figures playing music and dancing as part of funeral celebrations.

Roman Art

The story of Rome is one of conquest and empire building. Early Roman art reflected the influence of Etruscan art. However, by the second century BCE many Roman sculptures and other Roman artworks were variations of Greek works, and the standards for idealized presentations of Roman rulers were based on those of the Greeks. The Romans, however, made pioneering advancements in architecture and engineering. The Roman discovery of the equivalent of modern **concrete** was a major contribution to architecture, as it enabled Roman builders to fill the spaces between their stone walls with rocks and rubble bound together by the concrete mixture. With this strong material, the Romans were able to construct huge domed buildings. They also pioneered the use of the curved **arch**, using this form to build bridges and aqueducts. These structures were part of a paved road system, making communication and control very effective in the Empire. Two buildings that can still be seen in Rome, the [Colosseum](#) (72–80 CE) and the [Pantheon](#) (c. 126–128 CE), remain as monuments to the engineering genius of the Romans.



The Colosseum as depicted in a 1757 engraving by Giovanni Battista Piranesi.

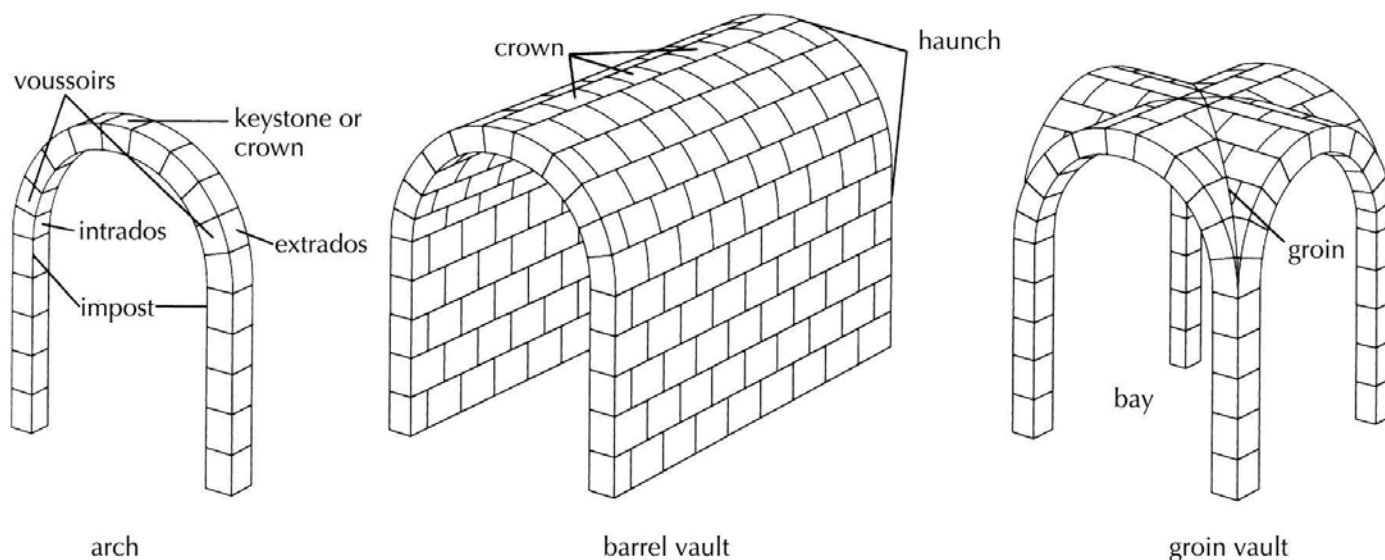
The Romans created numerous sculptures. Often, colossal triumphal arches would be topped with relief sculptures portraying Roman emperors or Roman military victories. The Romans also created relief sculptures for funerary purposes. Tombs and sarcophagi were decorated with reliefs. Some of these reliefs were simply decorative, but many others had narrative subject matter. The Romans also sculpted portraits, which ranged in size from tiny busts to huge statues. During the Roman Republic it became common for members of a funeral procession to carry small carved images of the deceased family member. Later, statues in memory of great statesmen or other noble figures were erected in public areas. Both the funerary sculptures and the public statues did not present naturalistic depictions of their subjects. Rather, the Romans favored an idealistic style that highlighted Roman ideals. The art of the Romans not only had a tremendous influence on the art of the Middle Ages, but also had a notable impact on the art of the Renaissance and much of the art that followed.

Byzantine and Medieval Art

With the fall of the Roman Empire, the connections between its parts disintegrated, and what was once a

vast empire evolved into separate and often warring kingdoms. But even as the Empire collapsed in Western Europe, it continued in Byzantium. The art that is best known from this Eastern culture is **mosaic** work in which small ceramic tiles, pieces of stone, or glass were set into a ground material to create large murals. It is an art that is largely Christian in content and can best be studied in the glimmering, shining mosaic walls of the great churches of Ravenna. Although Ravenna is in present-day Italy, it was then under Byzantine control. In terms of Byzantine architecture, the [Hagia Sophia](#) (532–537 CE), built in Constantinople, is still considered one of the greatest architectural achievements in history.

The medieval period witnessed a great deal of civil strife, and consequently the art of this era was preserved largely by the Church. During these times, the majority of the population was illiterate; formal education was largely limited to the noble class and the clergy. The international language was Latin, and books were hand copied on vellum or parchment. The preservation and production of books was largely confined to monasteries, where the monks spent time copying and illustrating the books in their collections, which



Components of an arch, a barrel vault, and a groin vault. The Romans pioneered the use of the curved arch.

were so valuable that they were chained to the tables where they were read. These illuminated manuscripts were remarkable works of art and helped facilitate the exchange of artistic ideas between northern and southern Europe. Among the many notable examples are the [Book of Kells](#) (late eighth or early ninth century) and the [Coronation Gospels](#) (c. 800–810).

Notable from the early medieval period (c. 375–1025) is the art of nomadic Germanic peoples, particularly their metalwork. The metal arts of this time period were abstract, decorative, and geometric and often took the form of small-scale, portable jewelry or ornaments made of bronze, silver, or gold and covered with patterns of jewels. Artifacts from this era also exist from the seafaring culture of the Vikings in Scandinavia. While metalwork was popular with the Germanic peoples, wood was the most important medium to the Vikings, who carved artistic designs and sculptures on their wooden ships. As a result of Viking invasions, the artistic styles of the Vikings eventually merged with those found in Anglo-Saxon England and Celtic Ireland. The resultant style is often termed Hiberno-Saxon.

In later medieval art, the architecture of churches became a dominant art form. Every city, town, and village had a church at its center, and the largest of these are masterpieces of art that often took more than a century to complete. The earliest churches of this period used a Roman arch as the basis of their design, and so the style used is called Romanesque. One

famous example is [Saint-Sernin](#) in Toulouse, France (c. 1070–1120). Romanesque churches were stone vaulted buildings that often replaced earlier churches that had highly flammable wooden roofs. Romanesque churches are usually formed of a tunnel of arches called a **barrel vault**. A **vault** is an arch-shaped structure that is used as a ceiling or as a support to a roof. Massive walls had to be built to support the heavy stone arches of the Romanesque style. Consequently, window and door openings were usually kept quite small and were often decorated with carvings and relief sculpture.

The Gothic style developed in the first half of the twelfth century and remained popular into the sixteenth century. Though this style was used for some secular buildings, it was largely applied to the construction of churches. One characteristic of the Gothic style was the use of pointed arches, which gave an upward, soaring sense to Gothic interiors. Another important element of the Gothic style was the addition of **ribbed vaults**, a framework of thin stone ribs or arches built under the intersection of the vaulted sections of the ceiling. A key innovation came in the early Gothic period when architects learned that the downward and outward pressure created by the arches of the barrel vault could be counteracted by the use of **flying buttresses**—additional bracing material and arches placed on the exterior of the building. This advance allowed for larger windows, many of which were filled with beautiful stained glass, and higher ceilings. A classic example of a Gothic cathedral is [Chartres Cathedral](#) in France (begun c. 1145; rebuilt after 1194). Here the effect of the tall

arches and the brightly colored light from the stained-glass windows directs attention heavenward.

The Renaissance in Southern Europe

Although we often tend to divide historical periods into a series of discrete and separate styles and events, in actuality, history is much more complicated and subtle. The transition from the later medieval period to the Renaissance provides a good example of this, as the styles from this period cannot be neatly identified as either Gothic or Renaissance, but rather involve a mix of the two. The artist most often mentioned in connection with this transitional time period is a Florentine named Giotto di Bondone (1267–1336/37), who is best known for his frescoes. A key advance visible in Giotto's works is his use of a simple perspective, achieved in large part by overlapping and modeling his figures in the round. This technique created the illusion of a stage for his figures, giving the viewer a sense of looking into the event. Giotto's works were different from many Gothic works as he gave his figures powerful gestures and emotional expressions. To our eyes, his paintings may not look entirely naturalistic, but his artistic innovations must have had quite an impact on viewers at the time, who were accustomed to the flat, unexpressive, and stylized figures of the Gothic style.

Like the art of ancient Greece, the art of the Renaissance continues to have an impact on art today. It is interesting to note that a change in the economy played a key part in triggering the Renaissance. It was in this time period that paper money was first developed, and its use led, in part, to the vast fortunes accumulated by notables such as the Medici family. These wealthy families were the major patrons of the arts during the Renaissance era. Another important factor was the fact that examples of Greek and Roman art were readily available in Italy, and these classical works of art had a tremendous impact on the art of the Renaissance.

As we discuss the art of this period and later, you will observe that the lives and works of individual artists are often highlighted, while this has not been the case in our discussion of earlier periods. In part, this can be attributed to a new emphasis on the individual and the concept of individual genius that emerged during the Renaissance. Until the time of the Renaissance, painters and sculptors were, in accordance with Greek traditions of art, considered artisans. That is, they were people who were viewed as being of lesser status



View of the dome of Florence Cathedral.

because they worked with their hands. During the Renaissance, the role of artists in society changed, as great artists came to be recognized as intellectual figures. Consequently, artists were accorded a special place in society.

An important event near the beginning of the Renaissance was a competition held in the city of Florence in 1401 for the design of the doors for the city's new baptistery. The winner of that competition was Lorenzo Ghiberti (1381?–1455), who designed a door panel that had figures harkening back to those of classical Greece. Ghiberti's panel design depicts the sacrifice of Isaac, in which Isaac appears as a classical Greek figure. Soon after the doors were installed, Ghiberti was asked to make a second set for another entrance to the cathedral. This second set took more than twenty-five years to complete. The doors were so magnificent that Michelangelo called them the "[Gates of Paradise](#)," and they have been referred to by that name



Leonardo da Vinci's Mona Lisa.

ever since.

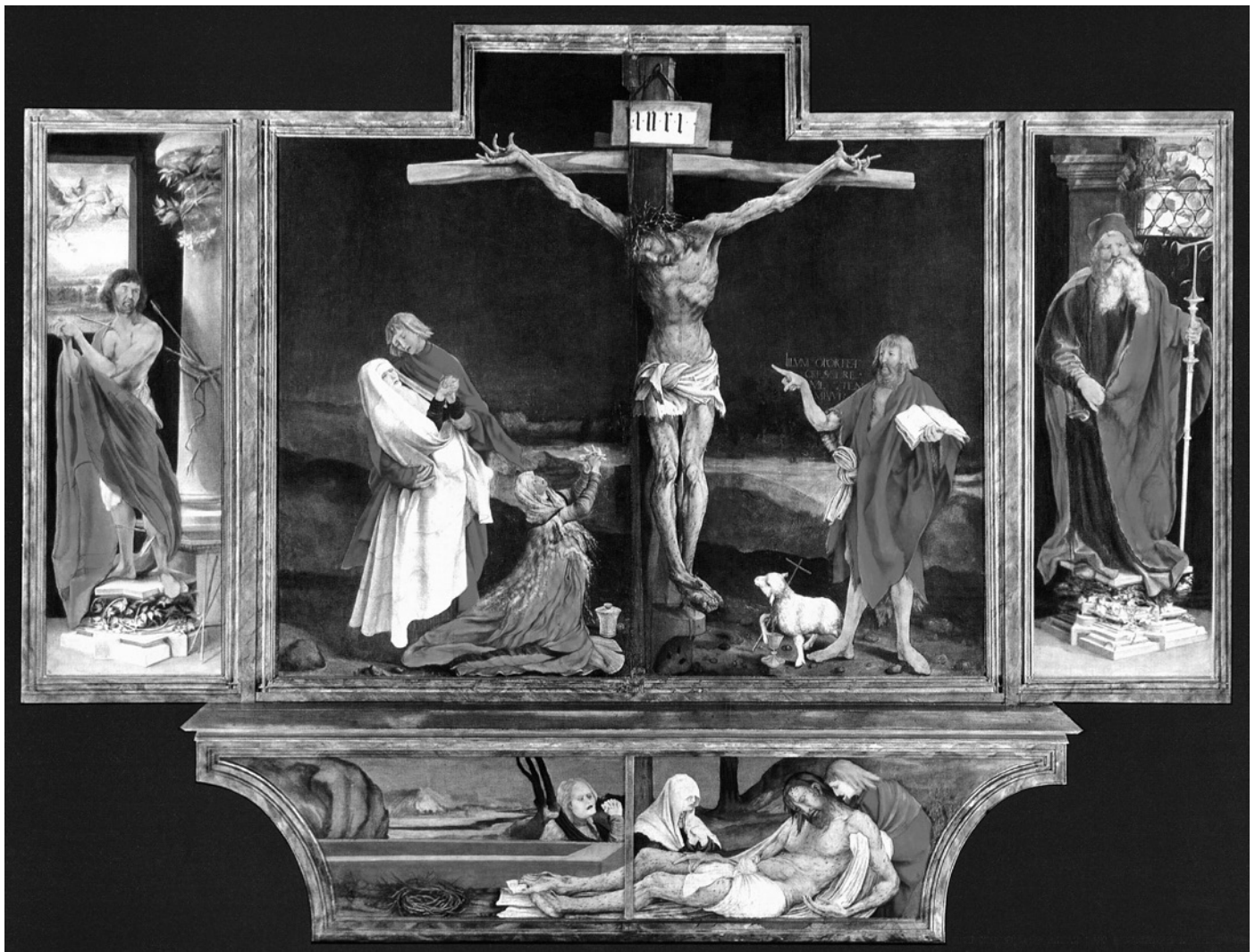
The second-place winner in the competition was Filippo Brunelleschi (1377–1446). After losing the competition, he concentrated on architecture and won a competition to complete the dome of the cathedral in Florence, which had remained unfinished for many years because architects had not been able to construct the huge vault that was required to span the open space. Brunelleschi achieved this major engineering feat with the help of a double-shelled dome design that has been imitated by many later architects. Brunelleschi is also credited with developing **linear (single vanishing point) perspective**. Masaccio (1401–28), a Renaissance painter, is given credit for putting Brunelleschi's theory into practice, as he used both linear and **aerial perspective** in his frescoes. The development of linear perspective had a tremendous and lasting influence on the world of art.

Among the most remarkable of Renaissance artists was Donatello (1389?–1466), who is widely considered the founder of modern sculpture. The influence of classical antiquity on his sculpture was strong, as evidenced by his best-known work, a bronze statue of [David](#) (c. 1420s–60s). This work was the first known freestanding nude statue to have been cast since antiquity. Toward the end of his life, Donatello's sculptures reflected a greater emphasis on naturalism and the expression of character and dramatic action.

A generation later, the work of Botticelli (1444?–1510), particularly his best-known painting, [The Birth of Venus](#) (c. 1482), established an image of female beauty that has lasted through the centuries. His long-necked Venus with her languid pose and flowing hair was one of the first paintings of a full-length nude female since antiquity.

The generation of artists that followed are often referred to as High Renaissance artists. Two well-known artists of this time period, Leonardo da Vinci (1452–1519) and Michelangelo (1475–1564), are the models for the term “Renaissance Man.” Leonardo da Vinci is well known as an inventor, but also is recognized as an architect, engineer, painter, sculptor, scientist, and musician. His design for the locks that control movements along canals from one level to another is still used today, and his drawings of submarines and helicopters have been found to be viable models. Two of his paintings, [The Last Supper](#) (c. 1495–98) and the [Mona Lisa](#) (c.1503–05), have become so well known that they are now icons of popular culture. Leonardo's key innovation in painting, which is readily apparent in the *Mona Lisa*, is the use of **sfumato**. Sfumato, from the Italian word *fumo*, meaning smoke, is the use of mellowed colors and a blurred outline. Sfumato allows forms to blend subtly into one another without perceptible transitions.

At the same time that Leonardo was working in Florence, another artist, Michelangelo di Buonarroti, was at work on the piece that would establish his reputation as a sculptor. The city held a competition to have a statue created from a massive piece of marble that it had acquired, only to discover that the marble was flawed. Taking this difficult piece, which had a large crack in the middle, Michelangelo turned it into his vision of [David](#) (1504). The statue is larger than life-sized, as it was originally meant to be placed high on the façade of the cathedral in Florence and



A partial view of Matthias Grünewald's Insenheim Altarpiece.

would have been viewed from far below. The beautiful carving, the smooth texture of the finished marble, and the striking pose were seen as the very embodiment of the spirit of Florence as a republic.

Throughout his stormy career, Michelangelo created a large number of other important sculptures, but it is a painting that often comes to mind when people hear his name. In 1505, Pope Julius II commissioned Michelangelo to design his tomb. Michelangelo began sculpting great statues such as [Moses](#) (c. 1513–15), [The Dying Slave](#) (1513–16), and [The Bound Slave](#) (1513–16) to be included in the Pope's colossal tomb. However, in the midst of this commission, the Pope canceled the project for uncertain reasons. The cancellation of his work on the Pope's tomb was one of the greatest disappointments of Michelangelo's career, and he was bitter and hesitant when Pope Julius II gave him another commission. This time, the artist was asked to decorate

the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel. It took Michelangelo four years, from 1508 to 1512, to cover the seven hundred square yards of the ceiling, but the result was an astonishing tour de force. The great masterpiece of the Sistine Ceiling has received renewed attention in recent decades, as restorers set about cleaning the great frescoes. The cleaning removed the collection of oil, wax, and grime that had accumulated over the centuries, and the colors have returned to their original brightness. Not everyone was happy with the results of the cleaning, however, and a controversy about this restoration, as well as the restoration of artworks in general, continues within the art world.

One of the most influential painters of the High Renaissance was Raphael Sanzio (1483–1520). When he was a young painter, Raphael was brought to Rome, where Julius II gave him several commissions. During this period, Raphael learned much from Michelangelo,

his older rival. Unlike Michelangelo, Raphael was not a loner, but employed numerous assistants to help him cover the Pope's official chambers with large, sumptuous frescoes, notably the *School of Athens* (c. 1508–11), an homage to the great Greek philosophers and scientists. Raphael is considered the most influential painter of the Madonna. His masterworks, such as the *Sistine Madonna* (c. 1513–14), created an image of the Virgin Mary that has endured in religious paintings throughout the centuries.

Rome and Florence were not the only locations to witness an incredible flowering in the arts. Venice, too, became a center of artistic creativity. Giorgione (1477/78–1510) is credited with making innovations in the subject matter of landscapes, as he painted scenes not taken from the Bible or from classical or allegorical stories. Prior to Giorgione's painting *The Tempest* (c. 1508), artists had generally begun with the figures that were to be the subject matter of the painting and then added the background. However, in *The Tempest* the landscape became the subject of the painting—the figures depicted are of lesser importance than the storm that threatens them.

Titian Vecelli (c. 1488–1576) was one of the most prolific of the Venetian painters. Titian is well known for his portraits of his patrons, and he is also recognized as having been the greatest colorist of the Renaissance artists. Titian was an innovative portraitist. He used various elements of setting, such as a column or a curtain, as the backdrop for his portraits instead of an atmospheric neutral background, as had been the custom. The influence of Titian's use and arrangement of background elements can be seen in portraiture up through the twenty-first century.

Tintoretto (1518–94), another great Venetian painter, is often linked with an artistic style called **Mannerism** that grew in popularity in the late sixteenth century. Mannerist works are characterized by the distortion of certain elements such as perspective or scale and are also recognizable by their use of acidic colors and the twisted positioning of their subjects. Although Tintoretto used some Mannerist pictorial techniques, his color schemes differed from those of the Mannerists. Tintoretto presented his figures from dramatic angles—it is said that he used small figures as models and arranged them and rearranged them until he had the most dramatic effect. He also used dramatic contrasts of light and dark, called **chiaroscuro**, to heighten the

emotional impact of his subjects. Tintoretto's later works are marked by their spiritual subject matter, and his use of sharp perspectives and chiaroscuro anticipate the Baroque era.

One of the most important events impacting the history of sixteenth-century art was the **Reformation**. Protestants criticized the opulence and corruption of the Catholic Church and called for its purification. For art, this meant a move away from the richly decorated churches and religious imagery of the Renaissance. The Church reacted to the Protestant Reformation by launching a **Counter-Reformation**, which emphasized, even more than before, lavish church decoration and art of a highly dramatic and emotional nature. One of the artists most closely associated with the Counter-Reformation is Dominikos Theotokopoulos, known as El Greco. El Greco was strongly influenced by Tintoretto's paintings, and he worked for a period of time in Titian's workshop in Venice. In 1576, El Greco left Italy for Toledo, Spain. El Greco is one of the most well known of the Mannerist painters, and his dramatic use of elongated figures captured the religious fervor of the Counter-Reformation. The works of both El Greco and Tintoretto can be seen as transitional works bridging the end of the Renaissance and the beginning of the Baroque period.

The Renaissance in Northern Europe

During the fifteenth century, the artworks being produced in northern Europe were smaller in scale than those of contemporaneous artists to the south. However, the work of northern artists displayed a degree of realistic detail beyond what can be seen in works of the south, primarily due to their use of new **oil paints**. While the Renaissance was occurring in Italy, much of European art north of the Alps was still Gothic in style. The influence of classical antiquity was also much less of a factor in the north, as the northerners did not share Italy's cultural connection with ancient Rome, nor did they have the advantage of being in close proximity to ancient Roman works as did their Italian counterparts.

The art of northern Europe in the sixteenth century demonstrates a far greater awareness of the Italian Renaissance than that of the fifteenth century. Many artists traveled to Italy to study the great works of the Renaissance, and some Italian artists brought these ideas with them when they traveled to the north. Engravers

copied some of the more notable Italian works, and these engravings became available throughout Europe, thus spreading the ideas and styles of the Renaissance. Trade connections between upper-class German merchants and merchants in Venice, a center of trade and art, provided another avenue of influence.

Though the influence of the Italian masters was notable, not all northern artists embraced the ideals and innovative techniques of the Renaissance, as many maintained a more traditional approach. Moreover, though linear perspective and the colors used farther south did travel northward, the manner in which they were used in the northern countries was quite different.

During the fifteenth century and into the early decades of the sixteenth century, areas of southern Germany witnessed a flowering of artistic production. Matthias Grünewald (1475?–1528) and Albrecht Dürer (1471–1528) are often considered the greatest artists of the Renaissance in northern Europe. Although only ten of Grünewald's works have survived, his influence has nonetheless been notable. Grünewald is known for his religious scenes and his depiction of Christ's crucifixion. The [*Isenheim Altarpiece*](#) (c. 1510–15), a work consisting of nine panels mounted on two sets of folding wings, is considered to be his greatest masterpiece.

Albrecht Dürer is perhaps the most famous artist of Reformation Germany. Dürer's early training was largely influenced by late Gothic works, but as the ideas of the Italian Renaissance spread northward in the sixteenth century, Dürer's work began to reflect some of these new influences. Dürer aimed to achieve a style that combined the naturalistic detail favored by artists of the north with the theoretical ideas developed by Italian artists. He traveled to Italy, studied the work of his Italian contemporaries, and brought his new knowledge back to Germany. Dürer wrote about theories of art and published many series of woodcuts and copper engravings, such as [*The Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse*](#) (c. 1498).

Hans Holbein the Younger (1497–1543) is another important artist of this era, and he is considered one of the greatest Renaissance portraitists. Though born in Germany, Holbein is best known for his work in England. He became court painter to King Henry VIII of England, and his portrait of Henry VIII shows not only his talent for presenting details, but also his ability to capture the psychological character of his subjects.

Holbein's works became the model and standard for English painting up through the nineteenth century.

Baroque Art

The term “**Baroque**” is generally used to refer to artworks produced from the late sixteenth century through the mid-eighteenth century. Baroque styles differed from those of the Renaissance in that Baroque artworks tended to be less static than Renaissance examples; the Baroque is characterized by a greater sense of movement and energy. The political structure of Europe during the Baroque era also differed from that of the Renaissance. Whereas the Renaissance witnessed wars between cities, the Baroque era saw conflicts between empires. During this time, the Church was determined to preserve its dominance in Spain and Italy, and orders like the Jesuits were founded to convert the peoples of other areas. Baroque art appealed largely to the emotions, and thus, these artists, influenced by the Counter-Reformation, aimed at dramatic and moving appeals to faith.

The seventeenth and eighteenth centuries in Europe were a time when society was governed by a ruling class that viewed its power as a divine right. Some of the most powerful sovereigns ever to rule are from this period. Empress Maria Theresa of Austria, Peter the Great and Catherine the Great of Russia, and King Louis XIV of France dominated the lives of the people of their countries. It was a time that saw the ongoing concentration of power and wealth into the hands of a few, until the results eventually became intolerable for the majority of the people. While a small minority of the population lived in great luxury, the lives of ordinary people were generally quite difficult, and eventually this disparity gave rise to protests like those found in the writings of Enlightenment authors, Jean-Jacques Rousseau in particular. Ironically, however, it was the patronage of the wealthy ruling class that gave rise to the great works of art of the period.

As we might expect, the art of the Baroque period moved away from the classic simplicity and calm that was so characteristic of Renaissance works. The word “baroque” has come to represent the richness of color and ornamentation that heightened the energy and emotion that were characteristic of the great works of art of this period. The emphasis was on dynamic works that presented imagery in the most dramatic way possible.

Baroque painters made use of chiaroscuro, using



Rembrandt's The Company of Frans Banning Cocq and Willem van Ruytenburch, known as The Night Watch.

exaggerated contrasts between light and dark to create a theatrical kind of lighting that made the subject appear to be in a spotlight. Caravaggio (1571–1610), an Italian Baroque painter, was renowned for his dramatic use of light and dark, and his technique influenced many artists who followed. Caravaggio's work is so important that artworks using extremes of dark and light are often termed "caravaggesque." Caravaggio's work is also notable for its provocative degree of naturalism. For example, Caravaggio portrayed the Virgin Mary and the apostles not as noble figures in classical garb as they had traditionally been represented, but instead depicted them as poor and simple folks in threadbare garments. His use of actual lower-class individuals as models for his work helped him achieve this effect. It is no wonder that

several patrons of Caravaggio's canvases rejected them for this reason.

With recent revisions of art history, a woman named Artemisia Gentileschi (1593?–1652?) has also joined the ranks of important Baroque artists. Gentileschi, the daughter of a painter, had the unusual opportunity to study in her father's studio. She is particularly known for her remarkable adaptation of Caravaggio's techniques. Her works include self-portraits and paintings of Old Testament women.

The most important Baroque artist, Gianlorenzo Bernini (1598–1680), the son of a sculptor, was a child prodigy who received recognition from the Pope at age seventeen. Bernini did his most significant work

in sculpture, but he was also a talented architect, painter, and draftsman. He worked as a designer in the theater, and many of his works reflect the influence of his theatrical background. His most important masterpiece, the *Ecstasy of Saint Teresa* (1647–52), is set into the altar of the Cornaro Chapel. The space includes a concealed stained-glass window that bathes the figure of the saint in dramatic gold lighting, as if she were on a stage. Bernini treated his medium in a new way as well. He did not adhere to the classical calm and natural flow of drapery around the figure that had been used in the past. Instead, Bernini pushed the use of marble to new limits and tried to make stone look like real fabric and even clouds.

The importance of the Baroque style extended beyond Italy. In Flanders, Peter Paul Rubens (1577–1640) established a huge workshop and produced works of great energy and color that became models for many artists. In the mid-seventeenth century, Rembrandt van Rijn (1606–69), a Dutch artist, created some of the best-known works from the Baroque period. Rembrandt is recognized not only as a painter and printmaker, but also as one of the greatest draftsmen ever. Perhaps his best-known work is *The Night Watch* (1642), more properly known as *Sortie of Captain Banning Cocq's Company of the Civic Guard*. Like many other group portraits of the time, each member of the company depicted paid a certain sum to be included in the painting. Rembrandt chose to break with tradition and grouped the members of the company in a way that gave more attention to some members than to others. This break with tradition, as well as other problems in his life, ultimately caused the decline of his career. Though Rembrandt died in poverty, the self-portraits of his later years are considered to be some of the greatest studies of the inner life of the sitter ever to be painted.

It might be argued that the Baroque period reached its peak in France. There, Louis XIV had come to power, and his long reign was marked by a blossoming of French culture. Louis XIV united all of France and built a lavish [palace](#) at Versailles beginning in 1669. The palace and its grounds covered about two thousand acres and included various grand chateaux and gardens. There was a stable, capable of housing hundreds of horses, and a grand *orangerie*, or greenhouse, for the king's orange trees. Eventually there was also a zoo and a system of fountains and

waterfalls that included a grand canal large enough for the staging of mock sea battles. The opulence and power of this “sun king,” around whom the world of the court revolved, became a model that contemporaneous monarchs tried to emulate.

An important feature of Louis XIV's court that was to influence art well into the nineteenth century was the system of choosing and supporting artists called the *Salon*. This annual exhibition established a set of rules for judging art that is still influential in the art world today. It was also under the rule of Louis XIV that the *Académie Royale de Peinture et de Sculpture*, often referred to simply as the “**Academy**,” was established, and it soon came to be a means for imposing aesthetic standards and principles of taste.

To the south, the Spanish court of King Philip IV of Spain tried to emulate the court of France, and his court painter, Diego Velázquez (1599–1660), was a contemporary of Bernini. Velázquez's method of building his figures from patches of color, rather than starting from a drawing, became a model for many later artists. In fact, Velázquez's work had an influence on the movement we call Impressionism.

Rococo, Neoclassicism, and Romanticism

While the **Rococo** style might be seen as an extension of the Baroque period, it is quite different in form and content. Whereas the Baroque aimed to arouse grand emotions, Rococo works were celebrations of gaiety, romance, and the frivolity of the grand life at court, particularly the court at Versailles. The emphasis was on light-hearted decoration with the use of gold and pastel colors.

Three artists who excelled at capturing the elegance and wit so valued by their aristocratic patrons are considered the greatest masters of the Rococo style. Jean-Antoine Watteau (1684–1721) was the leader of a new generation and the innovator of a new genre of painting called the *fête galante*. Paintings of this genre generally depicted members of the nobility in elegant contemporary dress enjoying leisure time in the countryside. François Boucher (1703–70) was influenced by Watteau's delicate style. He became the favorite painter of Madame Pompadour, mistress to Louis XV, and his works often transformed the characters of classical myth into scenes of courtly



Jacques Louis David's Oath of the Horatii (1784).

gallantry, with an emphasis on nubile nudes. Jean-Honoré Fragonard (1732–1806) was also promoted by Madame Pompadour. Fragonard studied with Boucher, and his works strongly reflect Boucher's influence.

The Revolution of 1789 in France ushered in an era of great change throughout Europe, and the idea of a democratic republic ruled by and for the people was reflected in the artwork of the time. In an attempt to hearken back to the democratic ideals of the ancient world, art of this period demonstrated a revival of interest in the art of classical Greece and Rome. This style, called **Neoclassicism**, emerged in the decades leading up to the Revolution and was also influenced by Enlightenment philosophy. The Neoclassical style, a direct challenge to the Rococo and its associations with the aristocracy, is epitomized in the work of Jacques Louis David (1748–1825), whose paintings,

such as the [*Oath of the Horatii*](#) (1784), illustrated republican virtues. Following the Revolution, David joined members of the new government as the master of ceremonies for the grand revolutionary mass rallies. Later he became a dedicated painter to Napoleon Bonaparte, and in this capacity he painted large propagandistic canvases that would seem to undermine his earlier revolutionary ideals. A closer investigation of his work and his career reveals the complicated world of an artist and his patrons. The work of David's pupil, Jean Dominique Ingres (1780–1867), shows the sharp outlines, unemotional figures, careful geometric composition, and rational order that are hallmarks of the Neoclassical style.

Ingres's rival, Eugène Delacroix (1798–1863), was a proponent of **Romanticism**. This style hearkened back to the emotional emphasis of the Baroque and had



Gustave Courbet's *The Stonebreakers*.

similar characteristics, though the subject matter was different. Whereas Neoclassical works emphasized line, order, and a cool detachment, Romantic painting tended to be highly imaginative and was characterized by an emotional and dreamlike quality—the Romantics favored feeling over reason. Romantic works are also characterized by their incorporation of exotic or melodramatic elements and often took awe-inspiring natural wonders as their subject matter. Delacroix's works are characteristic of the Romantic movement in that they centered on exotic themes and included foreign settings, violence involving animals, and historical subject matter. Théodore Géricault (1791–1824) and William Blake (1757–1827) were also important Romantic artists.

Realism and Impressionism

In many ways, **Realism** was a reaction to Neoclassicism and Romanticism. The Realist style was inspired by the idea that painting must illustrate all the features of its subjects, including the negative ones. It was also obligated to show the lives of ordinary people as subjects that were as important as the historical and religious themes that dominated the art exhibitions of

the day. The artist who represented this movement most forcefully was Gustave Courbet (1819–77), a flamboyant and outgoing personality who outraged conventional audiences by showing a painting of ordinary workmen repairing a road at the official government-sponsored Salon. This work, called *The Stonebreakers* (1849–50), also had political implications in the context of a wave of revolutions that spread across Europe beginning in 1848. Realism can also be seen in the works of Honoré Daumier (1808–79) and Jean François Millet (1814–75).

Impressionism largely grew out of dissatisfaction with the rigid rules that had come to dominate the *Salons* held to recognize selected artists each year. Édouard Manet (1832–83) is sometimes referred to as the first Impressionist. Although he refused to consider himself as one of the Impressionists, Manet's work, which showed light by juxtaposing bright, contrasting colors, nonetheless greatly inspired and influenced the generation of artists following him. Manet's painting *Le Déjeuner sur L'herbe* (*Luncheon on the Grass*) (1863)—included in the *Salon des Refusés* in 1863, an exhibit of works rejected by the “official” *Salon*—was singled out for ridicule. The scandal surrounding this



Georges Seurat, photographed in 1888.

work resulted from its violation of the unwritten rule that the only appropriate nudes in contemporary art were classical figures or women in suitably exotic settings. In *Luncheon on the Grass*, Manet based his work on an engraving with a classical subject matter, but he showed contemporary clothed men with a nude woman as part of the group. This caused an uproar.

While Manet continued to submit his work to the *Salon*, other artists who disagreed with the rigid artistic standards espoused by the Académie des Beaux-Arts in Paris and favored by the Salon set about establishing Impressionism as a new style. A work by Claude Monet (1840–1926) was the source of the movement’s name. Monet showed a work that he called [*Impression, Sunrise*](#) (1872), and the critics seized on this mere “impression” as a means by which to ridicule the movement. It was Monet who urged his fellow artists to work outdoors, and these endeavors were aided by technical advances in paint and brush production that made the medium more portable. Impressionist artists put their colors directly on the canvas with rapid strokes to capture the rapidly changing light. Scientific studies of vision and color led to the discovery that shadows were not merely gray but that they reflected the complementary color of the object casting them. Camille Pissarro (1830–1903) and Alfred

Sisley (1839–99) were two other Impressionists of note.

Post-Impressionism and Other Late Nineteenth-Century Developments

The artists who followed Impressionism, though influenced by the earlier artists, took various features of Impressionism in quite different directions. The most influential of these artists was Paul Cézanne (1839–1906). Dissatisfied with the lack of solid form in Impressionist works, Cézanne set about redefining art in terms of form. He suggested that a painting could be structured as a series of planes with a clear foreground, middle ground, and background and argued that the objects in the painting could all be reduced to their simplest underlying forms—a cube, a sphere, or a cone. Here we should note the obvious influence that these ideas, presented first by Cézanne, later had on the development of Cubism in the early twentieth century.

The ongoing search for more and more brilliant color was a unifying feature for many of the **Post-Impressionists**. The work of Georges Seurat (1859–91) placed an emphasis on the scientific rules of color. Seurat applied his colors in small dots of complementary colors that blended in the eye of the viewer in what is called optical mixing. The results were vibrant, though the emphasis on technique also resulted in static compositions.

As Seurat was attracting attention and Cézanne was formulating his rules for painting, a young Dutch painter named Vincent van Gogh (1853–90) was studying art. Van Gogh, using theories of contrasting color and very direct application of paint, set about capturing the bright light of southern France. His vigorous brushwork and twisting forms were designed to capture an intense response, and though his career was short, many of his works have become very well known. Van Gogh developed the idea that the artist’s colors should not slavishly imitate the colors of the natural world, but should be intensified to portray inner human emotions. The intense and jarring yellows, greens, and reds in the poolroom of Van Gogh’s [*Night Café*](#) (1888), which van Gogh considered a place of vice, illustrate this very influential idea.

The search for intense light and clear color also marks the work of Paul Gauguin (1848–1903), who is perhaps known as much for the story of his life as he is for his art. Though he was a successful stockbroker, Gauguin

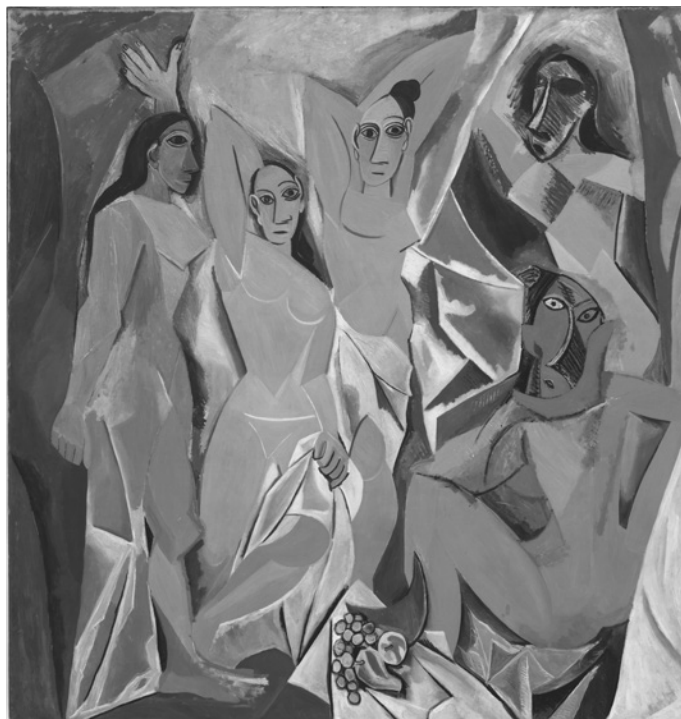
left his wife and family while in his forties to pursue his art career. He worked for a short time with van Gogh in southern France but was still dissatisfied with his art. Searching for more intense color and a more “unschooled” style, he went to Tahiti, where he painted works that depict the island’s lush, tropical setting and native people, as seen through the lens of colonialism.

At this juncture, it is important to note the outside influences that were affecting the changing art world. The invention of the camera called into question the very need to capture ordinary reality in art. Some of the most important inventions may seem quite mundane. The invention of chemically based paints and the paint tube allowed the Impressionists to paint outdoors easily for the first time. This was also a time of global exploration and colonialism, and the objects brought back from around the world had a profound effect on the Impressionists and the artists who followed. Artists were intrigued by masks from Africa, and many collected the Japanese prints that were used as packing for shipments of goods from Japan. Edgar Degas (1834–1917) was an Impressionist whose work exemplified these new influences. Degas often combined the snapshot style of photography with a Japanese-like perspective from slightly above his subject.

In England, a group of artists dissatisfied with the effects of the Industrial Revolution banded together and became known as the **Pre-Raphaelites**. These artists created a style that attempted to return to the simpler forms of pre-Renaissance art. The Pre-Raphaelites created many quasi-religious works that often blended Romantic, archaic, and moralistic elements. Their emphasis on nature and sweeping curves paved the way for **Art Nouveau**. Art Nouveau, which became popular in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, was a style of decoration, architecture, and design that was characterized by the depiction of leaves and flowers in flowing, sinuous lines.

The Emergence of Modernism

As we move into the twentieth century, we see artists who were continually striving to discover new ways of presenting their ideas. Furthering the attempts the Post-Impressionists had made to extend the boundaries of color, a group of artists led by Henri Matisse (1869–1954) used colors so intense that they violated the sensibilities of critics and the public alike. Taking their cue from van Gogh, these artists no longer thought their use of color needed to replicate color as seen



Pablo Picasso's Les Femmes d'Alger (O Version O).

in the real world. Their wild use of **arbitrary color** earned them the name of *fauves*, or “wild beasts.”

Natural form was to be attacked with equal fervor, as can be seen in developments in Paris around 1908. Pablo Picasso (1881–1973), in close collaboration with Georges Braque (1882–1963), was at work developing a whole new system of art. Picasso and Braque broke down and analyzed form in new ways in the style that came to be known as **Cubism**. Psychologists had explained that human experience is much richer than can be gathered from a traditional painting that shows a single view from a fixed vantage point. When we look at any given scene, we remember the scene as an overlay of visual impressions seen from different angles and moments in time. Picasso and Braque were familiar with these theories, as indicated by their habit of breaking figures up into multiple overlapping perspectives. The Cubists were also influenced by African art, which they imagined to be more intuitive and closer to nature than intellectualized European art. Cubist works reacted against the naturalistic, often sentimental, artworks that were popular in the late nineteenth and early twentieth century. The Cubists favored abstract forms over lifelike figures.

In Germany, an art developed that emphasized emotional responses. A group of artists calling themselves **Die Brücke**, which included Ernst Ludwig

Kirchner (1880–1938) and Emil Nolde (1867–1956), took the brilliant arbitrary colors of the Fauvists and combined them with the intense feelings found in the work of the Norwegian artist Edvard Munch (1863–1944). This highly charged attempt to make the inner workings of the mind visible in art is known as **Expressionism**. Another Expressionist group in Germany, **Der Blaue Reiter**, was led by the Russian artist Vasily Kandinsky (1866–1944), who around 1913 began to paint totally abstract pictures without any pictorial subject. Other pioneers of total **abstraction** were the Russian painter Kazimir Malevich (1878–1935) and the Dutch artist Piet Mondrian (1872–1944), whose **De Stijl** canvases, consisting of flat fields of primary color, have become a hallmark of modern art.

The next events in our story of the history of art are important because they mark the beginnings of modern art in the United States. It was these beginnings, coupled with the effects of the First World War, that were partly responsible for the eventual shift of the center of the art world from Paris to New York. While the movements of modern art were sweeping Paris, the American scene remained largely unaffected until 1913. The **Armory Show**, arranged by the Barnes Foundation and held from February 17 through March 15, 1913, was the first major showing of modern art in the U.S., and it caused a sensation. Artworks that were to become landmarks of various European art movements were a part of the Armory Show, and they had a profound and lasting effect on American art. Marcel Duchamp's (1887–1968) [*Nude Descending a Staircase*](#) (1912) and Picasso's [*Les Femmes d'Alger \(O. J. R. M.\)*](#) (1907) both shocked viewers with their challenging approaches to the figure and space. Brancusi's (1876–1957) [*The Kiss*](#), with its abstracted, block-like figures, and Kandinsky's non-objective paintings added to the outrage.

While the effects of the European works in the Armory Show rippled through the American art world, there was also a quintessentially American movement underway. During the 1920s, Harlem became a center for African-American creativity. Fueled by the popularity of jazz, writers and artists joined musicians in a flowering of the arts that is called the Harlem Renaissance. Though the movement lasted only a decade, it was an inspiration to many artists, including Jacob Lawrence, Romare Bearden, and other well-known artists of the next generation.

During World War I and its aftermath, another movement arose that challenged established ideas about art. This movement, called **Dada**, originated among a group of disaffected intellectuals living in Zurich and grew out of the angst of artists who were disillusioned with the war. Dada was an art that aimed to protest against everything in society and to lampoon and ridicule accepted values and norms. Marcel Duchamp created two works that have come to represent this amusing and irreverent view of the world. He added a mustache to a reproduction of the *Mona Lisa* and gave it an insulting title ([*LHOOQ*](#), 1919), and he also exhibited a common porcelain urinal ([*Fountain*](#), 1917).

Duchamp, in fact, invented a new category of artworks that he referred to as **ready-mades**. By taking an ordinary object and giving it a new context, Duchamp would create a work of art. In this way, Duchamp challenged traditional ideas about the way the artist functions—rather than physically making a work of art, an object became a work of art merely through the artist's choice. Picasso created several works that may also be considered ready-mades. For example, in a famous work Picasso took an ordinary object—bicycle handlebars—and made them appear as bull horns when coupled with a bicycle seat ([*Bull's Head*](#), 1943).

Some artists, influenced by the theories of Sigmund Freud, attempted to portray the inner workings of the mind in their artworks. This group of artists became known as the **Surrealists** and included artists such as Salvador Dalí (1904–89), René Magritte (1898–1967), and Joan Miró (1893–1983).

One of the most influential events in the history of art took place in Germany between the first and second world wars. A school of design called the **Bauhaus**—a name that would become a byword of modern design—established standards for architecture and design that would have a profound influence on the world of art. The Bauhaus made a bold attempt to reconcile industrial mass-manufacture with aesthetic form. Taking the view that form should follow function and should be true to the materials used, the faculty at the Bauhaus designed a curriculum that continues to influence many contemporary schools of art. After the school was closed by the Nazis in 1933, many of the Bauhaus' faculty, including Josef Albers (1888–1976), a well-known painter, graphic artist, and designer, came to the United States and continued to teach. We can still recognize the Bauhaus influence in our contemporary society with its

streamlined furnishings and buildings.

Abstraction

During World War II, organized movements in art came to a virtual standstill. Art was produced, but attention was really on the war. Many artists did in fact serve in the military, and often art was designed to serve as propaganda in support of the war effort. When the war was over and Europe was recovering, a new center for the international art world emerged. The action had shifted to New York, and it would be decades before the artistic centers in England, France, Italy, and Germany would regain something that approximated the prominence of New York.

During the 1950s, the art scene in New York was dominated by the ideas and writings of critics such as Harold Rosenberg and Clement Greenberg. These critics had a tremendous influence on the development of art styles. Greenberg chose to promote a particular view of art and was an advocate for artists who were further developing abstraction. Beginning in the 1940s, **Abstract Expressionist** artists followed Kandinsky's dictum that art, like music, could be free from the limitations of pictorial subject matter. These artists aimed at the direct presentation of feeling with an emphasis on dramatic colors and sweeping brushstrokes. The Abstract Expressionist movement, which included the artists Willem de Kooning (1904–97), Lee Krasner (1908–84), and Franz Kline (1910–62), reached its pinnacle with the work of Jackson Pollock (1912–56). Pollock eventually abandoned even the use of his paintbrush and instead dripped his paint directly onto the canvas.

Abstract Expressionist works tended to fall into two types: **Action Painting**, which employed dramatic brushstrokes or Pollock's innovative dripping technique, or **Color Field paintings**, which featured broad areas of color and simple, often geometric forms. Mark Rothko and Josef Albers are two well-known color field artists.

In response to the non-objective style of Abstract Expressionism, other artists began to return to naturalism, producing works that, though they may appear in some ways similar to those of the abstractionists, focused on ordinary consumer objects. Jasper Johns (b. 1930) created a series of works that featured common things such as flags, numbers, maps, and letters. Robert Rauschenberg (1925–2008) created sculptures from the cast-off objects he found around



Robert Rauschenberg's Monogram.

him to create what he called “combines.” He hung his own bedclothes on the wall like a canvas and painted them [*Bed* (1955)], and one of his most famous works, *Monogram* (1959), consists of numerous “found” items, including a stuffed goat, a tire, a police barrier, the heel of a shoe, a tennis ball, and paint. This use of everyday objects in artistic works had a decided influence on the next big movement in art—Pop Art.

Pop Art, Minimalism, and Photorealism

1960s **Pop Art**, with its incorporation of images of mass culture, violated the traditional unspoken rules regarding what was appropriate subject matter for art. Andy Warhol (1928–87), the icon of Pop Art, achieved the kind of popularity usually reserved for rock stars. His soup cans, Brillo boxes, and images of movie stars were created with a factory-like silkscreen approach that he used to mock the art world. Roy Lichtenstein (1923–97), another Pop artist, adopted the imagery of comic books and recreated them on such a large scale that the pattern of dots used to print them was made massive. Robert Indiana (1928–2018) used stencils that had been originally used to produce commercial signs to create his own artistic messages.

Minimalism sought to reduce art to its barest essentials, emphasizing simplification of form and often featuring monochromatic palettes. The invention of acrylic paint and the airbrush enabled Minimalist painters to achieve very precise outlines, which resulted in the term “hard-edge painting.” The artist who is best known for these large, entirely non-objective paintings is Frank Stella (1936–2024). The sculptors David Smith (1906–65),

who used stainless steel, and Dan Flavin (1933–96), who used neon tubing, also created large pieces that reflected this abstract minimalist sensibility.

A Pop-inspired group of artists began to produce works that aimed to create a kind of super-realism or what came to be called **Photorealism**. In these works, a hyper-real quality results from the depiction of the subject matter in sharp focus, as in a photograph. This technique offered a clear contrast to the use of *sfumato*, developed in the Renaissance, which had added a haziness to the contour of painted objects. Photorealist artists Chuck Close (1940–2021), with his portraits, and Duane Hanson (1925–1996), with his witty sculptures of ordinary people, hearkened back to the Realism promoted by Gustave Courbet.

Earthworks, Installations, and Performance

One intriguing development in the contemporary art world since the 1970s is that art is no longer limited to gallery or museum spaces, and many important works of art are departures from traditional formats. Some artists have taken their work to a new scale and have developed their artworks in new venues, often out of doors. In this way, artists also challenge conventional ideas about art and its function. An artist known by the single name Christo (1935–2020), working together with his partner Jeanne-Claude (1935–2009), is responsible for creating much interest in these kinds of **Earthworks**. Beginning in Europe, Christo startled the world with the idea that landscape or architecture is something that can be packaged. He wrapped several well-known monuments in fabric, built a twenty-four-mile-long cloth fence in California, surrounded eleven Florida islands with pink plastic, and set up orange fabric gates on pathways throughout Central Park. These works, which require years and even decades of preparation, are as much about the process as they are about the finished product, and it is for this reason that Christo's partner, Jeanne-Claude, played such an important role. While Christo designs the projects, Jeanne-Claude handled many of the logistical details that must be addressed to carry out the work. Their partnership raises important questions about the concept of the individual genius of the artist and how he or she works. Other artists associated with Earthworks are Michael Heizer (b. 1944) and Robert Smithson (1938–73).

The growth of **performance art** is another development

that allows artistic expression to transcend traditional boundaries. Some artists work in conventional media such as photography and painting, as well as in performance art. Performance art is a combination of theater and art in which the artists themselves become the work. Such works exist in time, like music or theater, and are fleeting and transitory in nature. The point is to create a real event in which the audience can participate, but that does not result in a fixed, marketable artwork for a museum or living room wall. Sometimes performance art is socially conscious in its intent. An example is the Guerrilla Girls, a group of New York-based artists who began to work together in 1985. The individual identities of the artists in this all-female group are kept anonymous at all times. The artists even wear gorilla masks when they appear in public to conceal their identities. The artists use guerrilla-warfare tactics, such as pasting up posters and flyers, as well as giving public speeches, to challenge what they see as an art world dominated by white men.

Postmodernist art arose in reaction to the modernist styles, and not surprisingly, it takes many forms across a variety of media. Postmodern works tend to reintroduce traditional elements or to exaggerate modernist techniques by using them to the extreme. Postmodern works often return to earlier styles, periods, and references and often question the mores and beliefs of contemporary society. A leading proponent of Postmodernism in architecture is Philip Johnson (1906–2005), who at one time was known as one of the leading modern architects of the International Style. For decades, architecture had largely been dominated by the Bauhaus idea of form following function, and sleek towers of steel sheathed in glass were the standard for large buildings. But, in 1970, Johnson suggested the radical idea that one of the functions of art was decoration, and with the AT&T Building (1984; now 550 Madison Avenue), he added a finial to the top of the standard office tower.

Today, artists around the world work in an endless variety of media and styles. One can no longer say that any particular city, country, or even continent is the “center” of the art world. The next section of this guide provides a brief overview of “nonwestern” art, but we should note that the categories of Western and nonwestern in the world of contemporary art are becoming obsolete with the emergence of transnational artists in an increasingly mobile and interconnected world.



The terracotta army was buried with the First Emperor of Qin.

BRIEF OVERVIEW OF NONWESTERN ART

The story of art that we have been studying thus far has been a traditional one and has been told over and over again by countless writers since Giorgio Vasari's time. It chronicles a history of Western European ideas that grew out of the concepts put forth by early Greek philosophers. These ideas experienced a revival during the Renaissance and were further refined in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. Atomic power, the increasing pace of technological inventions, and the electronic age further expanded and changed the realm of art in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries.

We should keep in mind that the history we have chronicled thus far, though valuable, has clear limitations. In recent decades, art history, like many other academic disciplines, has been challenged to include artists and works that were previously marginalized. The influence of feminist critics in particular has led to major revisions, and there has also been an increasing inclusion of the histories of art of other cultures. At this point, we will look at the arts

of Asia, Africa, Oceania, the Americas, and the art of Islam throughout the world. The art histories of these cultures are increasingly central to the development of the discipline of art history. Of course, this brief survey covers only a tiny fraction of the rich world of art beyond the boundaries of the Western world. The works considered here might be categorized as "traditional"; contemporary art from Asia and Africa, thoroughly immersed in the global art scene, is beyond the scope of this discussion, for example. Illustrations of the works of art discussed here can be found through basic Internet searches and in standard art historical textbooks.

Asian Art

Chinese Art

Civilization and art have been present in China for thousands of years, and some archaeological finds in China rival those in Mesopotamia and Egypt. Remains of painted wares have been found that date back to the fourth millennium BCE. Perhaps the most famous work of ancient Chinese art is the [Great Wall](#), which was constructed over the course of centuries and

covers thousands of miles. Of course this wall, now considered an enduring work of art and admired both for its engineering and aesthetic appeal, originally had a utilitarian function. This is an example of how meaning and function can change over time. In fact, many of the works we will examine here were created for a specific purpose but are now seen as works of art in a different context.

The dynasties or kingdoms that ruled for long periods of time had an impact on the history of art in China. In many cases, these rulers left elaborate tombs that contained many objects that have become great treasures of art. One of the most amazing works from the early period of Chinese art history is the monument to the first emperor to unite the kingdom—the Emperor of Qin (c. 210 BCE). He had a full army of soldiers and their equipment, including their horses, created life-size in clay and buried as part of his tomb. The technical ability demonstrated in these sculptures and the life-like detail of the soldiers and their horses are quite astonishing. The dynasties succeeding Qin built grand walled cities with huge palaces and tombs. These dynasties are noted for bronze statues and ceremonial vessels. These vessels are covered with intricate designs, and the methods of casting are still not completely understood.

The introduction of Buddhism from India had a profound effect on Chinese arts and culture. During the reign of the Tang Dynasty (618–907 CE), often referred to as China's Golden Age, artists produced some of the greatest works of ceramic sculpture ever made. Traditional Chinese art also placed great value on ink drawings. Many scrolls are meant for contemplation, and this contemplative aspect is a feature often associated with Asian art. Chinese traditions in writing, painting, and sculpture were maintained over the centuries. With the communist revolution that established the People's Republic of China in 1949, art became suffused with political ideas and was often an instrument of propaganda. However, since the late 1970s, Chinese art has gradually become less political.

Indian Art

India is an extremely diverse nation in which more than 1,600 different languages and dialects are currently spoken, and India is home to a variety of religious and cultural traditions. India's artistic traditions are among the oldest in the world, and here we will only

be able to touch on one or two aspects of India's rich artistic heritage. The influence of Buddhist traditions is strong, of course, but what often astonishes people unfamiliar with the art of India is the influence of Greek art on the classical images of Buddha. India has ruins of great early civilizations that rival those of Egypt and Mesoamerica, and the sensuous style of Indian sculptures has had an enduring impact on art over the centuries. Much Indian art reflects the tremendous influence of Hinduism. This religion, with its many gods and goddesses, gave rise to a lovely, lively, and sinuous style. Images of Shiva, who dances gracefully with his multiple arms, are particularly striking.

Japanese Art

The island kingdom of Japan, though tiny in size, has had a great influence on the international art world. Japan was closed to the West for the majority of its history, and this allowed Japanese art to remain relatively consistent and traditional. As with China, the history of Japan is one of succeeding dynasties, with each one leaving its mark in a series of succeeding styles. Also, as with China, Buddhism was imported to Japan and became an important focus in the traditional arts. The strength of Japan's artistic traditions remained even when the country became more open to Western cultures. During the rise of the Impressionist movement in Europe, Japan sent a group of artists to study in France. These artists returned to Japan and introduced the ideas they had encountered in the West, and so, for a short time at the end of the nineteenth century, there was a group of artists in Japan who used linear perspective and the colors and subjects of Impressionism. However, what is noteworthy is that the Japanese soon rejected these ideas and returned to the isometric perspective and flat areas of color favored by Japanese traditions. Although Japanese artists created excellent works in painting, architecture, crafts, and sculpture, it is for their printmaking that Japanese artists are best known in the Western world. Japanese prints had a profound influence on Western art, as French artists began to imitate the prints that they began to collect in the late nineteenth century. The flat colors and overhead viewpoint of these prints were adopted by many French artists during this period.

African and Oceanic Art

Some of the historic traditions of African art have already been discussed in our survey of Western art. As a result of the relationships between Egypt and

the Mediterranean world, the ancient arts of northern Africa are often incorporated into the history of Western art. Usually the art of sub-Saharan Africa is treated separately from that of northern Africa because of the regions' very different histories. A close look at all areas of the continent reveals that impressive art traditions emerged in west, central, east, and southern Africa quite early. Some of the oldest examples are cave paintings in what is now Namibia. In West Africa, the Nok civilization flourished from c. 900 BCE to 200 CE. Located in what is present-day Nigeria, this impressive civilization produced fantastically life-like terracotta sculptures, many of which were probably portraits of political and religious leaders. It is possible that the early Nok civilization had an influence on later cultural groups such as the Yoruba.

Another important historical tradition from Nigeria relates to the Benin Kingdom, which first emerged around 900 CE when the Edo people settled in the area. The kingdom became further consolidated with shifts in leadership in the eleventh century. Much of the remaining art from the Benin Kingdom was produced in association with a rich life at the royal court. Cast bronze portrait heads were intended for ancestral altars, and a variety of objects were made to reinforce the tremendous power of the oba, or Benin king. Countless treasures from the Benin Kingdom were destroyed or confiscated by the British in the 1897 raid on the royal palace. As a result, many more of these objects from historic Benin can be found in museums in Europe and the United States than in Nigeria.

While art objects in a variety of media have been created by many different African cultural groups, our study of them has been limited in many cases by the lack of necessary conditions for preservation. While there are some objects in metal and clay, the use of fiber and wood, which are quite perishable, has resulted in relatively few artifacts being preserved. Unfortunately, much African art was also destroyed by early European traders and colonial settlers on the continent. Westerners often viewed much of what they found in Africa as dangerous and threatening to the colonial pursuit, perceiving artworks as pagan symbols that should be destroyed rather than preserved. Hence, a wealth of cultural artifacts has been lost. The objects that were preserved were often collected as archaeological artifacts and, in most cases, important contextual information was lost. It is only relatively recently that



A Fang mask used for the ngil ceremony, an inquisitorial search for sorcerers. Wood, Gabon, nineteenth century.

art historians have begun to explore the rich variety of artworks and aesthetic systems of African cultures. In many cases, traditional African arts challenge the Western concept of art for art's sake—functional baskets, ceramics, and textiles, for example, are some of the most prized material objects for many African cultural groups.

When we look at African art in a museum, a great deal of contextual information that is crucial to our understanding of the object is lost. Many African

cultural groups, such as the Dan and the Bwa, are well-known for their impressive masks. Masks, though, are not meant to be seen in isolation as they are typically displayed when in art museums. Instead, masks are usually integrated into performance, coupled with a full-body costume and accompanied by music, dance, jokes, festivities, and a great meal shared with friends and family. It is difficult, of course, to recreate all of this in a museum context!

Similar issues occur in relation to the arts of Oceania. Oceania is the collective name for the thousands of islands that constitute Polynesia, Melanesia, and Micronesia. As is the case with Africa, many perishable objects dating back for centuries have been lost to us due to the use of fragile materials in a sometimes hostile climate. In Polynesia, tattooing and other body arts were important ways of expressing social stature. Clearly these art forms are lost with the death of the tattooed person and were preserved only through engravings made by visitors to the islands prior to the invention of photography.

Some of the most important art traditions of the Asmat cultural group of Melanesia relate to warfare. Traditionally the Asmat engaged in head-hunting practices, but these traditions have died out. Enormous carved wooden shields decorated with beautiful black, red, and white abstract patterns were traditionally used for protection in raids among groups throughout the area; today these shields are seen as cultural symbols, but they no longer serve the same function in war.

Carved masks were a central part of Melanesian cultures. In many cases, these masks were used in ceremonies that involved summoning the spirits of ancestors to honor the dead. As is the case with African art traditions, much is lost when these objects are viewed in museum collections.

Rich traditions continue to develop throughout Oceania today, especially as groups such as the Maori of New Zealand seek cultural renewal by reviving old traditions in a new context. Many people from traditional cultural groups that have been threatened by colonization recognize that art offers vibrant possibilities for expressing and reinforcing cultural identity.

Islamic Art

Today, Islam is a major religion that is not limited to any one region of the world. However, historically

Islam emerged in the Arabian Peninsula following the teachings of the prophet Muhammad (c. 570–632). The revelations of Muhammad are recorded in Islam's holy book, the Koran. This text plays a central role in the practice of Islam, and some of the most valued art objects are beautifully produced copies of the Koran or containers that hold the sacred text. Following the Koran's scriptures, Islamic art is largely non-figurative. Abstract or calligraphic decoration can be found on most Islamic art objects, including sacred architecture, which has a long history in the Islamic tradition. The [Dome of the Rock](#) in Jerusalem (687–692) is one of the oldest examples of Islamic architecture. Its position in Jerusalem marks the presence of Islam in a city that is also sacred to Jews and Christians. The act of prayer is central to the practice of Islam, and the mosque, with its *qibla* wall facing toward Mecca, emerged as a site for communal prayer. Mosque architecture can be found in a variety of forms throughout the world today.

The Americas

For many years art historians classified much of the art of North and South America as products of simple craftsmanship. These artifacts were not truly considered works of art and therefore were kept solely in archeological and anthropological museums. However, renewed interest and new studies of these works have added considerably to our understanding and appreciation of the art of the first Americans, and objects from these cultures are becoming more and more common in the collections of art museums. Great civilizations grew and flourished in the Americas, including the Olmec, Toltec, Maya, Inca, and Aztec. Great pyramids, rivaling those of Egypt, rose as the central features of large cities, of which the Pyramid of the Sun in Mexico is one of the best known. The decorative carvings on the Mayan ruins continue to amaze us, and in addition to architectural marvels, statues in clay and stone, as well as fine textiles and jewelry, remain as reminders of the glories of these civilizations.

While there is evidence of early people in many areas of present-day Canada and the United States dating back nearly 12,000 years, several of the conditions that we identified earlier as being necessary for preservation were not present. As a result, the majority of artifacts from these cultures are only from the last two thousand years. During the later centuries of the prehistoric period, the Native Americans of the Southwest



An image of the Dome of the Rock from Phillip Baldensperger's "The Immovable East: Studies of the People and Customs of Palestine," published in 1913.

demonstrated remarkable architectural skills in the building of **pueblo** complexes. These dwellings often consisted of well over a hundred rooms laid out in multiple stories.

ELEMENTS OF ART

Formal Qualities of Art

While it is crucial to examine any given work of art in its historical context in order to arrive at an understanding of its meaning, it is also important to focus intently on the formal qualities or the basic visual components of a work of art. These include **line**, **shape**, **form**, **space**, **color**, and **texture**, among other things. Formal analysis requires careful observation and description, often using the special vocabulary of art.

Line

Line is the most basic of art elements. Any kind of mark-making tool—a finger, pencil, paint, etc.—can be used to create a line on a surface. The strict definition of a line is the path of a point moving through space.

But beyond this technical definition, lines have a variety of characteristics such as length, width, and direction. Lines may appear hard or soft, bold or indistinct, uniform or varying in width. Sometimes lines are not solid but consist of a series of interrupted dots or lines that the eye connects to create an implied line. Think of prints in the sand or snow that imply the path of a person or animal. Sometimes we see the edges of objects as lines. The corners of rooms, the edges of doors, and the line where two colors meet all provide examples of how edges may be seen as lines.

Artists use lines to express ideas or feelings visually. Horizontal and vertical lines create a stable and static feeling. Vertical lines cause the eye to move upward. Medieval churches were created with very high arched ceilings, designed to raise the eyes of the people upward toward heaven to promote a feeling of spiritual awe. Horizontal lines, such as the line of the horizon, suggest a feeling of peace and tranquility while curving and jagged lines create a sense of activity.

Though the use of lines is perhaps most essential and noticeable in drawing and some kinds of printmaking, all artists use line in their artwork in some way.

Shape and Form

Shape and form are two elements of art that are closely related to one another. Shape is what defines the two-dimensional area of an object, whereas forms are objects that are three-dimensional, having length, width, and depth. For example, a square is a shape, but a cube is a form. A triangle is a shape; a pyramid or a cone is a form. When one draws an apple that in nature is a form, one draws a shape that represents the apple. If one creates an apple out of clay, that clay apple is a form. In a two-dimensional artwork, an artist may try to create the illusion of form through the use of shading, foreshortening, perspective, and other techniques.

Shapes and forms may be geometric, such as circles/spheres and squares/cubes. These geometric shapes and forms can be defined mathematically and are precise and regular. Some shapes and forms are described as being “organic” since living things tend to be freeform and irregular in shape or form. A geometric shape or form can convey a sense of order and stability, while organic shapes and forms tend to express movement and rhythm.

Space is an element of art related to the organization of objects and the areas around them. The objects, shapes, or forms in an artwork occupy what is termed **positive space**. Sometimes these objects, shapes, or forms may be called the figure. The area around these objects, shapes, or forms represents negative space. In three-dimensional forms, **negative space** may surround the forms or may be created as a result of open spaces within the forms. Three-dimensional artworks include, among other forms, architecture, ceramic objects, and sculpture. The two primary types of sculpture are freestanding, or fully in the round, and relief, meaning that the sculpture projects from a surface or background of which it is a part. Such sculptures may be in high relief—projecting boldly from the surface—or bas (low) relief—projecting only slightly from the surface of the sculpture.

Perspective

The creation of perspective or the illusion of depth is another important use of space in two-dimensional artworks. There are many effective techniques

that artists can use to create an illusion of three-dimensionality. They may use shading and highlighting on the contours—the visible borders—of objects to replicate the manner in which light shining on objects lends those objects a sense of volume and space. An artist can also create a sense of depth in an artwork by placing objects or figures lower on the picture plane to make them appear closer to the viewer. Or, one can do the reverse and place objects and figures higher on the plane to make them appear farther away from the viewer. Artists can also manipulate the size of objects to create a sense of perspective—larger objects will appear closer to the viewer than smaller objects. An artist can also have closer objects overlap objects that are farther away to indicate depth and distance. Moreover, the artist can make objects appear closer to the viewer by giving them greater detail than objects that are farther away—replicating the manner in which our eyes are able to perceive more detail in objects that are nearer to us.

Aerial perspective, also called atmospheric perspective, is a technique that takes into account the ways that fog, smoke, and airborne particles change the appearance of things when they are viewed from a distance. When an artist uses this technique, objects that are farther away will appear lighter and more neutral in color and will lack contrast of color or value.

Frequently, when we think of perspective, we think of the mathematical techniques that were developed during the Renaissance that can be used to create the illusion of space. Such techniques create what is called linear perspective because this perspective is founded on the visual phenomenon that as lines recede into the distance, they appear to converge and eventually vanish at a point on the horizon. We may, for example, notice this effect when viewing highways, railroads, or fence posts as they stretch into the distance. In employing linear perspective, the artist establishes one or more vanishing points on the real or imagined horizon of the artwork. Then, lines are carefully drawn to ensure a precise and extremely realistic depiction of interior and exterior scenes. Thus, in drawing a black and white checkerboard floor (a frequent feature in Renaissance interior paintings), the horizontal lines of the tiles are drawn as parallel, but the vertical lines—which we know are also parallel in reality—appear to converge or come together in a systematic way as they recede toward the back wall of the interior.



Pietro Perugino's use of perspective in this fresco at the Sistine Chapel (1481–82) helped bring the Renaissance to Rome.

Color

Color surrounds us wherever we go and is a compelling element in art. **Hue** is simply the name of the color. There are three primary colors—red, blue, and yellow—from which all other colors are produced. Secondary colors are formed from the mixture of two primary colors: red and yellow make orange; yellow and blue make green; blue and red make violet. There are six tertiary colors, made by combining a primary and an adjacent secondary color: red and violet make red-violet; violet and blue make violet-blue; blue and green make blue-green; green and yellow make yellow-green; yellow and orange make yellow-orange; orange and red make red-orange. The organization of these hues into a visual scheme, known as the **color wheel**, dates from the eighteenth century, though the underlying concepts were developed by Sir Isaac Newton in the seventeenth century. The color wheel is a useful tool for predicting the results of mixing hues.

Two important variables affecting color are the amount of light that is reflected and the purity of the color. The term “**value**” is often used when discussing the lightness or darkness of a color or of gray. Values in an artwork may be primarily dark or primarily light or may be

contrasting from dark to light. The artist’s use of value contributes to the expressive quality of the artwork. In mixing colors, artists create a lighter hue by adding white to the color. Adding white to red, for example, makes a lighter red or pink. Artists create darker hues by adding black to the color. Adding black to red, for example, makes a dark red. A few words about black and white are necessary at this point. Black and white are not hues; they are called **neutrals**. When mixing black and white, artists can create a continuum of grays.

Intensity refers to the brightness or purity of a color. The unmixed primary colors, being pure in color, are generally considered to be the most intense colors. If pure colors are mixed, they become less intense. Adding black or gray to a color will reduce its intensity. Adding a color to its complement lowers the intensity of the color, making it more dull or neutral in tone. Equal parts of two complements, such as red and green, will produce a dull, muddy brown tone.

Artists often use specific color schemes to produce particular visual or emotional effects. In the nineteenth century, scientists discovered the relativity of color; they determined that a given shade of red will look brighter or darker, more or less intense, depending

on what other (similar or contrasting) colors are placed next to it. Thus, colors do not have a fixed or immutable character or value.

In discussing art and color, we often speak of warm colors and cool colors. These color associations are culturally constructed and are not absolute. In the context of Western art, warm colors include red, orange, and yellow and are referred to as such because we associate them with the warmth of the sun, the heat of a roaring fire, or the dry grass of a late summer day. Cool colors—green, blue, and violet—remind us of cool forests, mountain lakes, and snow. Artists often use warm and cool colors to create space in artworks. Warm colors seem to advance toward the viewer while cool colors appear to recede. By employing contrasts of warm and cool colors, artists can create a sense of movement as the viewer’s eyes move over the surface of the artwork.

Color may be local, arbitrary, or optical. **Local color** refers to the “true” color of an object or area as seen in normal daylight, irrespective of the effects of distance or reflections from other objects. For instance, in a work using local color, a grassy field would be green despite the fact that it may, in reality, appear bluish from a distance. **Optical color** refers to the effect that special lighting has on the color of objects. Consider how colors change in moonlight, at daybreak, in candlelight, or in artificial lighting. Artists who use **arbitrary color** choose colors for their emotional or aesthetic impact. In the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, artists have come to use arbitrary color schemes more and more often.

Texture

Texture refers to how things feel or how we think they would feel if touched. From a young age, we explore the surfaces of things and store away these tactile experiences in our memory. When we see new objects or artworks, we call upon our previous experiences to determine the quality of the surface texture. In the context of art, we make reference to two kinds of texture: actual and visual. Some artists use actual textures in their art. For example, a ceramic artist may create an actual texture on the surface of a pot or plate. In collages, assemblages, or masks, artists may use yarn, rope, shiny paper, shells, and other natural or manufactured materials to create actual textural effects. Artists who work in three-dimensional media exploit the

textural qualities of their chosen material whether it is stone, wood, metal, or some other substance.

Artists who work in two-dimensional media create visual texture—an illusion of a textured surface—in their artwork. For example, an artist may wish to simulate the actual texture of a straw hat, a glass vase, or an orange. Textures may be created by using patterns of lines or shapes that suggest texture. An artist can use the contrast of light and dark on a surface to create a texture that appears rough. Conversely, the absence of such a contrast will evoke a smooth texture. Shiny surfaces appear to reflect light while matte surfaces appear soft and dull. In addition to using the aforementioned techniques to create visual texture, painters can create actual texture with their brushstrokes.

Composition

Composition refers to the artist’s organization of the elements of art, whether in two- or three-dimensional works. When speaking of a painting, the composition refers to the arrangement of these elements on the picture plane. In the case of architecture, composition is a word used to describe the organization of these elements in space.

Rhythm is the principle that we associate with movement or pattern. Artists create a sense of movement or rhythm in their artwork through the repetition of elements such as line, shape, color, and texture. The rhythm of a composition can cause the viewer’s eye to move rhythmically across and around the composition. Some rhythms flow smoothly, while others are more jarring. The artist directs the movement of our eye through the use of repeated elements.

Motif and **pattern** are two aspects of repetition. A motif is a single element of a pattern. For example, in a quilt design, one or more motifs are repeated to create an overall pattern. A pattern involves the repetition of certain elements—color or line—or motifs within a work of art. Many patterns feature regular repetition. Shapes or motifs may be repeated in a number of ways to create regular patterns. Some kind of grid system will underlie a regular pattern. Checkerboards offer an example of a regular pattern.

Balance refers to the equal distribution of visual weight in a work of art. There are a number of techniques that artists use to create balance. The

easiest to comprehend is symmetrical balance—a balance achieved when elements of the composition are repeated exactly on both sides of the central axis. If you fold a paper in half vertically and one side of the centerfold is a mirror image of the other side of the centerfold, then you have an example of symmetrical balance. Many formal styles of architecture make use of symmetry with columns, wings, and windows arrayed equally on either side of the central entrance. Artworks in which the central axis is horizontal and equal visual weight is placed above and below that axis also exhibit symmetrical balance. To avoid the rigidity and monotony that may accompany a symmetrical composition, many artists employ **approximate symmetry**. In this kind of balance, shapes or objects are slightly varied on either side of the central axis. The artist may also include variations in the color, detail, or position of the shapes to achieve this effect.

Asymmetrical balance is a visual balance that is achieved through the organization of unlike objects. Even though asymmetrical balance may appear to be more informal than symmetrical balance, it is actually a more complex compositional task. There are several ways that asymmetrical balance can be achieved. The first is by the position of objects. Think of two people of unequal weight on a seesaw. To maintain a balance, the lighter person must sit far out on the end of the seesaw while the heavier person must sit close to the fulcrum. Similarly, an artist may create balance by placing the heavier, more solid object close to the center of the artwork while placing smaller objects farther away from the center.

Contrast of color, value, shape, size, line, or texture creates interest to the eye. An element that contrasts with the rest of a composition will create a **focal point** where the eye tends to rest. This focal point appears more dominant, more important than other parts of the composition. In this way, the artist may guide the viewer to an understanding of meaning.

Proportion refers to the size relationships among the parts of a composition. Our sense of proportion is based upon our human scale. **Scale** refers to the dimensional relation of the parts of a work to the work in its entirety, and can refer to the overall size of an artwork. Size attracts our interest. The vast scale of the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel creates a sense of awe. The detail of a tiny painting or of illuminations in medieval manuscripts intrigues us. Artists consider the

purpose and place of their art when determining the appropriate scale for the work.

Scale also refers to the relative size of elements within the artwork. In a naturalistic work, we expect that the relative sizes of the objects depicted will appear as they actually are in life. In some cases, artists intentionally make one person or object in their composition larger to draw our attention to that person or object.

When representing the human face and figure realistically, artists strive to use accurate proportions. The standards for the relationship of the various parts of the human face and body were established nearly 2,500 years ago during the Classical Period of Greek sculpture. The Greeks believed that the human figure was the measure of all things. As a consequence, all structures were designed in proportions relative to human proportions, and specific rules were established. For example, the ideal human figure was determined to be seven and one-half heads high. The features of the human face could be correctly placed according to these rules: the corners of the eyes fall on a line halfway between the chin and the top of the head, the bottom of the nose falls halfway between the chin and the corners of the eyes, and the bottom of the lips falls halfway between the chin and the bottom of the nose. However, many artists at different times have altered these proportions to reflect changing ideals of beauty. At other times, artists have exaggerated or distorted proportions for an expressive effect.

To truly understand how artists manipulate the elements of art and the principles of composition, it is necessary to examine a great many artworks and to analyze how artists create meaning in their artwork through skillful choices and the application of these artistic concepts. Students should keep in mind that many of the elements discussed in the principles of composition section of this guide are more often found in traditional works than in modern artworks. The rejection of notions such as unity and balance is often the very essence of much modern art.

PROCESSES AND TECHNIQUES

Two-dimensional art processes and techniques are those that are created on a flat plane. They have height and width, but not significant depth. These include drawing, printmaking, painting, photography, and some mixed media. Artworks that have depth as well

as height and width and that exist in space are three dimensional. This category includes sculpture, other works in mixed media, and environmental art.

Drawing

Drawing is arguably the most basic of art processes. Most of us have been drawing since we could hold some tool and make marks on a surface. The most common drawing media are pencil, pen and ink, charcoal, crayon, and felt-tip pens. Artists can choose from a variety of surfaces upon which to draw. Early artists used walls of rock, and though some artists today continue to draw on walls, most use some kind of paper—from the white paper of common sketchbooks to a wide variety of manufactured and handmade papers. Papers may be smooth or rough, white or in a wide range of colors. Drawing tools may be black, colored, or white.

Drawing is primarily based on the use of line. Lines created by drawing media can vary dramatically in quality. Hard pencils will make thin, light lines while soft pencils will make thicker lines that may vary considerably in value from lighter to very dark. Charcoal is so soft that the color of the paper used will show through in places where the strokes are applied lightly. Each drawing tool or medium has its own unique qualities, and experimenting with a variety of drawing media is a good way to gain an understanding of their similarities and differences.

With drawing pencils or charcoals, a change in pressure will cause a change in value. More pressure creates darker values; lighter pressure creates lighter values.

Shading can also be used to change values. Artists use the techniques of **hatching** and **crosshatching** to shade objects and create an illusion of three-dimensionality. Hatching consists of placing lines closely side by side. Crosshatching is a process in which lines are crisscrossed to create shading. Many drawing media can be blended to change their value and enhance shading. Another technique for shading is **stippling**. With this technique, the artist creates different values by making a pattern of dots. The distance between the dots determines how dark the shading will be—the more densely clustered the dots, the darker the shading.

When an artist uses ink as a drawing medium, the ink can be thinned to create a wash of lighter value in which the paper shows through to lighten the effect. Undiluted ink is opaque; it is not transparent, and it

completely covers the underlying paper. But water can be added to make the ink translucent.

Color may be introduced into a drawing with the use of pastels or colored pencils. The same techniques used with black media are used with colored media. The artist using color must consider the effects of color and line in an artwork. Colored pastels became popular in the 1700s. These soft sticks of color can be readily blended to create delicate tints and shades, and they are particularly popular for portraiture. The major drawback of pastels is that they are very fragile, and pastel drawings must be cared for quite gently. Often, the surface of a pastel drawing is sprayed with a fixative to reduce the risk of smearing. Colored pencils are more durable than pastels, but like pastels, they may be layered to create blended colors.

Printmaking

Printmaking refers to a group of mechanically aided two-dimensional processes that permit the production of multiple original artworks. The principal printmaking processes include relief prints, intaglio prints, lithographs, and **screen prints**. All of these processes use some sort of printing plate (a “matrix”) on which an image is created. Ink is applied to the plate, and the image is transferred to paper or another material.

In **relief printmaking**, the artist cuts away parts from the surface of the plate. The matrix may be made of wood, linoleum, or a synthetic material, and a number of tools, including woodcarving or linoleum knives and gouges, can be used for cutting its surface. Once the plate has been cut, the remaining parts will stand out in relief. The relief sections may range from thin lines to broad fields, and it is these areas, when they are inked, that will produce the image. Wherever part of the plate is removed, the original color of the paper being printed upon remains. Ink is rolled over the surface of the plate with a brayer, and paper is placed over the inked plate. The plate and paper are then put into a press or rubbed with a burnisher to force the ink onto the paper.

Intaglio printmaking works in the opposite manner from relief printmaking. In the intaglio process, lines are incised on the wood or soft metal plate. Line is an essential element in the intaglio process. Carving tools are used to cut lines into the surface of the plate in a process called **engraving**. Another intaglio process is **etching**. In this process, the design is incised through a layer of wax or varnish applied to the surface of a metal



This engraving, titled Veronica, by Albrecht Dürer features hatching (e.g., background) and cross-hatching in many darker areas.

plate. After the incising, the plate is immersed in acid, which etches, or eats away, the exposed metal. Leaving the plate in the acid for a shorter time will make faint lines in the plate, while leaving the plate in for a longer time will make deeper grooves. After the plate is etched, the remaining wax or varnish is removed, and ink is forced into the etched areas of the warmed plate. Then, the ink on the surface of the plate is wiped off, and finally, paper is placed on the plate, and it is passed through a heavy press. The paper is forced into the etched, inked areas, and the ink transfers to the paper. In an etching, the printing process causes the printed areas to actually rise above the surface of the paper, giving a degree of dimension to the print.

Lithography is a process in which the image is drawn with a waxy pencil or crayon directly on a plate, which can be made of stone, zinc, or aluminum. The greasy image is hardened, and the plate is saturated with water. Then, ink is applied. The ink adheres only to

the greasy image since oil resists water. The image is picked up on the paper when the plate is moved through a press. Lithography can be a complex and demanding process, but in contrast to woodcut and engraving, it does not require special professional training; anyone who can draw can make a lithograph.

Screen prints are familiar to most of us since this is the process used to print most T-shirts. In the silk-screening process, a photograph or other image is transferred or adhered to a silk or synthetic fabric that has been stretched onto a frame. The image serves as a sort of stencil, blocking out areas of the permeable fabric. When ink is forced through the fabric using a squeegee, at those areas not blocked by the stenciling, the image is transferred to the paper or fabric beneath.

Because multiple originals can be made through printmaking processes, the cost of an individual print is considerably less than that of a painting.

Printmaking techniques have been used in the print industry for illustrating newspapers and books since the development of the printing press in the fifteenth century.

Painting

Painting encompasses a wide variety of media and techniques. Paint is usually composed of three different materials: **pigments**, **binders**, and **solvents**. Pigments are finely ground materials that may be natural or synthetic. Natural pigments include clays, gemstones, and minerals, as well as plant and insect materials that make color when powdered. These powdered pigments are mixed with a binder that holds the grains of pigment together and allows the paint to adhere to a surface. Egg yolks, linseed oil, and wax can all be used as binders.

A solvent such as water or oil can be added to change the consistency of the paint or alter its drying time. As with drawing, painters can apply the media to a variety of surfaces such as boards, paper, canvas, and plaster walls. Paint can be applied to a surface with many different tools. We usually think of paintbrushes as the tools used to apply paint, but fingers, sticks, palette knives, and anything else that an artist imagines will make the desired kind of applicator may be used.

One specialized technique of painting that has a long history is the **fresco**. The fresco technique is usually used to paint on walls or ceilings. In creating a fresco, the artist mixes pure powdered pigments with water and applies them to a wet plaster ground. The paint is permanently bound in the plaster, so the artist must plan carefully because he or she will not be able to make changes after the fact. This kind of fresco is termed *buon fresco* (“true” fresco). If an artist uses the technique called *fresco secco*, he or she will apply paints to dry rather than wet plaster. Frescoes have been found in the ruins of Pompeii and in many medieval and Renaissance churches. Diego Rivera, the famous Mexican muralist of the early twentieth century, used this technique for his murals in Mexico and the United States.

When we think of painting, oil painting usually comes to mind first. Oil paints were not widely used until the 1500s, and prior to that time, tempera was the most commonly used paint. Tempera is a water-based paint. Many of us remember using tempera paint in elementary school. Traditional tempera paint, which uses egg as a binder, has been used by fine artists

throughout history. **Tempera** painting requires great skill, and there are limitations to this medium. Tempera colors dry quickly, and so they cannot be blended once they are applied to a surface. Tempera also has a narrow tonal range—colors are either light or dark—and it cannot achieve the close imitation of natural effects that oil paints can. Nonetheless, the positive qualities of tempera are evidenced by the many ancient tempera paintings that still retain their clear and brilliant colors.

Oil paints are much more versatile than tempera paints. Oil paints can be easily mixed, and they may be thinned to build up layers of delicate **glazes**—thin transparent or semi-transparent layers that are applied over another color to alter it slightly. The translucency of glazes permits, for instance, a crimson layer underneath to shine through a yellow layer on top and can thus create brilliant, luminous effects that are impossible to achieve with tempera. Oils can be applied thickly or in heavy lumps to make an **impasto** surface. Since oils dry slowly, it is possible for an artist to work on an oil painting over a long period of time—days or even weeks.

In ancient Egypt, grave markers were painted with wax-based paints called **encaustic**. With encaustic, colored molten wax is fused with the surface via the application of hot irons. The fact that Egyptian markers have survived through the ages indicates the durability of the encaustic medium. Some painters today have returned to this ancient, traditional process.

Gouache is a water-based opaque paint that is similar to school-quality tempera, but of higher quality. Gouache has more body and dries more slowly than watercolor. It is a good medium for creating bright colors and meticulous details and is often used for design and fine artwork.

The most common water-based paint is **watercolor**. Watercolors are transparent, a quality that dictates the manner in which they are used. The white of the paper upon which the artist paints is a major factor in watercolor. White paint is rarely used in watercolors. Instead, to make tints, the artist adds more water to the paint. The lightest colors are applied first, and then the darker colors, working from background to foreground, from broad areas to areas of detail. Watercolor is not forgiving of mistakes, so watercolor artists must plan carefully and practice diligently.

A recent development in paint is **acrylic paint**. Made from synthetic materials, plastics, and polymers, acrylics were developed after World War II. Acrylics are very versatile. They do not require the slow, careful building up of successive layers with long drying periods in between as do oils. Acrylics are, however, unable to achieve some of the subtleties of which oil paints are capable. For artists who have developed allergies to oil paint and turpentine, acrylics offer a valuable alternative.

Photography

Photography was developed during the mid-nineteenth century, and it soon became a very popular way to document likenesses of people and scenes. The development of photography had a decided impact on other genres of art. As the use of photography grew, painters at first felt pressured to compete with the camera by achieving a higher degree of realism. Ultimately, however, artists felt less of a need to confine themselves to naturalistic styles of painting and were encouraged to explore various forms of art that were entirely beyond the reach of photography. Although not originally considered an art form, photography has gradually assumed a legitimacy within the art world that has only grown in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries. The medium of photography is in constant flux as new technology becomes available. In addition to still photography, film and video art are also used as art forms.

Sculpture

Sculpture is created in four basic ways: carving, modeling, casting, and construction. We usually think of sculpture as being **freestanding**, like the [Venus de Milo](#) or Michelangelo's [Pieta](#), but some sculptures are attached to surfaces such as doors, sarcophagi, altars, or church walls. Such **reliefs** may be carved into the stone or wood of the structure itself, or they may be cast of metal and fixed to the surface of the structure. High-relief sculpture projects significantly from the carrier surface, while low-relief sculpture projects only slightly. Reliefs can only be seen from a limited range, whereas a freestanding sculpture can be seen from every angle.

Carving is a subtractive process in which some of the original material is removed. For example, a stone or wood sculpture can be made by chiseling and gouging away with chisels, hammers, and files to bring the artist's imagined form into physical existence. The

scale of carved sculptures can range considerably, from miniature figures that rest on the tip of a finger to monumental forms carved of living rock.

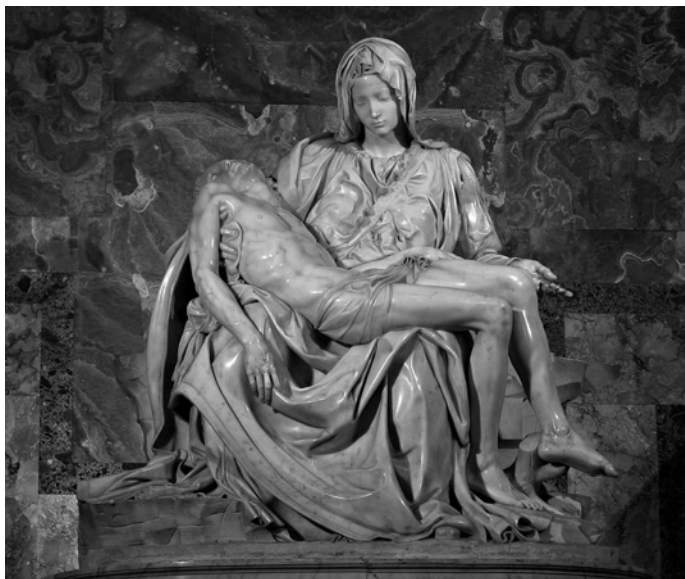
Modeling is an additive process. A soft, workable material like clay, wax, plaster, or papier-mâché is formed by hand. Amounts of these materials can be added to the surface, and the surface can be shaped and decorated by hand or with simple tools.

Sometimes an unfired clay or wax sculpture can become the basis for a **cast form**. In this process, the original form is encased in plaster. When the plaster hardens, it is removed from the original form and retained for use as a mold. The mold can then be filled and thus used to create one or more casts of the original object. Sculptures may be cast in plaster, metal, and more recently, synthetic materials like plastic or polyester resins.

Some sculpture is constructed using a variety of methods. Metal sculpture can be welded from sheet metal or bent from wire. Some artists use paper, board, or wood that is cut and glued, nailed, or joined together by some other means and then possibly painted. Sometimes found objects are combined to create a new sculpture.

Some sculptures can move or can have moving parts. For example, Alexander Calder (1898–1976) created mobiles with forms suspended by wire which can be moved by wind or air currents. Other artists have used a wide variety of motors, pulleys, ropes, pumps, or other mechanical means to introduce movement to their sculptures.

Environmental art, which includes subcategories such as **Earthworks** and **Land art**, is a newer category of art form that first emerged in the 1960s, and many works that fit in this category could be classified as sculpture. Environmental art is often large in scale, is sometimes constructed on-site, and is usually not permanent. Environmental art occupies space that may be outside in the natural world or inside a gallery or museum. In either case, the artwork redefines the space in which it is installed. Sometimes, performance may be coupled with the actual installation, and often the viewer is, to some degree, drawn into and involved with the artwork. Often, an essential part of the work of environmental artists is the process of collaborating with the community and governmental agencies to gain



Michelangelo's Pieta is a freestanding sculpture.

approval for their proposed works. Environmental art is often designed to be impermanent or to change over time. Photographs provide us with a more long-lasting documentation of these projects that are often designed to be fleeting in nature.

Mixed Media

Mixed media is the name given to a category of artworks in which the artist uses several art media, sometimes in conjunction with found materials such as fabric, rope, broken dishes, newspaper, or children's toys. Mixed media works can be either two- or three-dimensional. **Collage** is a kind of mixed media in which artists combine various materials such as photographs, unusual papers, theater tickets, and virtually any other materials that can be adhered to a surface. Artists will select materials for their texture, color, or other aesthetic properties or for their symbolic meaning. Pablo Picasso and Georges Braque are credited with introducing this medium to the high-art sphere around 1912.

The artist Robert Rauschenberg (1925–2008) is well known for his mixed media pieces that combine silkscreen images with paint. Some artists create assemblages using all found objects, both two- and three-dimensional, in their compositions. Joseph Cornell (1903–72) was a twentieth-century artist who filled open boxes with a variety of objects that visually created symbolic and metaphoric statements.

Among traditional and nonwestern cultural groups, masks, ceremonial costumes, and other objects often employ mixed media. Masks may be carved of wood

and embellished with grasses, beads, and paint.

Performance

Performance art is art in which the artist engages in some kind of performance, sometimes involving the viewers. Like environmental art, performance art lacks the permanence of more traditional genres of art. Videos or photographs of the performance may be the only remaining documentation of the event. In our world of canned, sterile, and constantly repeated media spectacles, performance art offers a means for recovering unique, unrepeatable human experiences. Since performances cannot be sold as objects, this art form has also been viewed by many as an escape from the increasing commercialization of art. True to the inventiveness of the artistic spirit, artists continue to explore new ideas, new materials, and new processes to express their unique perspectives and ideas. Such creative works continually challenge us to reconsider our own conceptions and definitions of the term “art.”

Craft and Folk Art

Craft, folk art, and popular art are all debated terms applied to a variety of art forms across cultures. In many cases, these terms are used to discuss art forms that are largely utilitarian. Through time and across cultures, people have often sought to make the objects they use more distinctive or beautiful. Consequently, pottery, jewelry, fibers, and glass and wooden objects have come to be recognized as art forms even though they may have a utilitarian purpose. A discussion of craft or folk art raises many questions about the nature of art and the aesthetic pursuit.

Pottery is a medium based upon the use of natural materials. Clay, dug from the ground, is the essential material. Many types of pots can be built using hands and simple tools. A basic pot can be formed from a ball of clay by punching the thumb into the center of the ball and pinching the clay between the thumb and fingers. Clay can also be rolled out into coils with the palm of the hand, and these coils can then be stacked up to form a clay vessel. Depending on the diameter of the coils, pots built in this way can be of enormous size or made on a tiny, dainty scale. Slab-built pots are made by rolling out clay and cutting carefully measured pieces, which are then assembled by applying liquid clay, called **slip**, to the edges that are to be joined.

The potter's wheel was used in many ancient cultures and continues to be used by artists today. Using the

potter's wheel, the potter forms the basic shapes of the pot by manipulating the ball of clay as it turns on the wheel. When a potter uses a potter's wheel to create pots, these pots are described as being "thrown." Throwing allows for particularly thin-walled pots in a wide variety of shapes. Many potters combine hand-built and thrown forms to create beautiful objects that may or may not be functional.

Once the clay form has air-dried, the kiln, a specialized oven, is loaded and fired. In the kiln, all remaining moisture is driven out of the clay, and a chemical change takes place. The pots harden permanently. Then, glazes made of clay and minerals that provide color may be applied to the surface of the pots, and the pots are fired once again. The glazes melt, forming a glassy, waterproof surface on the pots that is both decorative and useful. The surface of a ceramic piece can also be decorated with applied clay designs or with decorations incised or carved into the surface of the piece.

Fiber arts include both woven and nonwoven materials. Weaving has a long history in the production of materials for clothing and other household needs. Some weaving techniques use a loom while others rely on simple braiding, knitting, or crocheting. Quilting is another important craft form that is practiced by popular as well as fine artists.

Archaeological evidence indicates that glass was first made in the Middle East in the third millennium BCE. Glass is most often made of silica, which is derived from sand, flint, or quartz, combined with other raw materials. The introduction of additional minerals adds color. The development of glassblowing enabled the formation of glass vessels such as vases, drinking glasses, and perfume bottles. Stained glass became a dominant art form in the medieval period and was used to create the dramatic windows of cathedrals. By the end of the nineteenth century, stained glass had also become popular for lampshades and windows in residential homes.

Wood has been used to make functional objects such as furniture, boxes, boats, and homes. Northwest Coast Indians carve boxes and house boards with traditional designs. People all over the world have made wooden boats in varying practical and aesthetic forms. Today, artists make all kinds of objects from wood. Such objects may be functional, but first and foremost, they aim to be aesthetically pleasing. Functional objects

like tables and chairs assume the status of art when the design is unique, the craftsmanship superb, and the visual effect beautiful. Sometimes these objects may no longer be functional, but become art for art's sake.

Architecture

Architecture is the art and science of designing and constructing buildings. People in every culture and geographic area have designed shelters that meet their needs for protection. As people have imagined structures for a variety of communal and personal uses, they have developed various methods of construction to realize their ideas. Specialists in designing structures have become known as architects.

In early times, materials that could be found locally were used for building. Sticks, mud, grass, animal skins, ice, and wood were used in different climatic areas. Later, brick and stone were also used. An important architectural development was the use of the **post-and-lintel construction** technique in which a long stone or wooden beam is placed horizontally across upright posts. The famous Greek [Parthenon](#) is an example of post-and-lintel construction. This method is still commonly used today, with steel and wood being the favored materials.

Other key developments in architecture include the arch, the vault, and the dome. Each of these is a variation of the same concept that allowed for greater height and more interior open space inside a building. The Romans were great engineers, and the [Colosseum](#) in Rome provides a fine example of vaulted construction. The Romans developed concrete as a building material, which they used in building aqueducts, great baths, and other public works projects.

In the medieval period, a skeletal building style developed that alternated between strong buttresses and thin walls with stained-glass windows, which admitted more light and color into the building. Many medieval cathedrals provide classic examples of this method. The addition of flying buttresses—external arches that counterbalanced the outward thrust of the high, vaulted ceilings—allowed for even more height and window openings.

During the Industrial Revolution, many new materials and processes for building were developed. In 1851 the [Crystal Palace](#), so named because it consisted mainly of glass walls that were held in place by a framework of



Flying buttresses at Bath Abbey, Bath, England.

slim, iron rods, was built for the world's fair in London. The [Eiffel Tower](#) in Paris, an amazing and beautiful monument, is primarily a framework of wrought iron.

[Antoni Gaudi](#) (1852–1926) created ingenious buildings of cut stone in Spain in the late 1800s and early 1900s. Without any flat surfaces or straight lines, Gaudi's buildings are very organic in appearance. While we usually think of buildings as being more modular, having a regular and geometric shape, many architects have challenged this notion and have searched for aesthetically interesting designs and new materials to move beyond the idea of a building as merely being a box-shaped construction.

Steel and concrete have become the favored materials for large public, commercial, and multi-family housing while wood and brick continue to be commonly used for residential homes. While many buildings are designed by builders using more standardized plans, leading architects continue to explore new and exciting designs and materials.

SECTION I SUMMARY

- ◆ Art history is an academic discipline that seeks to reconstruct the social, cultural, and economic contexts in which an artwork was created. The basic goal of this work is to arrive at an understanding of art and its meaning in its original historical context. Art historians rely on a variety of documents and sources in order to conduct formal and contextual analyses.
- ◆ The history of Western art is often studied chronologically. This study begins with early cave paintings in southeastern France and takes us to contemporary art all over the world.
- ◆ Early civilizations arose in Mesopotamia. Other ancient Western cultures important for their art traditions include Egypt and Nubia, and the civilizations of the Aegean Islands, Greece, and Rome. The artworks that have survived from ancient civilizations are those made of durable materials. Often these

artworks were preserved in places that were relatively inaccessible.

- ◆ Tremendous shifts occurred in the art of the medieval period with the emergence of Christianity as a major religion and the Church as a powerful patron of the arts.
- ◆ The Church remained an important patron of art during the Renaissance and Baroque periods; at the same time, there was also a rise in secular artworks during these periods, in light of the Protestant Reformation and general societal and economic shifts throughout Europe.
- ◆ Major innovations of the Renaissance include the use of linear perspective and a move toward greater naturalism. Baroque art is generally distinct from Renaissance art because of its greater sense of movement and drama.
- ◆ The Rococo style of art was closely tied to the power of the French aristocracy prior to the Revolution of 1789. The Neoclassical movement may in part be seen as a reaction to the Rococo and a response to the political and social revolution. Romanticism, in turn, was a reaction to the classicizing tendencies of Neoclassical art. Romanticism sought to appeal to the emotions and the senses.
- ◆ Realism and Impressionism both emerged in the second half of the nineteenth century. Both movements were focused on everyday life as a subject matter, although Impressionism became increasingly concerned with ideas of visual perception.
- ◆ Other late nineteenth-century developments included Post-Impressionism and the Pre-Raphaelites.
- ◆ Modernism emerged in the early twentieth century. Important modernist movements include Cubism, Expressionism, Dada, Surrealism, and Abstract Expressionism.
- ◆ The Armory Show in New York (1913) marked a shift in the art world, as the United States became a new center of progressive artistic activity.
- ◆ Pop Art, Minimalism, and Photorealism responded to a post-WWII industrial culture. Installations, performance, and environmental art all sought to challenge conventional ideas of art and its limitations.
- ◆ In the past, areas of nonwestern art were not incorporated in the chronological study of Western art; distinct regions of the world have often been studied separately. Today, though, many art historians are challenging this based on the realization that art throughout the world is interconnected, especially in terms of contemporary art. Art historians sometimes rely on different methods to understand nonwestern art.
- ◆ China, India, and Japan are among the major cultures of Asia. All three countries have ancient traditions and have produced art that relates to political power and religious practice.
- ◆ Ancient traditions can also be found in Africa. Often the arts of Africa and Oceania were created for very different functions from art in the Western traditions; consequently, there are tremendous formal differences as well.
- ◆ Islam is a major world religion that has produced much art. Most Islamic art is non-figurative.
- ◆ Ancient civilizations existed in the Americas as well. Archaeology is often used to learn about these civilizations and their art.
- ◆ In addition to understanding context, art historians seek to describe the formal qualities of artworks. Important terms used to discuss the formal qualities of an artwork include: line, shape and form, perspective, color, texture, and composition.
- ◆ Artists throughout time have worked in a variety of media, including drawing, printmaking, painting, photography, sculpture, mixed media, performance, craft and folk art, and architecture.

Finding Our Way

WAYFINDING WITHOUT MAPS

Long before printed or drawn maps existed, people relied on oral histories, celestial alignments, patterns of use or modification to the land, and other strategies for orienting themselves. Narratives, sensory cues, and natural features help humans create a mental map of a place or route. These psychological, cultural, or perceptual “expressions of spatial knowledge,” which are often passed down orally, do not always translate to an act of map-making, which is recording spatial knowledge in a physical or graphical way.¹

Navigation and calculation by the stars, without the use of scientific instruments, has been an important method for humans to find their way for thousands of years. Knowing the stars and constellations—and when and where they could be expected to appear—was an important survival skill. For North American groups, star knowledge included one’s physical and seasonal location and orientation, but it was also a narrative tool for conveying cosmology. However, it was rare for this information to be written down or presented graphically. In Minnesota, the “Native Skywatchers” program (a joint effort of Dakota, Lakota, and Ojibwe artists, scientists, linguists, and elders) produced modern [visualizations](#) of Native star knowledge that show the intersection between physical location and cultural tradition.²

Many other indigenous cultures around the world

rely on such customary knowledge for wayfinding, including stories, songs, and other forms of oral history. Another example of this method of navigation comes from Australia, in the Pacific world. Aboriginal Australians who traverse the vast interior of the continent, known as the Outback, developed chants and songs for orientation. These served as navigational aids and helped connect personal travels to the journeys of the Ancestral Beings who shaped the land. This knowledge is also known as “the Dreaming.” Involving repetition and call-and-response, Indigenous Australian chants relate specific sites to their mythic storylines.³ Physical modification of the landscape, including [rock art](#), helped solidify these narratives and produced visual landmarks to go with the spoken ones. A visual language of patterns, shapes, and lines indicates features that include water holes, campsites, rivers, or areas of great spiritual or ancestral power. Certain motifs that appear in these rock paintings have been in continual use for tens of thousands of years, according to scientific dating.⁴ These tactics allow Aboriginal peoples to flourish in the harsh conditions of the desert by navigating to places of safety.

Before the creation of written or printed maps, compasses, sextants, or GPS, people around the world used their senses, landmarks, stories, and personal or collective memories to situate themselves in space and to get where they wanted, or needed, to go.

SELECTED WORK: Rebbelib Navigation Chart, Marshall Islands, Micronesia, Nineteenth Century (Before 1892)

The people of Oceania need multiple skills to navigate their world, which is dominated by the Pacific Ocean. Customarily divided into the regions of Polynesia, Melanesia, and Micronesia, the Pacific Ocean world is made up of thousands of islands dispersed across millions of square miles of water. Oceanic art encodes social relations, serves religious and ceremonial functions, and imbues objects of daily use with utility and beauty. The category of “art” as it exists in the modern West, as something set aside for aesthetic contemplation, is not an effective way to think about items in the Pacific Ocean world. As art historian Nicholas Thomas wrote, “Art forms were usually not looked at with the kind of detached contemplation that seems to



Wakahuia (*treasure box*), Māori people, New Zealand, nineteenth century. Used to hold treasured items of personal adornment, wakahuia are utilitarian items that also are believed to contain spiritual power.

Metropolitan Museum of Art, Michael C. Rockefeller Memorial Collection, Bequest of Nelson A. Rockefeller



Aje (*drum*), Marshall Islands, nineteenth century. Aje are ceremonial drums played by women to accompany men's dances.

Metropolitan Museum of Art, Crosby Brown Collection of Musical Instruments

characterize the Western viewer's observation of works in art museums... Pacific art suggests that effective action was and is more important than [visual] communication.”⁵

The Rebbelib Navigation Chart made in the Marshall Islands in the late nineteenth century that is featured in your Art Reproductions Booklet is an excellent example of this idea. It encodes a mental map of the region, allowing a navigator to take “effective action” to steer his canoe to a safe port. However, while it presents an intriguing and pleasing arrangement of shapes visually, its navigational message cannot be effectively “communicated” to anyone outside the family of navigators it was made by. In this, it demonstrates culturally and personally specific wayfinding, apart from Western notions of “navigation” or geography.

Micronesia, where the Marshall Islands are located, was probably settled starting around 1300 BCE, with migrants coming from mainland Southeast Asia to the west and Polynesia to the east.⁶ While the ocean is the most dominant force in Marshallese life, and fishing is an important aspect of survival, prehistoric settlers from Southeast Asia also brought domesticated plant and animal species, including breadfruit, coconuts, and poultry. Since the eighteenth century, Oceanic cultures have been increasingly impacted by global histories of

colonial exploration. Early histories of contact were marked by conflict, including the transportation of Marshallese populations for use as enforced labor on Hawaiian plantations into the late nineteenth century. Starting in 1885, the Marshall Islands were part of the German Empire, and after 1914 they were in the Japanese sphere of influence. Political control passed to the United States in the aftermath of the Second World War, a period marked by military occupation and nuclear testing. The Marshall Islands gained independence in 1979. Today the Republic of the Marshall Islands has a population of a little more than 42,000 people.⁷

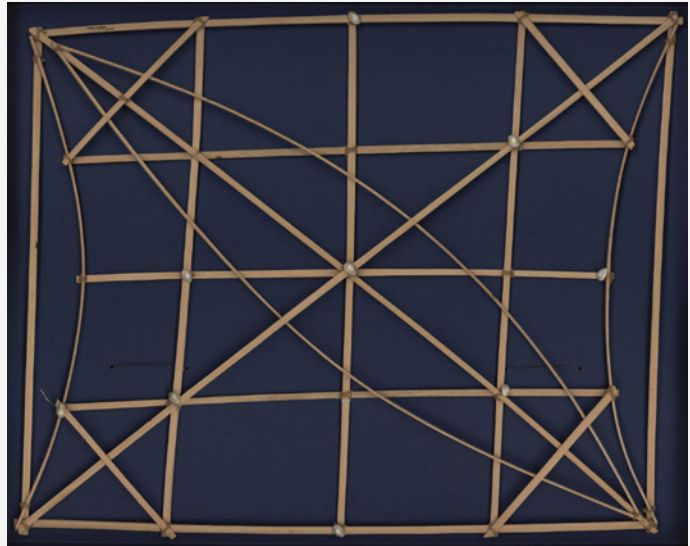
Early histories of contact in the Pacific world included collecting by European travelers, traders, and ethnographers amassing goods from Papuan, Polynesian, and Māori communities. This led to art targeted toward Western consumers as early as the 1770s. Compared with Polynesia and Melanesia, the rocky islands that make up Micronesia are not as rich in natural resources, and their artistic production is mostly limited to utilitarian objects. Therefore, Micronesian art was not collected as vigorously by Europeans and is not as well represented in Western collections today as the arts of other Pacific world traditions.⁸ However, one category of objects unique to the Marshall Islands can be seen in museums all over the world: the stick charts used for navigation, of which our selected work is an example.

The Marshall Islands, like the region of Micronesia more generally, are dominated by the ocean. Micronesia is made up of around 1,050 square miles of land to 2.9 million square miles of ocean; around 98 percent of the territory encompassed by the Marshall Islands is water.⁹ The Marshallese people rely on well-developed systems of ocean navigation dating back thousands of years. Traveling between the five major islands and twenty-nine atolls of the Marshall Islands, large fleets of twenty-five to thirty outrigger [canoes](#) relied on the expertise of master navigators who would sail a **pilot vessel**, a canoe that led the way for the other boats in the flotilla.

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The islands that make up the two major clusters of the Marshall Islands, the western Ralik and eastern Ratak chains, are low-lying landforms, making them difficult to spot from a distance. There are almost no noteworthy landmarks for navigators to use to guide their way. Even today, master navigators often choose not to use technological instruments. Instead, they rely on “the form and rhythm of ocean swells,” and “the behavior of land-based fishing birds, the movement of colors and clouds over land, the currents and [their] patterns.”¹⁰ Being a successful navigator—an exclusively male task—required strong leadership, quick decision-making, and most importantly, an excellent memory. To develop and exercise the remembered knowledge required for this task, elite families passed down “the secrets of navigation” using stick charts made from cowrie shells and the dried midribs of coconut fronds, bound together with natural fibers.¹¹

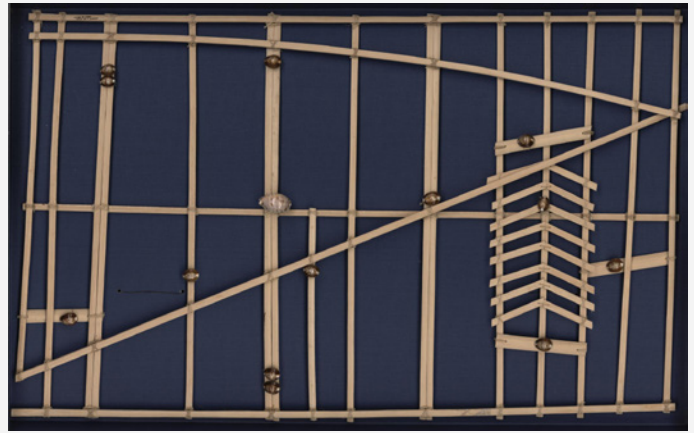
Though they may appear similar to laypeople, there are several varieties of these stick charts, each with a different function. **Mattang charts** do not map specific islands. They are diagrams used to teach navigators how swell patterns, known as **dunung**, radiate out from islands. **Mattang** charts are the most basic teaching tool a young navigator might start with, learning the elementary principles of how to feel the vibrations of **dunung** through the hull of the canoe and use those to guide a boat toward an unseen island. **Meddo charts** represent small, particular clusters of islands and their **dunung** patterns; they are used for local navigation.



Example of a mattang chart, Marshall Islands, c. 1920s.

Library of Congress, Geography and Map Division

Finally, ***rebbelib charts***, or *rebbelith* charts, like our selected object, represent large areas, often encompassing the entire Marshall archipelago. They are used for understanding how swells intersect and how winds and currents guide travelers across long distances. The background grid creates a stable framework, while the bent sticks represent *dunung* and wind or water currents. Small shells denote specific islands, though the spacing and relative position of the islands does not relate to their “actual” location in the archipelago. Instead, *rebbelibs* are “schematic” representations of mariners’ knowledge.¹²



Example of a meddo chart, Marshall Islands, c. 1920s.

Library of Congress, Geography and Map Division

Micronesian navigators created these charts to support the crucial activities of fishing and traveling between islands for trade, provisioning, or making political or familial connections. Navigators did not take the charts in their canoes with them. Instead, they served as memory aids that navigators would consult while on land. Makers reinforced knowledge by feeling the charts’ curves and reciting information about what they represented while preparing for a voyage. Bringing a chart into a canoe for use at sea would be considered bad luck, as it “called into question the extent of his [the navigator’s] knowledge and abilities.”¹³ These objects were also deeply personal and unique to the maker or his family. No two stick charts are alike, as they represent the interpretation of a specific navigator, filtered through years of individual experience.

The specific *rebbelib* shown in your Art Reproductions Booklet was collected in 1892 by a British naval captain, Edward Henry Meggs Davis, who visited the Marshall Islands on board the HMS *Royalist*. Of the more than seven hundred objects Davis collected across Oceania between 1890 and 1893, 141 are now in the [British Museum](#).¹⁴ However, like many objects acquired by sailors and travelers in this era, there is little documentation about how they were collected and who their original makers and users were. Without this precise information, we can still study Marshallese stick charts as a category of objects that provides “a tangible representation of how Marshall Islanders conceptualize their world and the oceanic terrain and pathways between its atolls.”¹⁵ Even if those pathways are invisible to the uninitiated eye, they served as vital currents of transportation for generations of Marshallese sailors across thousands of years.

AFRICAN AMERICAN HISTORIES OF FUGITIVITY

Another important historical example of navigating without maps was the experience of enslaved African Americans who sought freedom from bondage by undertaking the dangerous journey to the northern United States or to Canada. The Fugitive Slave Act, which was enacted in 1850, required people throughout the country (not just in slave-holding states) to turn “fugitives” over to law enforcement officials and criminalized aiding runaways. Resisting the legal language that equated freedom seekers and their allies with criminals, the formerly enslaved writer Henry Bibb coined an alternative term, “self-emancipation,”

in 1853.¹⁶ ***Abolitionists***, or those who sought the outlawing of slavery, protested the Fugitive Slave Act but were unsuccessful at challenging it. Anti-slavery resistance had led to the establishment of the ***Underground Railroad***, a network that assisted enslaved people in their escape to relatively safe areas in free states or, ultimately, to Canada. There was no actual, permanent infrastructure for the Underground Railroad; rather, to escape detection, it needed to remain as a constantly shifting network of trusted contacts, safe houses, and secure routes. Information about it was transmitted orally.

Escaping to freedom, whether on one’s own, or as part of an organized network such as the Underground



Poster supporting Anthony Burns, c. 1855. Burns was an escaped slave who was arrested in 1854. His trial attracted support from abolitionists. Ultimately Burns lost his case and was returned to Virginia the following year.

Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division

Railroad, was an act that involved complex wayfinding, relying on visual cues of space and place. “Runaway slaves had to look carefully for the most promising places of entry into the Northern states and then cautiously determine the safest routes for further travel,” wrote architectural historian John Michael Vlach, adding that successful fugitives had to be “skilled at reading and using the landscapes through which they traveled.”¹⁷ This was a visual experience that required cautious looking. Well-known images from the nineteenth century showing self-emancipated people, including [Theodor Kaufmann’s *On to Liberty*](#) (1867) and Eastman Johnson’s *A Ride for Liberty* (1862), show escapees scanning behind them for signs of pursuit.

The stars were important guideposts for self-emancipated people, who usually had to travel at night to avoid being seen. Navigation by the stars helped



Eastman Johnson, *A Ride for Liberty*, 1862.

Virginia Museum of the Fine Arts

orient them northward. The constellation known as the Big Dipper (also called Ursa Major), was known colloquially by African Americans as the “drinking gourd.” Two stars in this constellation, which can be seen year-round in the northern hemisphere, point toward the North Star, or Polaris, allowing runaways to chart a course toward safety. From folklorists to children’s books, popular media have spread the idea that the lyrics of the song “Follow the Drinking Gourd” provided travelers with a specific road map to freedom.¹⁸ However, no single “map” could be followed safely. It is more useful to see these journeys in terms of a process, requiring travelers to think quickly while on the move, constantly evaluating the security of possible routes.

Crossing bodies of water was also a crucial part of the journey: the Ohio River formed much of the border between the slave and free states and many fugitives saw it as their final major obstacle to cross. In paintings by the artist [Robert S. Duncanson](#), who was of mixed Black and European American heritage, bodies of water served as metaphors for the safe traversal of a dangerous landscape. In views of his home city, [Cincinnati, from across the Ohio River](#), Duncanson mapped visual geographies of slavery and freedom.¹⁹ Twenty-first century photographer Dawoud Bey’s series *Night Coming Tenderly, Black* picks up this journey on the other side of the river.

SELECTED WORK: Dawoud Bey, *Untitled #13 (Trees and Reflections)*, from *Night Coming Tenderly, Black*, 2017

In a career spanning nearly fifty years, American photographer Dawoud Bey has often engaged with representations of Black communities. In his series of black and white photographs [*Night Coming Tenderly, Black*](#), Bey records several sites on the final legs of the Underground Railroad. After crossing into Ohio, fugitives had to make their way to Cleveland, a port on Lake Erie, where they could catch a boat to the ultimate safety of Canada. Much of central Ohio in the nineteenth century was filled with thick forests, which helped provide protection and places of hiding.²⁰ Bey's photographs select sites along the last fifty miles of the route, through which self-emancipated people had to marshal all their resources and skills, without the aid of written maps. Bey's haunting, empty photographs are darkly lit and speak of a voyage filled with peril. But they also celebrate the resilience of those who were able to make it to the end of the journey.

Dawoud Bey was born in Queens, New York, in 1953 and completed his first major photographic project, [*Harlem USA*](#), in 1979. He later graduated with an MFA from Yale University School of Art in 1993. In 2017, Bey won a MacArthur Fellowship (sometimes called a "Genius Grant"), one of the most prestigious arts awards in the United States. In the early part of his career, Bey was mostly known for portraits and photographs of urban Black life. The genre of **street photography**, or informal unposed images taken in public places, was dominated by white photographers through the mid-1970s. Important street photographers included [*Walker Evans*](#), a pioneer of the genre in the 1930s, [*Robert Frank*](#), Lee Friedlander, and [*Garry Winogrand*](#). One major exception was the Harlem-based photographer [*Roy DeCarava*](#), who was known not only for his images' beauty and spontaneity, but also for his technical brilliance in developing high-contrast prints with rich, velvety black tones. In 1955, DeCarava published *Sweet Flypaper of Life* (1955) with text by the poet Langston Hughes. Both DeCarava and Hughes were major influences on Bey. The title of *Night Coming Tenderly, Black* was taken from Hughes's poem "Dream Variations" from 1926: "Rest at pale evening.../A tall, slim tree.../Night coming tenderly/Black like me."²¹

Bey's street photography focused on contemporary life. But in the early 2010s his work turned toward Black history. His first series on this theme was [*The Birmingham Project*](#) (2012), portraits that reflected on the six young lives lost in the bombing of a Baptist church in Birmingham, Alabama, in 1963. In 2017, the Cleveland Triennial for Contemporary Art commissioned Bey to investigate local histories of the Underground Railroad, leading to the first photographs in *Night Coming Tenderly, Black*. The series is not a documentary project, since most of the sites he chose were not actual locations of the antislavery network. Instead, Bey created an "[imagined experience of the journey](#)."²² Because of its clandestine nature, the Underground Railroad was not well documented in its own time, and much general knowledge about its operation is a



Roy DeCarava, *Couple Dancing, New York, 1956*.

Library of Congress Prints and Photographs Division

blend of truth and fiction. Its “position at the crossroads of history and myth” inspired Bey’s images, wrote art historian Steven Nelson.²³

Visually, the photographs are dark and impenetrable, mimicking the uncertainty and dread that must have accompanied the nighttime journeys. In *Untitled #13 (Trees and Reflections)* the tree line, cut off by the upper frame of the image, is reflected in the gently rippling water of a small pond. The darkness is eerie and intriguing, forcing the viewer to peer hard to discern details. The photographs are printed at large scale using **gelatin silver printing**, an analog photographic process first developed around 1890, which uses silver halides suspended in gelatin to create a light-sensitive surface for printing. Gelatin silver printing allows the photographer incredible control in creating a full tonal range from dark true black to crisp white.

Though it was shot in the daytime, *Untitled #13 (Trees and Reflections)* uses this analog printing process to achieve a hazy blackness that mimics photographs taken in low-light conditions. The image’s size of about four by five feet, much larger than we expect with photographs, creates an immersive and enigmatic viewing experience. The low contrast forces us to slow down to allow our eyes to adjust to the darkness. Conceptually, this darkness acts like an enveloping screen that provides the safety of concealment. At the same time, it blocks out everything but the stars and the dim outlines of trees, houses, or other guiding landmarks.

Untitled #13 (Trees and Reflections) takes an ordinary American landscape and makes it feel strange and alien, a parallel to what enslaved people fleeing through unknown spaces might have experienced. The other photographs in the series, such as *Untitled #1 (Picket Fence and Farmhouse)*, also stress the “unmonumental” nature of the sites where formerly enslaved people sought safety during their journeys; buildings used as way-stations for the Underground Railroad included private homes but also barns, sheds, or other humble outbuildings.²⁴

Peering across the pond in *Untitled #13 (Trees and Reflections)*, we struggle to find anything that might help orient a traveler in the difficult process of navigating. Instead of showing human figures moving through the space, as [nineteenth-century paintings](#) tended to do, the photographs ask us to imagine ourselves trying to navigate an obscured and uncertain route. The lack of clues about where to go next also forces the viewer to imagine the constant negotiation and assessment that fugitives experienced during their dangerous travels. As Bey explained, this position might be frightening, but it could also be liberating as he imagined Black freedom seekers “looking out as opposed to being looked at.”²⁵ That is, their journey necessitated careful attention, planning, and watchfulness, but it also freed them from the oversight, surveillance, and objectification they experienced during enslavement. In *Untitled #13 (Trees and Reflections)*, Bey chronicles the journey of an unnamed, imagined fugitive who made a trail to safety, guided by stars, rivers, whispers, and hints, through the black of night.

PERCEPTION AND THE ART OF WALKING

Walking can be a meditative or transformative experience: “let a man take to his legs and soon his brain will begin to grow luminous and sparkle,” wrote Alfred Barron in his 1875 book *Foot Notes, or Walking as a Fine Art*.²⁶ Walking is often built into acts of religious devotion, from the circumambulation of [Buddhist stupas](#) or the holy [Ka’ba in Mecca](#) to the medieval pilgrimage roads of northern Spain, which

Catholic devotees hiked to reach the [Cathedral of Santiago de Compostela](#). Meditating on the movement of the body through or toward holy spaces is intended to create a psychological state of reverence that allows the walker to contemplate the divine. The repetitive toil of a journey on foot challenges both body and mind. Secular walking, as the geographer Yi-Fu Tuan suggests, becomes a method of achieving mindful and open attentiveness to self and surroundings, causing the walker to reflect on their own place within a large and complex world.²⁷

SELECTED WORK: Richard Long, *A Line Made by Walking*, 1967

Through its intervention into the English landscape, Richard Long's *A Line Made by Walking* raises questions about human relationships with nature, expressed through the way we walk the land. The photograph of *A Line Made by Walking* shows what appears to be a short, whitish line about thirty feet long in a field of scrubby grass and tiny flowers. On closer looking, we see that the line is not painted, drawn, or built onto the ground but has been created by walking back and forth across the field until the walker's feet have flattened down the grass enough to change the way it reflects the light. Compressing the grass and packing it close to the earth have produced a line whose outlines wobble and waver as parts of the grass start to spring back up.



Robert Smithson, *Spiral Jetty*, 1970. Rozel Point, Great Salt Lake, Utah.

For Long, the photograph was only the documentation of the work. The piece itself was the act of walking back and forth for about twenty minutes and the “sculpture” that was temporarily produced by the artist’s actions in an unremarkable field in a London suburb.²⁸ As critic Caroline Tisdall wrote in 1971, responding to an exhibition of Long’s works at the Whitechapel Gallery in London, “The most transient are the traces left in the grass. They represent the number of times the artist passes over the same spot. The more times, the deeper the trace. The only trace left once the grass straightens will be the photographic record.”²⁹ This photograph is the only way *A Line Made by Walking* was recorded for the public to view.

A Line Made by Walking is an important early work of both Land art and conceptual art that deals with walking as a basic human function and as an artistic practice. In the **Land art** movement of the late 1960s and 1970s, artists made physical interventions into the natural environment to change the way the visitor sees, thinks about, or experiences that space. Land art often by necessity dealt with the experience of walking, as the spectator had to move around the site to fully appreciate the artist’s modification of it. One example is Walter De Maria’s *Las Vegas Piece* (1969), a sunken path carved into the Tule Desert in Nevada. The artist forbade the work to be photographed from the air, which meant it could only be experienced on foot.³⁰

In **conceptual art**, which emerged around the same time as Land art, the finished product is less important than the idea (or “concept,” hence the name). Conceptual art was interested in exploring repetitive forms, pre-determined processes, or “scripts.” American artist Sol LeWitt described conceptual art this way: “all of the planning and decisions are made beforehand and the execution is a perfunctory affair. The idea ... makes the art.”³¹ The dedication to process over result pushed conceptual artists to explore basic, everyday acts such as walking. Pieces include Bruce Nauman’s video *Walking in an Exaggerated Manner Around the Perimeter of a Square* (1967–68) and Vito Acconci’s *Following Piece* (1969), in which the artist selected random strangers to follow around New York City. Both used a script to stage walking-related actions. *A Line Made by Walking* spans the genres of Land art and conceptual art. Though Long usually refers to himself as a sculptor, most of his pieces are transitory interventions into the landscape, made permanent only by documentation such as photographs, writings, and maps.

Richard Long was born in the city of Bristol, England, in 1945, a member of Britain’s baby boom generation. As a child, Long accompanied his parents on “walking holidays” that clearly inspired his artistic interests. From 1962 to 1965, he studied at his local art school, the West of England College of Art in Bristol. Starting in

1966, he began a course of sculpture at St. Martin's School of Art in London, one of the most prestigious art schools in postwar Britain. In the 1960s, the sculpture faculty at St. Martin's was dominated by [Anthony Caro](#), known for large-scale works exploring equilibrium and balance, executed using industrial materials and bright colors. Even though he was a flexible and inspirational teacher who used experimental instructional methods, Caro's fame inspired some pushback among his students. The generation of the 1960s that included Long, [Hamish Fulton](#), and [Bruce McLean](#) turned away from Caro's example. Their works are often transient, self-deprecating, and intimate where Caro's were permanent, grandiose, and monumental.



Richard Long in 2015.

Long produced *A Line Made by Walking* in 1967, when he was still a twenty-two-year-old student.

Since then, he has produced [walking-related pieces](#) all over the world, as well as installations that bring natural materials such as [local mud](#) and [stones](#) into traditional gallery spaces. In 1989, Long won the prestigious Turner Prize, awarded annually to the best exhibition or installation in a British museum or gallery. He has often been discussed as an important pioneer of Land art.

Land art has been tied to the emergence of what would later be called the environmentalist movement, with its focus on land conservation and resource stewardship. However, the best-known practitioners of Land art, including Robert Smithson, [Nancy Holt](#), [Michael Heizer](#), and Walter de Maria, did not usually approach their work with an environmental consciousness. Heizer bulldozed the land, carving trenches into rock; Smithson polluted sites with industrial chemicals in his “pour” works, such as [Glue Pour](#) (1969). These artists created their pieces primarily in the vast open spaces of the American Southwest, where, historically, land modification went along with histories of expansion and Manifest Destiny.

[British Land art](#) tended to have a quieter impact and [more limited scope](#). Art curator Dieter Roelstraete contrasted the “aggressive, macho ethic” of American Land Art, which often resulted in large-scale, industrially constructed interventions, with a culture of “humility in the face of nature and the landscape” practiced by English artists like Long, Fulton, and Andy Goldsworthy.³² It is not only in its humble scale and respect for the integrity of natural materials that *A Line Made by Walking* differs from American examples of Land art, though. The history of walking itself is embedded in a Britishness that is an important part of *A Line Made by Walking*'s context and meaning.

Walking for pleasure has a long history in the British Isles, dating back at least to the late eighteenth century, when it was adopted by Romantic writers as a habit that could encourage self-reflection through bodily and sensory experiences. As the balance of the British economy began to shift away from the land (and toward mercantile and industrial economies), rural areas became less associated with productive labor and more closely tied to modern notions of relaxation and escape from drudgery. Outdoor time was now leisure time. By the Victorian era, large groups of walkers known as “rambling clubs,” mostly made up of working-class men, organized to challenge the idea that only the landed gentry, or hereditary landowners, “belonged” in the English countryside. Rambling clubs pushed for walkers' right to pass through private land in the country, leading to the formation of the Open Space Society in 1865 and the Forest Ramblers' Club in 1884.³³

Walking in twentieth-century Britain transformed into an activity connected with youth movements and

countercultural attitudes. Starting in the late 1960s, [Alfred Wainwright](#) published his series of irreverently humorous walking guidebooks. He envisioned long-distance walking almost as a form of guerrilla action, advising ramblers to ignore threats from local landowners and providing instructions for evading detection, crossing safely over barbed-wire fences, and defusing run-ins with farm animals. British youth culture of the 1960s and 1970s was also connected to a “New Age” movement focused on harnessing mystical energies they envisioned as a deep part of the rural landscape. One influential text that experienced a revival of interest in the 1960s was Alfred Watkins’s *The Old Straight Track* (1925), which outlined a theory of “[ley lines](#).” This network of ancient walking paths, Watkins believed, connected sites of psychic power across the British Isles.³⁴

Richard Long read *The Old Straight Track*, but probably not until after he had already completed *A Line Made by Walking*. However, the countercultural ethos of “New Age” mysticism among youth of Long’s generation is explicitly present in many of his works. He has often walked sites associated with ancient British religious rituals, including [Silbury Hill](#), a neolithic earthwork not far from Stonehenge, and created pieces associated with pagan sites in other parts of England and [Scotland](#). *Cerne Abbas Walk* (1975) traces a six-mile circle around the massive figure of a walking man known as the “Cerne Abbas Giant.” In the 1970s, many believed this figure, which is cut into the turf of a hillside to reveal the white chalk beneath, was around 1800 years old. In a caption for Cerne Abbas Walk, Long wrote: “His eyes watch over a country mile / The giant / Walks on the hill / One step / Forever.”³⁵ These walks and artworks excavate deep histories of walking in the natural landscape, re-enacting imagined religious and ceremonial processions by the ancient peoples of the British Isles. As Long plans and records his walks, he also engages in another important aspect of finding our way: mapping.



“Hike for Health,” Southern Railway advertising poster, c. 1930.

Science Museum of London

MAPMAKING AND NAMING

While the experience of holding a physical map is much less common today than it was just a generation ago, most of us have some experience reading maps. They may mark out important landmarks or sites of interest or simply use an algorithm to tell us the quickest route from point A to point B. With the use of satellite imaging, maps have become more accessible than ever before. We can pull up an image of almost any corner of the globe instantly, in the palm of our hands. As we saw in the discussion of wayfinding, maps are not the only way of locating ourselves in space or navigating to a desired location. However,

starting in the fifteenth century, the age of European exploration privileged the production of drawn or printed maps. **Cartography**, or the art of mapmaking, became a tool for navigation, exploration, and control.

We might think of a map—especially a digital one created using satellite images, street views, and geological or demographic data—as a reflection of objective reality.³⁶ Maps’ primary function is to be accurate as navigational guides, and they usually succeed in doing this. But this does not mean maps are neutral—there are always choices about what to include and exclude, and how prominently information should be displayed. For instance, a mapping app



Joan Blaeu, *Map of New Belgium and New England*, c. 1662. Typical of early modern maps, this map contains little usable navigational information.

Harrison Mann Jr. Map Collection, George Mason University

might highlight certain businesses that pay to have their visibility boosted. The history of mapmaking suggests that early modern maps were often a European tool “to locate and dominate places and people,” and to do so, they used strategies of drawing boundaries, gridding, and naming.³⁷

Early modern European maps took many forms. **Portolan charts** were [navigational guides](#) for sailors that only mapped the outline of a coastal area, while maps showing blank interior regions might be filled in gradually as travelers gained more information about new places. Maps helped create what scholar William Boelhower described as a “cartographic culture,” one that helped early explorers “imagine” America by envisioning how they might fill those empty spaces with knowledge about a new place.³⁸

Some early maps were useless for actual navigation; instead, they showed vignettes of local people, animals, and plants, or marked areas of political influence with large crests or coats of arms. Gradually more scientific forms of mapmaking stressed accurate surveying, consistent scale, and use of grid lines to ensure standardization. By the end of the eighteenth century, American mapmaking was a highly developed business. Consumers had a growing expectation that maps would accurately display features of specific locations and convey the correct distances between places. To do this required detailed surveying.

An important moment in mapping America was the establishment of the United States Geological Survey after the Civil War. Initially created to determine optimal routes for railway lines, the survey’s mission

expanded over the rest of the nineteenth century. As art historian Jason Weems noted, “in the late nineteenth century the business of cartography was no longer concerned only with filling in blank spots on the map but also with the collection and communication of deeply detailed and actionable information.”³⁹

The first major survey, authorized in 1867, was led by geologist Ferdinand V. Hayden in 1871. Hayden’s brief was to map and document the Yellowstone region of Wyoming, recording its important features, local resources such as woods and minerals, and flora and fauna. This survey team included two artists: photographer [William Henry Jackson](#) and painter [Thomas Moran](#). In addition to the scientific participants—surveyors and cartographers, geologists, botanists, zoologists, and meteorologists—artists became an important part of any survey team. Images made by [survey artists](#) created indelible [visions of the American West](#) in the popular imagination. In addition, each survey produced detailed topographical maps that were printed by the government and made publicly available. In 1884, John Wesley Powell

claimed that the “Government cannot do any scientific work of more value to the people at large than by causing the construction of proper topographic maps of the country.”⁴⁰

While mapping allowed settlers to visualize and traverse unknown locations, names gave a place a concrete presence and identity on a map. **Toponyms**, or place names, are deeply encoded with history and meaning. American toponyms derive from the names of rulers or important historical figures (Maryland, Carolina, Washington, Columbia); local landowners or developers (Austin, Fairfax, Bozeman); geographic features (Little Rock, Council Bluffs, Grand Rapids); religious figures and Biblical locations (Bethesda, Canaan, San Francisco); and people or places from the ancient world (Cairo, Carthage, Cincinnati). They also derive from words in English, French, Dutch, German, Spanish, and dozens of Indigenous languages. Indigenous place names were often used to indicate the former presence of Native peoples there, a convention that some [contemporary Native American artists](#) reflect on in their works.

SELECTED WORK: Jaune Quick-to-See Smith, *State Names*, 2000

Jaune Quick-to-See Smith was an important Indigenous artist and curator. She was known for her paintings, collages, and installation art dealing with Native American history and culture. Her painting *State Names* engages the histories of cartography and naming, using the United States map to contrast these scientific forms of knowing with the more embodied, local relationship with place cultivated in many Native communities.

Born in 1940, Jaune Quick-to-See Smith was an enrolled member of the Confederated Salish and Kootenai Tribes of the Flathead Nation of Montana. Her childhood was difficult: she was raised by a single father who often struggled to find work as a horse trainer and rodeo performer. At a young age, she learned carpentry from him and absorbed an interest in creating beautiful things by hand. In 1958 she started taking college art classes but did not complete her undergraduate degree until 1976. Later that year, she moved to New Mexico and began her exhibition and curatorial career, earning



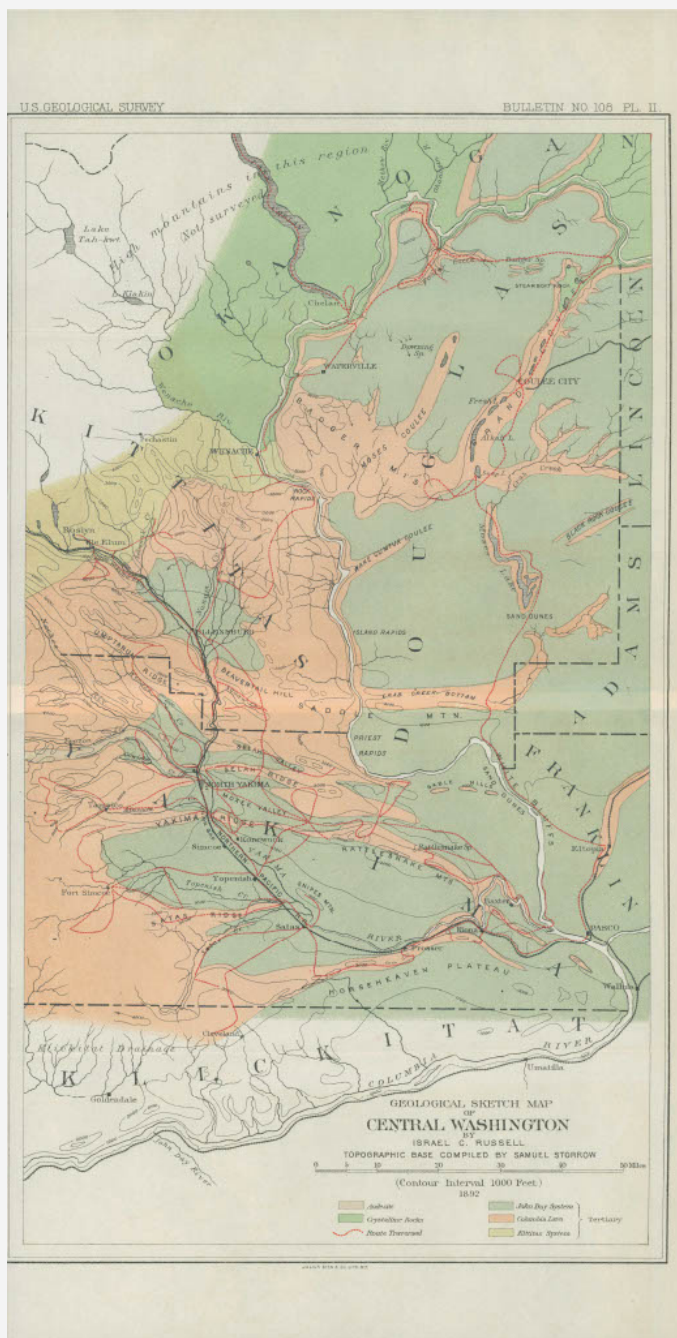
Jaune Quick-to-See Smith, photo by Thomas King.

an MA at the University of New Mexico in 1980. Smith was best known for her large-scale artworks dealing with histories of Native American life and representation in the United States, including some of her best-known pieces, *The Red Mean: Self-Portrait* (1992) and *Trade: Gifts for Trading Land with White People* (1992). Her work incorporates layered references to popular culture, art history, ecology, and American history.

Smith was also known for her advocacy on behalf of Indigenous artists, writing that “My life’s work involves examining contemporary life in America and interpreting it through Native ideology.”⁴¹ In 1992, Smith curated her first major exhibition, which featured the work of thirty-eight contemporary Native American artists and traveled to a dozen locations. *Submuloc Show – Columbus Wohs* (“Submuloc” spells “Columbus” backwards) was a response to the 500th anniversary of the arrival of Christopher Columbus in the Americas, as seen through Indigenous viewpoints. Smith’s most recent curatorial project was *The Land Carries our Ancestors: Contemporary Art by Native Americans* at the National Gallery of Art in 2023–24. She passed away in 2025.⁴²

State Names is about the origin of place names in North America. The piece shows a map of the United States, along with parts of Canada and Mexico, surrounded by an inky black ocean. States with names that come from Indigenous languages are labeled, while those with European origins are left blank. Language is a crucial part of Smith’s artistic practice. She recounted in a 2024 interview that her father attended a residential boarding school where he was beaten for speaking Salish, an experience shared by many Native American children of his generation. Smith used this anecdote to reinforce the importance of language transmission among Native groups: “Our languages carried thousands of years of knowledge.”⁴³ Copies of her tribal newspaper, the *Char-Koosta News*, often appear as collaged fragments in Smith’s works.

State Names loosely resembles the brightly colored paintings of the [United States map](#) by American Pop artist Jasper Johns. Johns’s use of simple and iconic forms such as maps, the [alphabet](#), and the [American flag](#), underlaid with collaged texts from newspapers and advertisements, influenced Smith’s working methods.⁴⁴ But where Johns’s touchstones are more about instant recognizability as popular icons, Smith ties her painted maps explicitly to Native American identity.



Map of central Washington State, from the Bulletin of the United States Geological Survey, Government Printing Office, 1893.

In *State Names*, the words jump out at us from the composition. In a uniform, newspaper-like font, the names of states and provinces in Canada, the United States, and Mexico that are taken from Indigenous languages are large and legible, despite the dripping and layered paint. Familiar words are brought to the viewer's attention, inviting a consideration of how and why those place names came to be. Do they mark an absence or an ongoing presence of Native peoples in those sites? How did varied Indigenous languages contribute to our mental map of North America? For languages that lacked written forms, who decided how place names should be spelled, and how did they make that decision? Do any of these names rely on misunderstandings, misrepresentations, or mishearings? *State Names* asks viewers to think about how it came to be that Native words and places are all around us, and yet we often do not think about Native peoples as persisting in the contemporary world.

State Names engages with ideas about the land and mapping that offer an alternative to the mathematical and scientific impulses of early modern European maps and nineteenth-century surveys. In this painting, Smith considers how Indigenous ways of knowing and naming places cannot be bound by the straight lines and arbitrary divisions of cartographic knowledge. Compare the runny, wavering borders between the states in Smith's composition with an example of official cartography: a survey map from 1893, shown on the previous page. Showing part of central Washington, this map features manmade divisions cutting across natural features of the landscape. Geological foundations, which curve with the topography, are overlaid with thick, rigid dashed lines that divide the region into counties, many named after important political figures.

In 2018, Smith wrote that Native ways of knowing reject the notion that “humankind is in control of nature.” She recalled an embodied, sensory experience of place that was central to her upbringing and reflected on a way of imagining the land that can't be divided by lines on a map: “the Sacred is the land, the sky, the water, and everything that is the natural world ... the here and now we reside in, all breathing the same air, all imbibing the same water, and all made of the same earth ... This is not hippie-dippie stuff, this is thousands of years of formatting culture.”⁴⁵ The view of Native cultures Smith expressed here—what she saw as a long-term relation to the landscape that resisted certain forms of organization and control, like maps—inflects *State Names*.

State Names highlights the arbitrary nature of administrative divisions. Some borders, like the part of the United States–Mexico border traced by the Rio Grande, are determined by natural features. But others, such as the strict ninety-degree angles created by the intersection of the “Four Corners” states of Colorado, New Mexico, Arizona, and Utah, are drawn without regard for either geological boundaries or Indigenous communities. As one example, the Navajo Nation or Dinétah, the largest reservation by land area in the U.S., spans across parts of three of the Four Corners states.

In *State Names*, borderlines become blurred and illegible through the dripping paintwork that obscures sharp divisions. Southeastern Arkansas runs almost seamlessly into northeastern Mississippi, both rendered in shades of blue green. Yellow rivulets from Oklahoma seep down into Texas, a reminder of the vast Comanche empire that once dominated these lands, heedless of the borders later created by official maps. *State Names* asks us to look again, and to re-orient ourselves, within the recognizable mapped contours of our nation.

SECTION II SUMMARY

Wayfinding without Maps

- ◆ Long before printed or drawn maps existed, people relied on oral histories, celestial alignments, patterns of use or modification to the land, and other strategies for orienting themselves.

SELECTED WORK: Rebbelib Navigation Chart, Marshall Islands, Micronesia, Nineteenth Century (Before 1892)

- ◆ The Republic of the Marshall Islands in Micronesia, in the Pacific Ocean, is an independent nation of about 42,000 people. Around ninety-eight percent of Marshallese territory is water, so the Marshallese rely on systems of ocean navigation dating back thousands of years.
- ◆ The islands in the Marshall archipelago are low-lying. To find their way, navigators must remember and interpret the patterns of ocean swells, known as *dunung*.
- ◆ Male navigators from elite families were responsible for leading fleets of canoes between islands. To develop the necessary navigational knowledge, families educated their sons using several kinds of stick charts.
- ◆ *Mattang* charts teach the basic principles of how swell patterns radiate out from islands. *Meddo* charts represent particular clusters of islands and are used for local navigation. *Rebbelib* charts often encompass the entire Marshall archipelago. They are used for understanding how swells intersect and how winds and currents guide travelers across long distances.
- ◆ Navigators did not take charts in their canoes. Instead, they used them to prepare for voyages.
- ◆ No two charts are alike, as they represent the interpretation of a specific navigator or family.

African American Histories of Fugitivity

- ◆ The Underground Railroad was a network that assisted enslaved people in their escape to freedom.

- ◆ The Fugitive Slave Act, enacted in 1850, required people to turn “fugitives” over to law enforcement officials and criminalized aiding runaways.
- ◆ Escaping to freedom involved complex wayfinding, relying on visual cues of space and place. The stars were important guideposts for freedom seekers, who usually had to travel by night to avoid being seen.

SELECTED WORK: Dawoud Bey, *Untitled #13 (Trees and Reflections)*, from *Night Coming Tenderly, Black*, 2017

- ◆ American photographer Dawoud Bey was born in Queens, New York, in 1953. Bey was first active in the genre of street photography. In the early 2010s his work turned toward Black history.
- ◆ *Night Coming Tenderly, Black* was commissioned by the Cleveland Triennial for Contemporary Art in 2017. The series records sites around Cleveland, Ohio, which was on the final legs of the Underground Railroad route. Once they made it to Cleveland, most formerly enslaved people attempted to get a boat to Canada.
- ◆ *Night Coming Tenderly, Black* is not a documentary project since most of the sites shown were not actual locations of the antislavery network. Instead, Bey created an imagined experience of the places a runaway might have seen or passed.
- ◆ *Untitled #13 (Trees and Reflections)* is a very large photograph printed to mimic a photograph taken in low-light conditions. The image forces us to slow down and allow our eyes to adjust to the darkness, trying to discern guiding landmarks.
- ◆ *Untitled #13 (Trees and Reflections)* takes an ordinary American landscape and makes it strange, a parallel to what Black “fugitives” might have experienced. The lack of clues about where to go next forces the viewer to imagine the constant assessment self-emancipated people experienced during their dangerous travels.

Perception and the Art of Walking

- ♦ Walking can be a meditative or transformative experience. Walking is often built into acts of religious devotion and pilgrimage. Secular walking can also achieve mindfulness, causing the walker to reflect on their place within a large and complex world.

SELECTED WORK: Richard Long, *A Line Made by Walking*, 1967

- ♦ British sculptor Richard Long trained at St. Martin's School of Art in London. He produced *A Line Made by Walking* in 1967, when he was still a twenty-two-year-old student.
- ♦ *A Line Made by Walking* was created by walking back and forth across a field for about twenty minutes. While the artist considers himself a sculptor, the photographic documentation was the only permanent recording of *A Line Made by Walking*.
- ♦ *A Line Made by Walking* is an important early work of both Land art and conceptual art that deals with walking as a basic human function and as an artistic practice.
- ♦ In its humble scale and respect for the integrity of natural materials, *A Line Made by Walking* is similar to other Land art by British artists, in contrast with the larger scale of American Land art.
- ♦ Walking for pleasure has a long history in the British Isles, dating back to the late eighteenth century. In the nineteenth century, rural areas became less associated with productive labor and more closely tied to modern notions of relaxation.
- ♦ Walking in twentieth-century Britain was connected with youth movements and countercultural attitudes. British youth saw walking as a way to harness mystical energies. This "New Age" mysticism of Long's generation appears in many of his works, which took place in sites of historical or religious significance around the British Isles.

Mapmaking and Naming

- ♦ Maps are not neutral—there are always choices about what to include and exclude, and how prominently information should be displayed. Cartography can be a tool for navigation, exploration, and control.
- ♦ By around 1800, consumers expected maps to be geographically accurate. This required scientific surveying of new places.
- ♦ The United States Geological Survey was established after the Civil War. Surveys produced detailed topographical maps that were printed by the government and made publicly available.
- ♦ American place names derive from diverse origins, including Indigenous languages.

SELECTED WORK: Jaune Quick-to-See Smith, *State Names*, 2000

- ♦ Jaune Quick-to-See Smith was an important Indigenous (Confederated Salish and Kootenai Tribes of the Flathead Nation of Montana) artist and curator.
- ♦ She was known for her paintings, collages, and installation art. Her work incorporates layered references to popular culture, art history, ecology, and American history.
- ♦ *State Names* is about the origin of place names in North America. States with names that come from Indigenous languages are labeled, while those with European origins are left blank. The piece asks viewers to think about how it came to be that Native words and places are all around us.
- ♦ *State Names* contrasts scientific forms of knowing, like cartography, with the more embodied, local relationship with place cultivated in many Native communities.
- ♦ *State Names* also highlights the arbitrary nature of administrative divisions, which often do not follow the borders that would be determined by natural features.

SECTION III

Global Currents

EXPLORATION AND EMPIRE

In 1492, Christopher Columbus landed in the Caribbean, an event that changed history forever. As most American students learn, Columbus, an Italian navigator, had embarked from Spain in search of a trade route to Asia. Instead of finding himself in China, Columbus unexpectedly landed in what quickly became known to Europeans as the “New World.” The consequence was a centuries-long process of colonization and cultural exchange as France, Spain, England, and Portugal vied to control lucrative resources. The first part of this section will examine two artworks that explicitly depict imperial exploration and expansion. Art was an important part of imperial projects, prompting exploration of territories colonial powers wished to control, presenting national narratives and, in the present, reflecting on the legacies of global expansion.



Alphonse Bigot, “Landing of Columbus,” 1853. A collectible trading card based on John Vanderlyn’s painting *The Landing of Columbus*, which hangs in the U.S. Capitol rotunda.

New York Public Library, Miriam and Ira D. Wallach Division of Art, Prints and Photographs

SELECTED WORK: Sir John Everett Millais, *The North-West Passage*, 1874

For hundreds of years before the construction of the Panama Canal enabled ships to pass through the narrowest point of Central America, European sailors searched for a shorter water route from the Atlantic to the Pacific Ocean. The elusive route would allow ships to sail north, over Canada, instead of making the arduous journey around the treacherous waters of Cape Horn, at the farthest tip of South America. Over several centuries, Britain sent multiple expeditions to search for this so-called “Northwest Passage” that would enable traders to purchase desirable goods from Asia quickly and efficiently. Oral traditions of Inuit peoples told of a water route that could be traversed by canoe, but traders wished to find a path that larger ships could navigate safely. Martin Frobisher, the first British explorer to seek the Northwest Passage, set sail in the 1570s, making three failed voyages to the Arctic. Sir John Everett Millais’s painting *The North-West Passage*, made at the height of the British Empire’s power, chronicles both the hope and the tragedy that this search represented for Britons.

Sir John Everett Millais was born in the English port city of Southampton in 1829. At the age of eleven, Millais became the youngest student ever accepted to the Royal Academy of Art, which since 1768 had been the premier location for young British and American artists to learn painting and drawing. In 1846 he made his debut at the annual Academy exhibition. Even at this early stage in his career, Millais chose to

focus on an event related to histories of empire and exploration; though visually very different from his later style, his initial work for exhibit, [Pizarro Seizing the Inca of Peru](#), shows an incident of colonial conflict.

At the Academy, Millais met fellow student [William Holman Hunt](#). Along with another painter, [Dante Gabriel Rossetti](#), in 1848 the trio formed what they called the **Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood**, a group of socially and artistically progressive young English artists who rejected the Academy's teachings. Their name referred to their desire to return art to a time "before" the High Renaissance embodied by the Italian painter [Raphael Sanzio](#). They argued that Renaissance art was too formulaic and **idealizing** (showing things not as they truly appear but as perfect, ideal forms). They rejected linear perspective and Renaissance proportion in favor of a return to a quasi-medieval aesthetic, which also included the use of [minute detail](#) and [saturated color](#). As part of their rejection of idealism, they dedicated themselves to close observation, pledging to represent things as they really appeared, and not shying away from imperfection, age, or decay.



Martin Frobisher searching for the Northwest Passage in a kayak, 1580.

New York Public Library, Rare Book Division

First exhibited in 1848, their work was harshly criticized for its [awkward, flat-looking figures](#), [unusual color choices](#), and un-idealized details such as dirty fingernails. However, within five years, the Pre-Raphaelite movement had gained many supporters, including John Ruskin, the most influential art critic of the nineteenth century. Viewers became more familiar with the style, and it gained popularity among audiences, spawning many imitators during the next several decades. One of Millais's most typical and well-known early works in the Pre-Raphaelite style is [Ophelia](#) (1852). In his later career, Millais turned from a highly detailed approach to a more brushy, loose style that is seen in *The North-West Passage*. In 1885, Queen Victoria granted him a baronetcy (a non-hereditary title). In 1896, shortly before his death, Millais was elected President of the Royal Academy, making him one of the most influential artistic figures in Britain.⁴⁶

The North-West Passage is filled with visual references to Britain's naval power and to its main character's experience as a sailor. An older man sits at a desk, while a young woman perches on a low stool beneath him, holding his hand. A view out the window shows that the house overlooks the ocean, with a single sailboat passing by in calm waters. Near the man's elbow, at the far left of the picture, is a table holding a stack of books and papers, a glass of spirits, a telescope, and a dish holding a lemon, perhaps a reference to the need for sailors to replenish vitamin C with fresh fruit while at sea.

Above his head is a framed black and white print of [Admiral Horatio Nelson](#), a major naval commander during the Napoleonic Wars at the turn of the nineteenth century. Another framed image, a painting of a ship crossing an Arctic sea filled with icebergs, is partially covered by the British flag, known as the Union Jack, and a white naval ensign flag. The man seems to have just looked away from the Portolan chart of the Canadian coastline on the table, while the girl, usually assumed to be his daughter, may be reading a maritime log. This painting enacts a quiet family drama of loss and worry, while also referencing historical issues of empire and exploration.

The North-West Passage is one of the most important works of Millais's later career. It debuted at the Royal

Academy in 1874 and was part of the English art exhibition at the 1878 Paris world's fair. The painting was acquired by the National Gallery of British Art (precursor to the Tate Gallery) in 1897. Art historian Alison Smith described *The North-West Passage* as “one of the defining images of British imperial heroism.”⁴⁷ Admiral Nelson, whose figure is pictured above that of the grizzled old sailor, famously sent the signal flag message “England expects that every man will do his duty” before the [Battle of Trafalgar](#), a major victory for the UK, in which Nelson lost his life. The model who posed as the old mariner in the painting, Edward John Trelawney, was himself a veteran of the Royal Navy and served at Trafalgar.⁴⁸

This image of Nelson as a naval hero, along with the flags in the upper right, set a patriotic tone. The title, referencing the fabled trade route to the Pacific, also gave *The North-West Passage* an important meaning for nineteenth-century Britons. As Millais's son John Guille Millais wrote of his father's picture, it was “an expression more eloquent than words of the manly enterprise of the nation and the common desire that to England should fall the honour of laying bare the hidden mystery of the North.”⁴⁹ However, this upbeat tone contrasts with the tragic real-life explorations searching for the Northwest Passage and with the family sorrow implied in the painting's pair of figures.



Sir John Everett Millais, Self-Portrait, 1881.

Searching for a Northwest Passage to speed naval trade to the Pacific became increasingly important as Britain expanded its empire in the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. Stories of a sea route that wove its way among the many small islands of the north Canadian archipelago prompted voyages of exploration, many of which ended in disaster. In 1845, in an event that would still have felt fresh in the minds of many Victorian Britons, the Admiralty (the government department responsible for administering the Royal Navy) lost touch with an expedition led by the experienced colonial administrator and explorer Sir John Franklin. It was later discovered that the two ships, the HMS *Erebus* and HMS *Terror*, had become trapped in the polar ice and were eventually abandoned by what remained of their crews. Numerous search parties were unable to locate either the remains of the broken ships or the survivors. By 1854, it was widely reported that all 129 men who were sent on the mission had perished.⁵⁰

This sensational event spawned plays, poems, popular songs, and more than one major work of art. In addition to Millais's *The North-West Passage*, Edwin Landseer exhibited [Man Proposes, God Disposes](#) (1864), showing fearsome polar bears in the wreckage of a sailing ship. Novelists Charles Dickens and Wilkie Collins collaborated on a play, [The Frozen Deep](#) (1856), based on the tragedy, and in 1883 Arthur Conan Doyle published a horror short story, [“The Captain of the ‘Pole-Star,’”](#) about a ship that becomes trapped in polar ice. In *The North-West Passage*, the father and daughter appear to show concern over the fate of a loved one—son and brother—who has not yet returned from his mission. The small, framed image of a ship in ice

at the upper right and the old sailor's haunted stare suggest the dangers of the Admiralty's mission of global exploration in the service of expanding British trade.

However, despite the danger of finding the Northwest Passage, most contemporary viewers embraced the notion, which served as the caption for the Royal Academy catalog entry for *The North-West Passage*: "It might be done, and England should do it."⁵¹ Even knowing the fate of Franklin's crew, the British had not given up hope that they might be the ones to discover the route. Another Arctic expedition led by George Strong Nares set out in 1875, and because of the recent fame of *The North-West Passage*, Millais was invited to meet the sailors before they departed.⁵² It was not until 1905 that the first non-Inuit person successfully navigated the Northwest Passage by water. Unfortunately for British patriotic aspirations, it was Norwegian adventurer Roald Amundsen, not an Englishman, who finally discovered the route.



James Hamilton (artist) and John Sartain (engraver), *Entering Lancaster Sound*, from *The U.S. Grinnell Expedition in Search of Sir John Franklin, 1853*, one of the search parties sent after the failed Franklin expedition to find the Northwest Passage.

New York Public Library, Rare Book Division

Millais's painting makes plain that sacrifices would be necessary to cement British naval dominance in a globalizing and interconnected world. It underscores how the British public supported a widespread Victorian "appetite for Arctic glory."⁵³ While the Northwest Passage missions failed, the painting still stood as an emphatic statement of British naval power and a positive representation of the possibilities of colonial exploration. But, like most English people of his day, Millais failed to see the issue of colonization from the perspective of the colonized. In the twenty-first century, artists from around the former British Empire would push back on these narratives, inquiring about the long-term legacies of the empire and its zeal for travel.

SELECTED WORK: Lisa Reihana, *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]*, 2015

Lisa Reihana's *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]* is a video installation first exhibited in 2012 with the title *in Pursuit of Venus*. It represents customary lifeways of peoples throughout the Pacific Ocean world against an idealized backdrop of unspoiled nature. In later versions of the work, Reihana included images of contact between Indigenous people and white sailors, adding *[infected]* to the title to signify how, according to the artist, "Once people have encountered each other, history is changed forever...and that's the infection."⁵⁴ Reihana retells the story of British and French exploration in the Pacific through the complex interactions that resulted from initial moments of contact.

Lisa Reihana, born in 1964 in Auckland, New Zealand, is an internationally recognized filmmaker, photographer, performance artist, and member of the art collective the Pacific Sisters. Since the 1990s she has been known for her use of digital media to create work that examines and re-frames histories of empire. Reihana's work is informed by her identity as a Māori woman. The Māori are the Indigenous people of New Zealand, whose ancestors came from Polynesia in the northeast Pacific around 1200 CE.

Māori art and culture are performative with many sacred narratives and cultural structures expressed through dances and other rituals, focused on respect for ancestors, and strictly divided by gender. Māori

definitions of “art” are also very different from those in European traditions. For the Māori, objects, even ordinary ones, are imbued with sacred power or *mana*. This means that customary artistic productions of Māori culture, such as intricate wood carvings that adorn architectural spaces are seen to “create ancestors as real and immediate presences.”⁵⁵ All these elements appear, to different degrees, in Reihana’s *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]*.

in Pursuit of Venus [infected] has been displayed at many different global venues. These include the Auckland Art Gallery (2015), the [Venice Biennale](#) (2017), and the Royal Academy in London (2018), where Millais once exhibited *The North-West Passage*. The piece is a sixty-four-minute [looped video](#) representing more than 140 imagined vignettes of daily life for Indigenous Pacific men and women, alongside moments of contact with British sailors during the Age of Exploration. The installation is projected in a darkened room onto an eighty-foot-long, narrow screen with an accompanying soundtrack that includes nature sounds and songs or chants in various Pacific languages. The background is digitally rendered and resembles a painting of a “generic” Oceanic landscape, while the figures are video recordings of Māori, Aboriginal, and Pacific Islander actors performing everyday and ritual acts such as weaving, dancing, and storytelling, or meeting British travelers whose ships float at anchor in the background.



Lisa Reihana in 2022, after her investiture as a Companion of the New Zealand Order of Merit (CNZM), for services to the arts.

New Zealand Government, Office of the Governor-General

As the video plays, the scene slowly scrolls, exposing the viewer to an expansive and constantly shifting series of interactions, all stitched together seamlessly into one apparently endless vista. This moving horizontal format echoes a type of visual spectacle popular in Europe beginning in the eighteenth century, known as a **panorama**. Panoramas consisted of painted scenes in a [large-scale horizontal format](#), often representing faraway destinations or “exotic” locations as a form of vicarious travel. Some panoramas were installed in [specially built circular rooms](#) that allowed a truly immersive experience, while others used long canvases stretched between rotating rollers to create a sensation of motion and changing scenery.

Reihana’s inspiration for the composition of *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]* was a novelty wallpaper manufactured by the French company Dufour around 1805, with the title *Les sauvages de la mer Pacifique* (*The “Savages” of the Pacific Ocean*, usually now translated as *The Native Peoples of the Pacific Ocean*). This product emerged out of the voyages of exploration that European countries mounted to support commercial expansion and scientific discovery during the Age of Enlightenment. The artist of the wallpaper, Jean-Gabriel Charvet, based the large-format scenes on illustrations from books published by English and French explorers detailing their travels in Oceania. These included Captain James Cook’s multi-volume *Voyages* (1773–85), lavishly illustrated by [William Hodges](#) and [Sydney Parkinson](#), among other sources.

The wallpaper consisted of twenty individual scenes, each printed on a panel about eight feet high by a little

under two feet wide. When installed continuously, the wallpaper would create a seamless image more than thirty feet long. This wallpaper was just one of many products that exoticized the Pacific world for European consumers. It represented an idealized, sensuous, and beautiful Oceanic world that many European viewers found attractive. The Dufour wallpaper, its manufacturer wrote, was intended to “please the eye and to excite the imagination.”⁵⁶ In the present day, Reihana responded that the wallpaper, like other historic representations of Oceania, “claims to represent the Pacific, [but] the characters’ attire and the unfamiliar flora are unlike anything I associate with my Polynesian roots. This fascinating concoction was a fabulation located in someone else’s elsewhere.”⁵⁷ To create her alternate version of this European-constructed vision, Reihana worked with performers from Pacific communities who acted in the video, transforming “imperial fantasy” to “living performance.”⁵⁸

The element of performance is important to *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]* because it is an embedded aspect of Māori life. In 2003, UNESCO (the United Nations body tasked with protecting global art and cultural traditions) identified the need to preserve “intangible cultural heritage” as rigorously as physical art and architecture. Intangible cultural heritage is transmitted from generation to generation and includes cosmology (“knowledge ... concerning nature and the universe”), social practice, spoken language, music, and dance.⁵⁹ Reihana shows many of her actors performing customary dances and rituals, choreographed by Māori director Rachel House. She also depicts everyday artistic production such as weaving and carving, stitching together the tangible and intangible cultural practices of New Zealand and other Pacific cultures.

In the Māori language, *taonga*, meaning “prized possession,” can refer to both physical objects and cultural practices, all of which are protected by treaties with the modern nation of New Zealand. At the [Royal Academy](#) in London, *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]* was projected alongside art and artifacts from around the Pacific in an exhibition titled [Oceania](#). In response to this display, Reihana reflected on how histories of European collecting had stripped cultural objects of their power and importance, and how *Oceania* might re-energize them: “people are seeing these incredibly beautiful taonga, artefacts, and then



Amo (post figure) from a communal meeting house, Māori people, New Zealand, c. 1800.

Metropolitan Museum of Art, The Michael C. Rockefeller Memorial Collection, Bequest of Nelson A. Rockefeller, 1979



Jean-Gabriel Charvet and Joseph Dufour, Les Sauvages de la Mer Pacifique (original wallpaper), 1804–5.

Te Papa (Museum of New Zealand). Purchased 2015 with Charles Disney Art Trust funds.

they're seeing something that's brought to life" with *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]*.⁶⁰

The most disruptive scene in *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]* is the death of Captain Cook at the hands of native Hawaiians, which occurred in February 1779. Strangely, this violent interlude was also included in the background of panel eight on the original wallpaper, making this decorative item more complicated than it at first appears. Though the other nineteen panels showed an idealized representation of Oceanic life, the killing of Cook transforms the wallpaper from utopian décor to an “unsettling acknowledgement of the often-bloody conflicts involved in cross-cultural encounter.”⁶¹ Of course, it is impossible to know how many purchasers of the wallpaper actually chose to display this panel in their homes, but its inclusion suggests that even within positive depictions of global travel in the Age of Empire, currents of resistance were visible.

ARTISTS IN TRANSIT: BLENDING CULTURAL INSPIRATIONS

For many artists, global travel has been a way to gain inspiration and to blend their customs, traditions, and subject matter with those from other cultures. Especially in the nineteenth century and later, it became common for artists to travel to unlock their creativity and enrich the references, visual styles, or materials they used. This section discusses two

artists whose work was influenced by international travel. Both ended up returning home and making representations of their own backgrounds and experiences but were changed by the places they traveled to and what they learned there. While these travels were sometimes impacted by larger global issues, these artists deal less with geopolitical currents and more with how global flows of images and information affect personal identity and inner states of mind.

SELECTED WORK: Osman Hamdi Bey, *Young Woman Reading*, 1880

In a brightly lit room, a young woman kneels in front of a bookstand reading the Qur'an with her hands folded in her lap. She is wearing a fashionable nineteenth-century dress in pale yellow silk and a red-orange head covering. Behind her, a wall of repeating blue and white tiles creates a complex pattern, while at the left we glimpse the view through an elaborate metal screen onto a tree-filled garden. The bookstand is embellished with a mosaic of mother-of-pearl squares, and on top of it is laid an elaborate floral cloth. Sitting atop this cloth, we view one page of a decorated manuscript with writing in Arabic. *Young Woman Reading*, a representation of a modern, active, and educated Muslim woman from the late 1800s, is a product of its artist's journeys from Turkey to Paris and back home again.

The painter Osman Hamdi Bey led a fascinating life. Born in Istanbul in 1842, Hamdi was brought up in a highly educated and westernized household in the waning years of the Ottoman Empire. At its height in the

sixteenth century, the empire had stretched from North Africa to the Persian Gulf, encompassing present-day Turkey, Albania, Greece, Bulgaria, Serbia, and Romania, and parts of the modern nations of Hungary, Ukraine, and Moldova. By the mid-nineteenth century, the Ottoman Empire's power and influence had shrunk under pressure from European expansion into North Africa and West Asia. However, it was still an important global power, and its court had been shaped by hundreds of years of tradition.

Hamdi's father, İbrahim Edhem Pasha, rose from humble beginnings on the island of Chios. He was orphaned as a young child during the Greek War of Independence and then sold into slavery and eventually adopted by a powerful Ottoman admiral. Sent to France for his education, Edhem later became the French teacher to Sultan Abdulmeçid and was eventually elevated to the position of trade minister. In 1860, Edhem sent his teenaged son Osman Hamdi to Paris to attend law school. Instead of preparing for a legal career, Hamdi transitioned into artistic education under the instruction of [Gustave Boulanger](#). Hamdi's style was also inspired by Boulanger's friend and studio-mate [Jean-Léon Gérôme](#); both painters worked in the genre known as **Orientalism**.



J. Pascal Sébah, Osman Hamdi Bey, 1885.

Popular throughout Europe in the nineteenth century, Orientalist paintings represented an imagined, Western view of the customs, people, and places of what was popularly called “the Orient,” referring to the Muslim-majority regions of North Africa and the Middle East. Hamdi became one of the only known Muslim painters to produce work in a European Orientalist style. He first exhibited his work publicly at the Paris **Salon** in 1866, a now-lost painting listed in the catalog as *Femme turque* (*Turkish Woman*).⁶²

For Hamdi, learning to paint human anatomy by studying plaster casts, classical sculptures, and live models was an important component of his French training.⁶³ While some Islamic artistic traditions ban the depiction of the human figure, this is not true of all cultures. In the **hadith**, a collection of sayings attributed to the Prophet Muhammad, there is a proscription on making images of holy figures and living beings. However, interpretation and application of this have varied in different Muslim traditions across time periods.

Generally speaking, the late Ottoman court did not follow a prohibition on human representation and even encouraged the development of European-style figure painting. Sultans hired European artists [Ivan Aivazovsky](#) and [Stanisław Chlebowski](#); other Ottomans of Hamdi's generation painted the human figure in a Western style, including [Halil Pasha](#), Şeker Ahmed Pasha, and [Sarkis Diranian](#), an Armenian-Ottoman.⁶⁴ The Sakıp Sabancı Museum in Istanbul holds several of Halil's drawings of male and female models, showing his careful study of how to render the human form.⁶⁵ (Hamdi would have produced similar sketches as a student, though none of these have survived.)

In 1868, after spending eight years in France, Hamdi was posted to Baghdad as a government administrator.

He worked in administrative roles for the rest of his career, enabling him to use the honorific title **Bey**, which referred to a high-ranking Ottoman official. Hamdi is known today equally for his artistic works and for his eminent career as a museum director and archaeologist. In 1877, he was named the inaugural director of the Imperial Museum of Antiquities in Istanbul, which collected coins, sculpture, and other artifacts from ancient Anatolia. In 1884, Hamdi helped enact new export regulations, making it more difficult for foreign archeologists to export antiquities excavated on Ottoman soil. He was a “palace painter” (or court artist) to [Sultan Abdülhamid II](#) after 1880 and the founding director of Istanbul’s Academy of Fine Arts in 1882. Hamdi oversaw excavations that expanded the collections of the Imperial Museum, which he directed until his death in 1910.⁶⁶

Throughout this time, Hamdi pursued a career as a painter in the Orientalist style, showing scenes of everyday life in public and private spaces around Istanbul, often using himself and members of his family as models. Hamdi’s works are a calculated blend of Ottoman and French traditions. This helped produce a well-rounded vision of modern Turkish life, as seen in *Young Woman Reading*. Minutely detailed items of Ottoman material and religious culture, such as the Qur’an stand, carpet, metalwork, blue and white tiles, and incense burner, reinforce a sense of direct, observed reality. The painting celebrates a worshipper’s personal relationship with Islam and shows the study of religious texts as an important component of personal development for both genders.

Hamdi was part of a modernizing, progressive faction in the Ottoman government, but there is no indication that he was not a devout Muslim in his private life. He devoted several paintings to figures reading or discussing the Qur’an, including *Clerics Talking before a Mosque Entrance* (c. 1890) and [A Young Emir Studying](#) (1905). Hamdi also frequently represented women as active in modern Turkish life, showing them in public, appropriately veiled in *yashmak* (a gauzy head and face covering popular in the late Ottoman period) in works like [At the Mosque Door](#) (1890) or pursuing private pastimes like playing musical instruments, as seen in [Two Musician Girls](#) (1880).

But Hamdi’s paintings also spoke a “European” visual language, as the historian Edhem Eldem has outlined. The most frequent exhibition venues for Hamdi’s works were abroad: France, Germany, Britain, and the United States. It was not just the artist himself that was a world traveler; in the last two decades of the nineteenth century, his paintings circulated globally and were shown at venues such as the 1893 World’s Columbian Exposition in Chicago. Because of this international audience, Hamdi’s paintings took on a cross-cultural communicative role, offering themselves as correctives to the fantasies of Western Orientalist painters.⁶⁷

Orientalism in nineteenth-century Europe was less a style or movement than a set of ideas about how to represent the region known as “the Orient,” a term Europeans used to describe lands in North Africa, Anatolia, and the Middle East. Orientalist paintings often represent these areas as “exotic,” different from Europe in their customs, [clothing](#), colors, foods, and [religion](#). Orientalist paintings, whose audiences were middle-class and



Jean-Léon Gérôme, Prayer in the Mosque, 1871.

Metropolitan Museum of Art, Bequest of Catharine Lorillard Wolfe, 1887

elite consumers in Western Europe and the United States, tend to tell us more about the expectations of Europeans than they do about real life in the areas depicted. The paintings, taken as a group, create an imagined “Orient” that is seductive and gorgeous, locked in a [premodern past](#).

Orientalist paintings are visually appealing and highly detailed, often almost photorealistic, convincing audiences of their “truthfulness.”⁶⁸ But many Orientalist works depict [scenes](#) white male painters would never have been able to see—such as interactions taking place in the [harem](#), or female-only part of a private household—which tells us that these are works of imagination, not factual observation. Even the French occasionally conceded that the style was an [escapist fantasy](#). In response to the Paris Salon of 1864, the critic Jules-Antoine Castagnary scolded Orientalist painters for their desire to “run away from the world around them, to escape the ... real and the present.”⁶⁹

For Hamdi, an Ottoman Orientalist, paintings like *Young Woman Reading* offered an opportunity to make this view of “the Orient” more complex. As Zeynep Çelik argued in her article “Speaking Back to Orientalist Discourse,” Hamdi’s art reveals a “dialogue between cultures” rather than a one-sided imposition of European expectations. He used the sharp detail, alluring settings, and [“exotic” colors, fabrics, and textures](#) common in Orientalist painting to resist negative narratives created by Europeans and to present his subjects as “thinking, questioning, and acting human beings who display none of the [passivity and submissiveness](#) attributed to them by European painters.”⁷⁰

Young Woman Reading does this successfully. Instead of being scantily clad, the woman is modest and fashionable. Instead of [reclining on a couch or smoking hashish](#), she is educated and absorbed in study. Instead of being timeless, she exists in the modern world. Such elements are a product of Hamdi’s detailed knowledge of contemporary Ottoman life, filtered through his youthful education abroad and his ongoing correspondence with artists, museum professionals, archaeologists, and government officials all over the world.



Osman Hamdi Bey, The Scholar, 1878, an earlier image stressing scholarly and religious engagement, with a similar composition to A Young Emir Studying.

SELECTED WORK: Frida Kahlo, *Self-Portrait on the Borderline between Mexico and the United States*, 1932

Seventy years after Hamdi’s time in Paris, another artist painted an image marked by international travel. One of dozens of self-portraits by the Mexican painter Frida Kahlo, *Self-Portrait on the Borderline* reflects on the years Kahlo spent living in the United States. Like Hamdi, Kahlo was multilingual (speaking Spanish, English, and German) and was brought up in a household that prized education and the arts. Kahlo’s images of travel reflect on ideas of nation and homeland, self-image and identity.

Frida Kahlo was born in 1907 in Mexico City. Her mother was a descendent of Indigenous Indians and Spanish settlers, while her father was from a German Jewish family. Kahlo’s early life coincided with the Mexican Revolution that began in 1910. The revolution sought to enact social reforms that would turn Mexico into a republic, including abolishing systems of landownership that had overwhelmingly benefited Hispanic populations of European descent. Other reforms included providing legal protections for workers and establishing rights for Mexico’s Indigenous populations. In 1917, a new constitution outlined many of these

reforms, though the civil war went on through 1920.

Kahlo's life and work were marked by the political, social, and racial issues raised by the revolution: in her paintings she explored both [*mestizaje*](#), or the experience of being a mixed-race person, and [*indigenismo*](#), or the new Mexican interest in [*Indigenous life and heritage*](#). While studying at the National Preparatory School in her teens, Kahlo joined a radical group that supported the revolution's goal of a modern Mexico. She would later state that she wished to paint "something useful" to the "revolutionary movement," but her work's political potential was often deeply buried under layers of dreamlike imagery and personal symbolism.⁷¹

In addition to her family background and political experiences, Kahlo's life as a disabled woman also impacted her art. When she was eighteen, a city bus Kahlo was riding on was struck by a street trolley; the accident severely damaged her spine, pelvis, and right leg. Kahlo had already survived childhood polio, an infectious disease that can cause paralysis, and the traffic accident left her with chronic pain and limited mobility throughout the rest of her life. Some biographers suggest that the long period of recovery from the accident was when the young Kahlo began painting. The trauma provided ongoing subject matter for many self-portraits, in which she represented her body as [*fragile and vulnerable*](#).

Kahlo was self-trained and had no formal artistic education. Her inspirations came from ancient Mexican cultures such as the [*Aztec*](#) and [*Olmec*](#); seventeenth- and eighteenth-century [*paintings*](#) from the colonial era, when the Spanish taught Indigenous artists to copy prints of European religious art; [*Mexican folk art*](#); and the works of fellow avant-garde painters from Mexico and Europe.⁷² Despite her lack of artistic training, she became one of the most recognizable Mexican painters of the twentieth century, with a legacy that has marked art, fashion, and pop culture. The popular appreciation of Kahlo's unconventional beauty and her flair for [*fashionable ensembles*](#) has masked the serious nature of her work and her investigation into complex Mexican and Pan-American identities (understanding "Pan-American" to refer to a hemispherical identity that encompasses the Americas more broadly).

Mexico City was an important site of artistic innovation in the aftermath of the Mexican Revolution. European and American artists, writers, and photographers came to Mexico to be inspired by the revival of interest in pre-Columbian histories; these included the painters Josef Albers and [*Marsden Hartley*](#); photographers [*Edward Weston*](#), [*Tina Modotti*](#), and Robert Capa; and writers, including the British novelist D. H. Lawrence and André Breton, the French founder of Surrealism. Many interacted closely with Mexican painters and photographers, some of whom had also spent time studying in Europe.⁷³ This led to a major re-orientation of Mexican art in the 1920s and 1930s, as artists combined visual styles associated with European modernism and influences from the deep past.

The "big three"—[*José Clemente Orozco*](#), [*David Alfaro Siqueiros*](#), and Kahlo's husband [*Diego Rivera*](#)—led [*Mexican muralism*](#), which spread from Mexico City to include noteworthy commissions across North America. This artistic movement featured large-scale wall paintings that stressed Indigenous heritage and narratives as part of a new national history in postrevolutionary Mexico. While Rivera, Siqueiros, and Orozco



Toni Frissell, Frida Kahlo Standing Next to an Agave Plant, 1937.

Library of Congress Prints and Photographs Division

painted in this bold format, covering thousands of square feet of wall space, Kahlo painted small, intimate images, often on tin, echoing Mexican and Mexican American traditions of painting on scrap or recycled metal to produce **retablos**, small religious [images or altarpieces](#), mainly made for personal or household devotional use.

Only around twelve by fourteen inches, *Self-Portrait on the Borderline* shows Kahlo standing between two landscapes, the left representing Mexico while the right shows the United States, specifically the automobile manufacturing powerhouse of Michigan. Instead of the Indigenous Tehuana dress Kahlo dons in many of her self-portraits, here she wears a modern pink party dress and smokes a cigarette, situating her as an unambiguously twentieth-century woman. In many of her works, Kahlo shows [her self as divided](#) between her Indigenous and European roots, but here it is the landscape that is split.

To the left, an Aztec temple, crumbling with time, and Olmec ceramic figurines represent the Mexican past. Colorful flowers with deep roots suggest a new flourishing of ancient traditions, perhaps made possible by the post-Revolutionary attempt to uncover and celebrate Indigenous histories. Despite its dilapidation, the pyramid still stands, overseen by the sun and moon deities. By contrast, the side representing the United States is machinelike and repetitive, showing progress without any ties to deep human narratives. Instead of roots, power cords snake down into the earth from a fan, motor, and lamp. Smokestacks with the word “FORD” reference the Ford Motor Company, and their steam materializes into a United States flag that hovers in the sky above the artist’s head. In case Kahlo’s sympathies were not clear, she holds a small Mexican flag in her hand. This is an image rich with symbolism and critique. But it is also important to consider in view of the artist’s travels.

Frida Kahlo was married to fellow artist Diego Rivera for twenty-four years. Their tumultuous relationship was marked by his frequent infidelities with other women (they briefly divorced in 1939 before remarrying the following year). In the early 1930s, they spent nearly two years living and working abroad, including in Detroit, New York, and San Francisco. During that time, Kahlo painted several reflective pieces responding to her [experience](#) of living in the United States, including [My Dress Hangs There](#) (1933) and *Self-Portrait on the Borderline*, which was painted in Detroit.

The automaker Henry Ford had hired Rivera to paint a series of murals in the Detroit Institute of Arts, which became known as *Detroit Industry* (1932–33). The murals depict automotive production alongside pre-Columbian deities, suggesting a hopeful synthesis between ancient cultures and modern industrialization. Kahlo felt emotionally and culturally isolated while staying in Michigan. She even signed *Self-Portrait on the Borderline* as “Carmen Rivera,” combining her own given name with her husband’s last name, stressing that she was traveling on his business, not her own. While her husband celebrated the possibilities of American industry, travel allowed Kahlo to see the value of her own culture more clearly. Instead of showing herself divided between her Indigenous and European sides, Kahlo chose to represent herself unambiguously as a



Ceramic figure, Olmec, Mexico, 1000–400 BCE.

Metropolitan Museum of Art, The Michael C. Rockefeller Memorial Collection, Bequest of Nelson A. Rockefeller, 1979



Diego Rivera, *Detroit Industry*, north wall, 1932–33.

Detroit Institute of Arts. Gift of Edsel B. Ford

Mexican patriot. Indeed, as Lucy Havard writes, Kahlo returned from the United States “more passionate than ever to promote *mexicanidad* [Mexican identity] in her homeland.”⁷⁴

But there is some ambiguity in *Self-Portrait on the Borderline* that suggests the division is not as strong as we might at first think. Underground, the roots and power cords intertwine, suggesting a symbiotic relationship between the two nations. This rhizomatic connection also destabilizes the idea of a border: as we saw in Jaune Quick-to-See Smith’s *State Names*, borders are often arbitrary political designations. When the border between Mexico and the United States was fixed in the nineteenth century, it left many Mexicanos in the lands that became Texas, New Mexico, Arizona, and California. In this way, *Self-Portrait on the Borderline* may represent a more enmeshed Pan-American unity that crosses international borders. Ultimately, *Self-Portrait on the Borderline* does not show an unambiguous preference for Mexico over the United States but instead presents a more complex picture of shared histories.

Kahlo’s time in Detroit was an important turning point in her style. While she was in Michigan, she suffered a devastating miscarriage, represented in *Henry Ford Hospital* (1932), and the death of her mother. These events, though painful, led to a new complexity and depth in Kahlo’s paintings. Always rich with symbolism, her works became more layered and their range of references more eclectic and culturally diverse. This difficult period in her life led to a great artistic flowering over the next decade.

Kahlo’s work was not as appreciated in her lifetime as it is today. She had her first solo show in New York City in 1938 but did not have a solo exhibition in Mexico until 1953. By the late 1940s, the chronic pain caused by the bus accident in her youth was becoming worse. She underwent numerous unsuccessful surgeries on her spine, but her health declined dramatically after 1950. Kahlo passed away in 1954 at the age of just forty-seven years old. Despite her short career, the posthumous recognition of Kahlo’s work has firmly established her as one of the most recognizable and well-known artists in history.

MIGRATION AND MEMORY

The human experience is synonymous with migration. Whether they are large-scale migrations, such as those that settled Micronesia three thousand years ago, or one family's decision to move to a new location, migrations leave powerful emotional traces. Many artists have dealt with migration by thinking about individual people's experiences as they connect with larger historic forces driving migrations.

Danish artist Christian Krohg's dramatic painting [*Leiv Eirikson Discovering America*](#) (1893) chronicles the Viking need to find new areas of arable land to settle. In nineteenth-century America, the push westward was celebrated in paintings that emphasized European [American settlers'](#) resilience and ingenuity, while changes in Lakota [beadwork](#) practices marked the end of nomadic lifeways and the beginning of the reservation era. Created in the twentieth century, Dorothea Lange's iconic photograph [*Migrant Mother*](#) (1936) depicts a woman of white and Cherokee ancestry who was making her way from Oklahoma to California during the Great Depression, while Jacob Lawrence's painting series [*The Migration of the Negro*](#) (1940–41) represents push-and-pull factors leading millions of Black Americans to leave the rural South for new opportunities.

Photojournalists after World War II, including Henri

Cartier-Bresson, chronicled the lives of people displaced by the war as they sought to find their way home or to establish new homes. Twenty-first century photographers [Richard Mosse](#), Nilüfer Demir, and Alessio Paduano have continued to document stories of displacement and migration, whether because of wars, economic pressures, or extreme weather events.

Migrations lead to **diasporas**, or communities of people from particular countries, ethnic groups, or religious backgrounds who have left a homeland and settled all over the world. Members of these diasporic communities are patriotic members of their nations but may also cherish connections with others who hail from a shared homeland or background. Diasporic identities may include languages, traditions, foods, or even just a sense of belonging. For instance, Liverpool-born painters The Singh Twins collaborate on complex works inspired by traditional Indian miniature painting. Their practice is shaped by stories of migration and memories passed down by an older generation and represents experiences shared by many Britons of Indian, Bengali, and Pakistani heritage. In all these cases, migration is closely tied to both history (the official recounting of what happened) and memory (a more personal process of recounting and reflecting on experiences). History and personal memory become intertwined in our next featured work by the British artist Lubaina Himid.

SELECTED WORK: Lubaina Himid, *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced*, 1991

Lubaina Himid has worked across media including sculpture, painting, and installation. Her artworks deal with Black diasporic histories and with themes of migration. Himid was born on the Indian Ocean island of Zanzibar, part of the East African nation of Tanzania, in 1954. Her mother, who was white, was from England, while her father, of the Comoran ethnicity, came from Zanzibar. Her father died unexpectedly shortly after her birth, and Himid's mother relocated to London. *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced* reflects on her identity as a mixed-race person who grew up in Britain with ties to East Africa. The painting also references British art historical traditions and the UK's involvement in African migrations.

Himid's academic background contributes to her use of varied artistic and historical references: she has a degree in Theatre Design from Wimbledon College of Art in London and an MA in Cultural History from the Royal College of Art. Since the 1980s, Himid has been a prominent member of the UK's Black British Art Movement, which pushed for more visibility and opportunity for contemporary artists with ancestry from Africa and the Caribbean. Between 1986 and 1990, the London gallery she founded, the Elbow Room, was a key site for exhibiting work by up-and-coming Black and Asian artists. Himid is known for brightly colored paintings and large-scale installations featuring painted cutouts of figures, which she often deploys

with satirical humor. In 2017, Himid won the Turner Prize for the exhibitions [Navigation Charts](#) and [Invisible Strategies](#). She was the first woman of African descent to win this prestigious award.

Between the Two my Heart is Balanced shows two Black women in a boat speeding through choppy seas. The style of painting is simplified, focusing less on naturalistic representation than on colors, shapes, and the textures of the brushwork. There is no apparent means of navigation, but the two figures appear calm, even happy. The woman sitting at the right juggles two blue shapes between her hands; the artist describes the two women as ripping up maps and casting the fragments into the waves. The figure at the left, whose elongated head wrap causes her simplified profile to resemble an ancient Egyptian [wall relief](#), reaches into a stack of horizontal lines painted in thick stripes of ochre, dark red, black, and blue green, perhaps to pull out another map. By tossing these navigational guides away, the two women chart a perilous but exhilarating journey across the unknown depths of the sea, discarding the narratives of exploration implied by the maps. This painting contains references to British art history, the artist's own identity, and the historical patterns of migration, both forced and voluntary, that shaped the modern world.

The composition of *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced* is inspired by the London-based French artist James Tissot's [Portsmouth Dockyard](#) (1877), which shows a pleasure boat making its way through a busy English harbor with three figures seated at the rear: a Highland soldier between two fashionably dressed women. In her reworking, Himid replaces the male figure with the ambiguous pattern of horizontal lines, which appears simultaneously to represent a stack of maps, a length of brightly colored fabric (perhaps referencing Himid's mother, a textile designer), or the wake the boat leaves as it passes. Without the male figure, the two women are no longer prompted to rivalry or competition by his presence and are free to explore contented companionship or even love. (The figures are based on Himid and her partner at the time, Maud Sulter.⁷⁵) Himid's biography, including her birth abroad and her childhood in England, informs the sense of both displacement and equanimity in *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced*. The title may refer to the two women in the boat, to the two sides of Himid's family heritage, or to the two homelands she feels allegiance to, Britain and Zanzibar.

Himid was not the only British artist in the 1980s and 1990s to remake "classic" works of British painting by replacing white characters with Black figures or by [highlighting](#) the people of color who *do* appear. Himid noted: "The point I am often exploring *vis-à-vis* the Black experience is that of being so visible and different in the white Western everyday yet so very invisible and disregarded in the cultural, political or economic record or history."⁷⁶ Her work, and that of other Black British artists of her generation, brings those "disregarded" stories into the light by focusing on narratives of global diasporic identity. Sculptor



Lubaina Himid in 2022.

[Yinka Shonibare](#), painter [Sonia Boyce](#), and graphic artist [Barbara Walker](#) are among the contemporary artists who have engaged in similar tactics. All these artists use their work to call attention to the traditional invisibility of non-white narratives in British painting. Even further, they highlight the extent to which the elite life depicted in iconic English works like Thomas Gainsborough's [Mr. and Mrs. Andrews](#) (1749) or William Hogarth's series [Marriage A-la-Mode](#) (c. 1743) relied on the almost invisible operation of global capital, including the circulation of people in the transatlantic slave trade.

Many viewers have commented on the prevalence of the sea in Himid's art. Omar Kholeif, a curator and a friend of Himid's, wrote of the "immeasurable expanse of water" as a frequent motif in her work over decades, while the artist Hannah Black specifically noted the "frightening sea" of *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced*.⁷⁷

The threat of capsizing, especially as the painting doesn't show any oars or tiller to propel or steer the boat, troubles the feeling of calm on the faces of the two women. The sight of Black figures in a boat in a tempestuous sea might recall for many viewers another classic work of British painting, Joseph Mallord William Turner's *The Slave Ship* (1840). While Turner's painting explicitly shows the brutality of the slave trade, Himid references these historical events more subtly. In a caption for *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced*, the artist wrote: "How many died crossing the water?"⁷⁸

[Naming the Money](#) (2004), one of Himid's installations featuring life-sized cutout figures, more directly took on the theme of the "millions living unrepresented lives within the centuries-long institution of transatlantic slavery" by giving enslaved figures names and imagined backstories.⁷⁹ For many Caribbean, African American, and Black British people, the forced journey across the Atlantic Ocean during the period of the international slave trade has formed a central aspect of shared history and diasporic identity. Other major works by British artists reflecting on the legacy of the slave trade include Keith Piper's [Go West Young Man](#) (1987) and John Akomfrah's video project [Vertigo Sea](#) (2015).

But there are also uplifting currents in *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced*. While it references the slave trade of the eighteenth century, it is also a celebration of a new wave of twentieth-century migration. The arrival of [HMT Empire Windrush](#) in 1948 kicked off the "Windrush era," when large numbers of West Indians immigrated to the UK, followed by many other groups from around the former empire. As part of a series ominously titled "Revenge," *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced* actually presents migration as an act of strength, solidarity, and persistence. The artist wrote that the series' title is affirmative, not negative: "their revenge is that they are still here, they are still artists, that their creativity is still ... committed to change, to change for the good."⁸⁰



Joseph Mallord William Turner, *The Slave Ship*, 1840. An iconic example of British Romantic painting, the work focuses on the brutality of the slave trade between Africa and the Americas.

Museum of Fine Arts Boston

SECTION III SUMMARY

Exploration and Empire

- ◆ In 1492, Christopher Columbus landed in the “New World.” The consequence was a centuries-long process of colonization and cultural exchange.
- ◆ Art was an important part of imperial projects, prompting exploration of unknown territories, presenting national narratives, and reflecting on the legacies of global expansion.

SELECTED WORK: Sir John Everett Millais, *The North-West Passage*, 1874

- ◆ Sir John Everett Millais was the youngest student ever accepted to the Royal Academy. With William Holman Hunt and Dante Gabriel Rossetti, he founded the Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood, a group of progressive English artists. They dedicated themselves to close observation, rejecting Renaissance idealism.
- ◆ *The North-West Passage* references Britain’s naval power. It includes items associated with life on board ship, along with the British flag and a white naval ensign. The model, Edward John Trelawney, was a veteran of the Royal Navy.
- ◆ In the Age of Empire, Europeans searched for a northern water route from the Atlantic to the Pacific, known as the “Northwest Passage.” At the time of Millais’s painting, British explorers had been looking for this route for three hundred years.
- ◆ Several voyages of Arctic exploration ended in disaster. In 1845, Sir John Franklin captained the HMS *Erebus* and HMS *Terror* to seek the Northwest Passage. By 1854, it was reported that all 129 men on the mission had perished. This event inspired plays, poems, popular songs, and Millais’s painting.
- ◆ *The North-West Passage* blends patriotic symbolism with a narrative of sadness and anxiety, as family members wait for news of a loved one who is presumably on a similar voyage of naval exploration to the Arctic.
- ◆ Despite the danger involved in finding the Northwest Passage, most Britons considered

it a patriotic endeavor. It was the Norwegian adventurer Roald Amundsen, not an Englishman, who finally discovered the route.

SELECTED WORK: Lisa Reihana, *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]*, 2015

- ◆ Lisa Reihana is a Māori filmmaker, photographer, and performance artist.
- ◆ *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]* is a sixty-four-minute video representing more than 140 vignettes of daily life for Indigenous Pacific men and women, alongside moments of contact with British sailors during the Age of Exploration. The scrolling video is projected in a darkened room onto an eighty-foot-long, narrow screen.
- ◆ Reihana’s inspiration was a French novelty wallpaper from 1805. The wallpaper was based on illustrations from books by European explorers detailing travels in Oceania. This was one of many products that exoticized the Pacific world for European consumers.
- ◆ To create her alternate version of this European-constructed vision, Reihana worked with performers from Pacific communities. She shows them performing customary dances and rituals and depicts everyday artistic production such as weaving and carving.
- ◆ She also represents moments of encounter with British travelers, including the death of Captain James Cook at the hands of native Hawaiians in February 1779. This event was also depicted on the wallpaper that inspired the piece.
- ◆ *in Pursuit of Venus [infected]* shows a different side of global travel in the Age of Empire.

Artists in Transit: Blending Cultural Inspirations

- ◆ Global travel allows artists to gain inspiration and to blend their customs, traditions, and subject matter with those from other cultures, expanding the references, visual styles, or materials they use.

SELECTED WORK: Osman Hamdi Bey, *Young Woman Reading*, 1880

- ◆ Osman Hamdi Bey was brought up in a highly educated and westernized household in the

Ottoman Empire. In 1860, he went to Paris to attend law school, but instead he studied painting with a French artist. His teacher painted in the genre known as Orientalism.

- ◆ Orientalist paintings represented an imagined, Western view of the customs, people, and places of what was popularly called “the Orient,” referring to the Muslim-majority regions of North Africa and the Middle East.
- ◆ Hamdi became one of the only known Muslim painters to produce work in a European Orientalist style.
- ◆ After returning from France, he worked in many administrative roles, including as a museum director, archaeologist, and court artist to the sultan.
- ◆ Hamdi’s paintings represent everyday life in public and private spaces around Istanbul, often using himself and members of his family as models. Hamdi’s works blend Ottoman and French elements.
- ◆ *Young Woman Reading* celebrates a worshipper’s personal relationship with Islam and shows the study of religious texts as an important component of personal development for both genders, a common theme in Hamdi’s work.
- ◆ *Young Woman Reading* uses elements of European Orientalism, such as the sharp detail, alluring settings, and “exotic” colors, fabrics, and textures common in French Orientalist painting. However, Hamdi’s representation of a modest, educated, and modern Muslim woman resists the negative narratives often created by European artists.

SELECTED WORK: Frida Kahlo, *Self-Portrait on the Borderline between Mexico and the United States*, 1932

- ◆ Kahlo was born in 1907 in Mexico City. Her life and work were marked by the Mexican Revolution that began in 1910: her art explored both *mestizaje*, or the experience of being a mixed-race person, and *indigenismo*, or the post-revolutionary interest in Indigenous life and heritage.

- ◆ Kahlo had no formal artistic education. Her inspirations came from ancient Mexican cultures, paintings from the colonial era, Mexican folk art, and fellow avant-garde painters.
- ◆ Mexico City was an important site of artistic innovation after the revolution, which led to a re-orientation of art in the 1920s and 1930s. The “big three”—José Clemente Orozco, David Alfaro Siqueiros, and Kahlo’s husband Diego Rivera—led Mexican muralism. In contrast with their large works, Kahlo painted small, intimate images, often on tin.
- ◆ *Self-Portrait on the Borderline* shows Kahlo standing between two landscapes, the left representing Mexico while the right shows the United States. The Mexican landscape is dominated by natural imagery and symbols of history, while the United States focuses on industrialization and consumerism.
- ◆ *Self-Portrait on the Borderline* was painted while Kahlo was living in Detroit, Michigan. The automaker Henry Ford had hired her husband Diego Rivera to paint a series of murals in the Detroit Institute of Arts. She felt emotionally and culturally isolated in Detroit. In *Self-Portrait on the Borderline*, Kahlo chose to represent herself as a Mexican patriot.
- ◆ However, underground roots connecting the two sides of the painting also suggest a symbiotic relationship between the United States and Mexico. *Self-Portrait on the Borderline* may represent a Pan-American unity that crosses international borders.

Migration and Memory

- ◆ Artists have dealt with migration by thinking about individual people’s experiences as they connect with larger historic forces driving migrations.
- ◆ Migrations lead to diasporas, or communities of people from particular countries, ethnic groups, or religious backgrounds who have left a homeland and settled all over the world. Members of diasporic communities may cherish connections with others who hail from a shared background.

SELECTED WORK: Lubaina Himid, *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced*, 1991

- ◆ Lubaina Himid's art deals with Black diasporic histories and with themes of migration. Himid was born in Zanzibar to a white English mother and a Comoran father from Zanzibar. In 2017, Himid was the first woman of African descent to win the Turner Prize.
- ◆ *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced* reflects on her identity as a mixed-race person who grew up in Britain with ties to East Africa.
- ◆ *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced* shows two Black women in a boat speeding through choppy seas, tearing up maps as they go. They chart a perilous but exhilarating journey, discarding the narratives of exploration implied by the maps.
- ◆ The composition is inspired by James Tissot's *Portsmouth Dockyard*, which shows a pleasure boat making its way through a busy English harbor. Himid removes the male figure from the original composition to focus on female relationships.
- ◆ With its depiction of a journey by boat, Himid's painting references the historical trade in enslaved Africans, but it also celebrates twentieth-century histories of Black migration to the United Kingdom. *Between the Two my Heart is Balanced* presents migration as an act of strength, solidarity, and persistence.

⇒ SECTION IV ⇐

Traveling For Pleasure

While the previous sections dealt with traveling for the sake of exploration or imperial expansion, this section looks at a relatively modern phenomenon—vacation. A religious pilgrimage might take the traveler away from their everyday life, but its goal was enlightenment, worship, or contemplation, not pure enjoyment. In the modern era, we see the development of a leisure travel industry that encourages voyagers to enjoy themselves, see the world, appreciate natural scenery, or simply relax. The images in this section show how traveling for pleasure has, and has not, changed over the past few centuries.

MODERN NATURE TOURISM

One important component of traveling for pleasure is the opportunity it gives tourists to appreciate the

natural landscape. In the modern era, roughly the mid-1700s to the present, “nature” has come to be defined as something separate from the realm of human endeavor. As the world grows more urban and industrialized, people become separated from the nature that once was all around them and determined the rhythms of their lives. Instead of being an integral part of daily practice, nature has become something people use to escape from the experience of being a modern, urban person: “to get away from it all.” Over the past several centuries, artists have shown nature as something refreshing and rejuvenating to mind, body, and spirit. It may also represent spectacles of national pride or evoke feelings of sublime grandeur.

SELECTED WORK: Utagawa Hiroshige, *New Fuji, Meguro*, from *One Hundred Famous Views of Edo*, 1857

Mount Fuji is one of the most recognizable sites in Japan. In the 1700s and 1800s, tourism to Mount Fuji intensified as religious pilgrimage was supplemented by a new focus on touristic travel in modern Japan. Utagawa Hiroshige was one of the best-known artists of the period, with a focus on images of noteworthy locations around the country. He was born Andō Tokutarō in 1797. When he was orphaned around the age of fourteen, he began studying painting under the master Utagawa Toyohiro, whose surname he adopted. A few years later, he began signing his work simply as “Hiroshige,” the name he is known under today.

Hiroshige started producing landscapes around 1830 and was one of the most prolific artists of the period, making an estimated eight thousand images over the course of his thirty-year career. His student Suzuki Chinpei (who signed his work “Hiroshige II”) continued producing images from many of his teacher’s series after Hiroshige’s death in 1858.⁸¹ In *New Fuji, Meguro*, Hiroshige used a relatively new form of mass-produced travel image that was typical of Japan in the mid-1800s: a colored print.

These prints emerged in the 1700s in the Japanese city of Edo, which became known as Tokyo after 1868. They are a form of visual arts that flourished during the Edo period (1603–1868), during which Japan was under the military control of the Tokugawa family. In this era, Japan became one of the most literate and urban societies in the world. It was also a period of expanded travel for pleasure. Written travel guides introduced readers to noteworthy sites, historical events, and natural wonders. The center of publishing

was the Nihonbashi district of Edo, where nearly three dozen bookstores and print shops sold their wares. From illustrations supplementing written guidebooks, prints expanded to become their own important form of Japanese art by the mid-1700s.

Hiroshige's prints were part of the genre known as ukiyo-e, which translates to “pictures of the floating world.” The term *ukiyo-e* refers to the subject matter that was popular with an educated, urban audience in late Edo-era Japan, which included scenes of tea houses and tea house hostesses, celebrities such as actors and sumo wrestlers, representations of annual festivals and celebrations, and scenic views around cities and the countryside. Erotica and religious and folkloric imagery were also important sub-genres of *ukiyo-e*. These images could be made using several techniques including drawing, painting, or printing.

The method used to make Hiroshige's *New Fuji, Meguro* was a multicolor woodblock printing process known in Japan as nishiki-e. Woodblock is a relief printing process. The design is drawn onto a wooden block, and the areas that the artist does not want printed are cut away, leaving a raised design that can be inked (like a rubber stamp). Translating to “brocade pictures,” *nishiki-e* specifically refers to multi-colored prints of *ukiyo-e* subjects. Each color required a separate block, and impressions had to be carefully aligned to ensure a high-quality final image. *Nishiki-e* were influenced by imported images from Europe and sometimes used Western pictorial techniques like linear perspective alongside traditional Japanese forms of representation.

Producing a print required cooperation among an artist (who drew the original design), block cutters (who carved the blocks), printer (who inked and aligned the blocks), and publisher (who arranged for sale and distribution). The prints required extensive skill and patience to produce, but once an image was perfected, publishers could market large print runs of up to ten or fifteen thousand copies. This mass scale meant that prints were affordable commodities for consumers and were widely available. Prints were often issued in thematically focused portfolios, in which images could be purchased individually or as a series. Some famous examples are Katsushika Hokusai's [*Thirty-Six Views of Mount Fuji*](#) (c. 1830–32) and Hiroshige's [*Fifty-Three Stations of the Tōkaidō*](#) (1833–34). The print *New Fuji* is from Hiroshige's series [*One Hundred Famous Views of Edo*](#) (1856–59), which shows festivals, urban daily life, and natural wonders around the capital.⁸²

The chosen print from this series, *New Fuji, Meguro*, shows the increasing Japanese interest in nature tourism in the mid-nineteenth century. Mount Fuji, about sixty miles outside Tokyo, is the tallest point in Japan. It is easily recognizable due to its pleasingly symmetrical low conical shape, a remnant of many volcanic eruptions (the last was in 1707). Mount Fuji has become a symbol of Japanese national identity and a focus of religious practice, attracting male pilgrims from the Shugendō branch of Buddhism and the



Utagawa Kunisada I, Memorial Portrait of Utagawa Hiroshige, 1858.

Art Institute of Chicago, Clarence Buckingham Collection

local Fujikō sect. (Women could participate in pilgrimages, but only after an extremely rigorous period of purification, and they were not allowed to ascend all the way to the summit.)

Starting in the twelfth century, an infrastructure of roads, roadside shrines, and hostels grew to accommodate these pilgrims. Most of the traffic to Fuji for the next six hundred years was religious, much of it aimed at appeasing deities to prevent further eruptions. However, in the Edo period, the mountain came to be viewed less prominently as a religious site and more as a “national” symbol of Japan, solidifying nearby Edo as the new capital. In Hokusai’s *Thirty-Six Views of Mount Fuji*, the mountain appears at [all times of year](#), in various [scales](#), from various [angles](#). In these scenes, Fuji is sometimes presented as a sacred site but often simply as a part of the landscape (as in [Under Mannen Bridge at Fukagawa](#)). In the later nineteenth century, Mount Fuji increasingly transformed into a site of recreation and leisure.⁸³

The representation of Mount Fuji in *One Hundred Famous Views of Edo*, as the series title implies, focuses more on touristic appreciation of the mountain from a distance. Located rather far outside Edo, the mountain was challenging to climb, and many people often viewed it casually from the city instead of making the difficult multi-day journey. In *New Fuji*, Meguro, Hiroshige shows viewers looking at Mount Fuji from one of several specially constructed platforms scattered around the Edo suburbs.

At the base, tourists take refreshment from tea stands or stroll among blooming cherry trees. Women, elderly people, and children are present as tourists, though all three groups would have been excluded from participating in religious pilgrimages to the mountain. Hiroshige shows the snow-covered top of Fuji, many miles away but clearly visible in the otherwise relatively flat landscape. However, the careful viewer might notice something odd about the platform the tourists are standing on: it is shaped like Mount Fuji itself, and as the print’s title implies, is a “new Fuji.”⁸⁴

Many of the newly constructed viewing platforms, or “mini-Fujis,” mimicked the iconic shape of Fuji’s volcanic cone and even featured zigzagging paths that resembled the [path](#) pilgrims hiked up the *real* Fuji. The first replica was built in 1779 and throughout the Edo period more than one hundred of these mini-Fujis were constructed. The one shown in *New Fuji* was built at Meguro in 1819. The original intention was to make “ascending” Fuji easier and more democratic, as one text from 1818 noted: “Mount Fuji is so high that even in the case of men, those with a weak heart fall ill ... How much harder then is it for women ... And it is arduous also for the very young and the old to climb Fuji.” With the new replicas, however, “men, women, young and old could set their hearts at peace.”⁸⁵ Those visiting the mini-Fujis on festival days could buy snacks and souvenirs and enjoy views of Mount Fuji in their everyday garments (rather than special white



Torii Kiyonaga, Yushima, from the series *Scenes of Ten Teahouses*, c. 1783. A nishiki-e print showing an interaction in an urban tea house, typical of the ukiyo-e genre.

Art Institute of Chicago, Gift of Mr. and Mrs. James A. Michener

pilgrimage robes). In drawings and prints, artists Hiroshige, [Hasagawa Settan](#), and Kobayashi Eijirō showed the festive atmosphere of tourists mingling at the base of mini-Fujis while spectators climbed to the top to appreciate the view of the real thing.

Far from dominating the landscape, in *New Fuji*, *Meguro*, the volcano's size is matched by its mini “twin,” the artificial replica. As viewers of the print, we are treated to Hiroshige's playful treatment of scale, seeing the replica and the mountain juxtaposed at an apparently similar size.

Is the “famous view of Edo” the image of Mount Fuji—arguably the most famous sight in all Japan? Or is it a more self-referential notion that *nishiki-e* prints themselves fed a growing tourist culture, leading to the creation of proxy viewing points that allowed city-dwellers to frame the perfect view of Fuji from a distance?



Mount Fuji, Japan, seen from Ōwakudani.

The Fuji replicas of the 1800s were built to accommodate the large numbers of viewers who wanted to, but could not, ascend the sacred mountain. Today, Mount Fuji experiences a radical intensification of the tourism that led to the popularity of the “New Fujis” during the Edo period. In 2013 Fuji was recognized as a UNESCO World Heritage Site, which prioritizes global landmarks of historic and cultural significance for conservation. However, the estimated 300,000 tourists who hiked Mount Fuji annually in the 2010s (almost all of whom visited during a ten-week period in the summer) created an almost impossible challenge for preserving it as “an object of outstanding universal value and an integral part of the natural heritage of the Japanese archipelago.”⁸⁶

In 2024, Shizuoka and Yamanashi Prefectures, which share responsibility for Fuji, took steps to severely limit the number of tourists to Mount Fuji, implementing a ¥4000 fee (around \$25 to \$30), earlier closing times, required reservations, and restrictions on the number of reservations that will be issued each day.⁸⁷ In spite of restrictions like these at sites around the world, nature tourism continues to be a huge business. Maybe a return to the Fuji replicas of the 1800s would allow tourists to get their perfect Instagram shot without leaving their trash behind or eroding the centuries-old paths to the summit.

SELECTED WORK: Charles Whittlesey, El Tovar Hotel, South Rim of the Grand Canyon, Arizona, 1905

Seeing the views is just one part of nature tourism. You also have to get to where you are going and figure out how you are going to eat and sleep in between your encounters with the wonder of the wilderness. In the American context, there was a long history of hotels that catered to tourists trying to escape their urban lives to replenish and rejuvenate in natural settings. The string of hotels developed by Fred Harvey and his heirs in the Southwest from the 1880s through the 1930s was the culmination of American traditions that stretched back a century. One of the most dramatic



Frederic Edwin Church, Niagara, 1857.

National Gallery of Art, formerly in Corcoran Collection

constructions sponsored by Harvey's company was El Tovar Hotel, located on the rim of the Grand Canyon, which was completed in 1905. This location was part of the hotel's appeal, as it catered to tourists primarily interested in appreciating the dramatic natural wonders of North America.

The United States has always seen itself as a nation defined by its spectacular natural features. In the 1830s, one of the earliest important American art movements was the Hudson River School of painting, led by landscape artists [Thomas Cole](#), [Asher B. Durand](#), [Jasper Francis Cropsey](#), and others. Loosely connected with the literary movement of Transcendentalism, which focused on intellectual communion with and appreciation of nature, these artists framed American scenery as capable of inspiring intense emotional responses in viewers. They succeeded in creating a popular taste for landscape painting among middle-class patrons of art and helped spur the creation of a tourist infrastructure based around appreciating the landscape.



Thomas Moran, The Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone, 1893–1901. A later version of a painting Moran made after the U.S. Geological Survey in 1871, it shows the dramatic colors and sublime landscapes of the American West.

Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of George D. Pratt

The [Catskill Mountain House](#), for example, perched above the Hudson River, was a popular resort that catered to travelers and artists interested in seeking out spectacular views. On the other side of New York State, Niagara Falls increasingly became a tourist attraction, its fame spread by paintings including Frederic Edwin Church's *Niagara* (1857). Such artworks relied on **sublime** visual effects. Sublime elements in landscape painting are techniques that evoke the way natural wonders fill viewers with awe and make us feel small and insignificant. In Church's painting, these effects include the sensations of great height, the thundering cascade of sound, and the general feeling of awe and danger a viewer might feel when experiencing a sight like Niagara Falls.

By the later part of the nineteenth century, the focus of landscape painting had shifted away from the East Coast to the dramatic scenery of the American West and Southwest. Artist Thomas Moran, who accompanied the 1871 geological survey party, produced spectacular paintings like *The Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone* (1872) that helped make eastern audiences aware of the massive scale, fantastic colors, and unfamiliar geological formations of the West. The completion of the first transcontinental railroad in 1869, followed by the expansion of other existing railway lines in the 1870s, meant that it was becoming relatively easy for travelers from all over the country to experience these geological wonders for themselves. Railway companies like the Atchison, Topeka & Santa Fe expanded their networks to include transportation, lodging, and food, the better to create a captive audience of consumers.

Entrepreneur Fred Harvey was born in London in 1835. As a teenager he immigrated to the United States, apparently on his own, and by age thirty he was working as a freight agent for a railway company in Leavenworth, Kansas. His job required frequent travel, and Harvey saw a business opportunity in the poor quality of the food available at railroad stations in the Midwest. Food was cold, preparation was unsanitary, and seating was poor or nonexistent. Harvey came up with the idea to serve affordable but good quality food in a sit-down dining environment. In 1876 he reached an agreement with the Atchison, Topeka & Santa Fe Railroad and opened his first "Harvey House" restaurant in the Topeka depot. By 1882, the company gave him an exclusive license to operate its existing rail-side hotels and to develop more hotels along the popular tourist rail line that ran from the Midwest to New Mexico. By the time of his death in 1901, Harvey had opened more than forty hotels and restaurants; his sons took over the company, which continued expansion

up through World War II. The Harvey company is considered the first hospitality chain in America.⁸⁸

The Harvey Company and its partner Atchison, Topeka & Santa Fe Railroad aggressively marketed travel to the Southwest by building tourist accommodations directly alongside their main rail line. The hotels were intended to serve as dramatic landmarks on a tourist's westward journey, and architects designed them using an eclectic variety of historic references, including [Moorish](#), [Spanish Colonial](#), Baroque, [Pueblo](#), and Navajo. Through a combination of these fantastical designs and an interior decoration scheme overseen by Mary E. Colter, Harvey hotels presented a vision of the American Southwest as rustic and exotic while also offering travelers convenience and predictability. Starting in 1902, Colter accessorized public areas with local Native American handicrafts, and several Harvey hotels started selling package tours to nearby towns where tourists could buy directly from artisans (known as Harvey's "Indian detours").⁸⁹ While most hotels were built immediately adjacent to railway stations on the main line, El Tovar, arguably the company's most spectacular investment, was built on a spur line overlooking the majestic views of the Grand Canyon.



Fred Harvey.

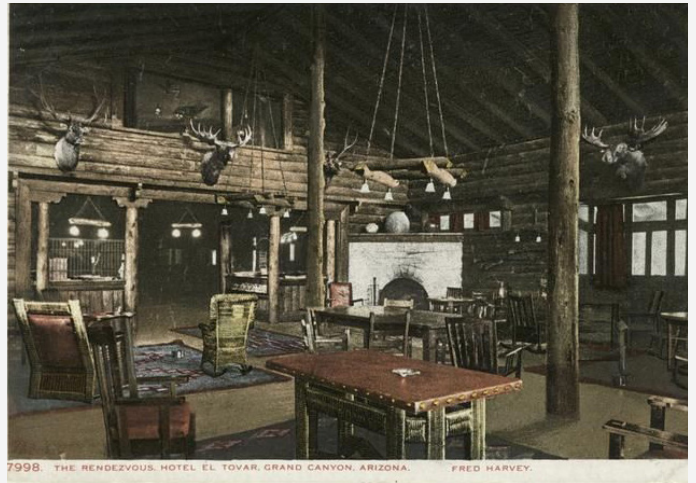
The Atchison, Topeka & Santa Fe Railroad built the Grand Canyon spur line in 1901, and the next year it commissioned El Tovar Hotel with a budget of \$250,000. The company tapped in-house architect Charles Whittlesey to design the hotel. Originally from Chicago, in the 1890s Whittlesey had worked for the architect Louis Sullivan, who also employed a young Frank Lloyd Wright around the same time. Like his more famous counterpart, Whittlesey made use of natural materials and showed an awareness of how buildings harmonize with the surrounding landscape.

The sprawling hotel, which took three years to complete, had nearly a hundred guest rooms, music and entertainment rooms (the latter featuring card tables, billiards, and shuffleboard), a men's spa offering shaves, haircuts, and massages, and "the most artistic dining room in the Southwest."⁹⁰ Its state-of-the-art amenities included hot and cold running water, electric lighting, and a Western Union telegraph office for sending messages. Its exterior, built of pine wood and "native boulders" was rustic in appearance, combining elements of a Swiss chalet, or alpine lodge, and what its promotional materials called a "Norway villa," probably a reference to the extensive use of wood siding that resembled that of log cabins. The interior contained furniture in the popular Arts and Crafts style, exposed ceiling beams, rugged wood paneling, and decorative accents that included Navajo "curios" and taxidermized local game specimens.⁹¹ But no one would stay at El Tovar just to partake of these amenities: its entire purpose for existing was its proximity to the Grand Canyon, a growing area of tourism, soon to be a national park.

"No one can describe the Grand Canyon to you. It must be seen," began a promotional brochure for El Tovar published in 1909, the year after President Theodore Roosevelt declared the canyon a National Monument. It

continued a few pages later: “El Tovar commands a prospect without parallel in the world. A perpendicular mile from rim to river (seven miles by trail) and thirteen dizzy miles across to the opposite canyon wall.”⁹² At more than 270 miles long, the Grand Canyon is one of the most spectacular geological features in North America. Given its name by survey party leader John Wesley Powell in the 1870s, within a decade the Grand Canyon had become one of the most popular tourist destinations in the United States.

Where earlier generations had praised the sublime qualities of Niagara Falls, the Grand Canyon’s sheer massiveness gave new meaning to the term “sublime.” El Tovar was built to capitalize on this reputation and to provide travelers from all over the world with a cozy spot from which to survey the grandeur of nature. In 1919, Congress officially created Grand Canyon National Park, and in 1979 the canyon was declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site. El Tovar was designated a National Historic Landmark in 1987 and is one of the few original Harvey hotels still in operation. Today, around 4.5 million people visit Grand Canyon National Park each year.⁹³



Postcard of the “Rendezvous” Lounge at the El Tovar Hotel, 1903–04.

New York Public Library, Miriam and Ira D. Wallach Division of Art, Prints and Photographs

IMAGES AS SOUVENIRS OF TRAVEL: FROM THE ELITE TO THE EVERYDAY

When journeying to new places, travelers have long enjoyed bringing home a souvenir to remind them of their trips. For medieval religious pilgrims these might include a small [lead badge](#) (inexpensive and mass-produced in molds) they could pin to their clothing. Starting in the eleventh century, Hajjis (those who undertake the pilgrimage to Mecca) often

commissioned [scrolls](#), sometimes lavishly decorated with calligraphy, that certified they had completed the pilgrimage; in the modern era these take the form of printed Hajj certificates. Secular journeys, too, often prompted travelers to bring home something that would allow them to think back on their trip. This section looks at how changes in recording media—from painting to photography—allowed ever greater numbers of travelers the opportunity not just to purchase souvenirs but, eventually, to make their own images of their voyages.

SELECTED WORK: Canaletto, *The Square of Saint Mark's, Venice*, 1742/44

During what appears to be a sunny, breezy day, dozens of people go about their ordinary business in the largest and most famous public square in Venice: Piazza San Marco or St. Mark's Square. *The Square of Saint Mark's, Venice* shows close observation of everyday life along with the details of the buildings that line the square. Thinly applied oil paint and precisely gridded lines give the work the appearance of an architectural drawing, but the artist also pays careful attention to the poses and gestures of the people in the scene, mostly grouped together in twos and threes as they discuss, stroll, shop, debate, and look after their children. This image is one of around five hundred [vedute](#), or “views,” made by the Venetian painter Canaletto, which were marketed as souvenirs for wealthy tourists in the eighteenth century.

The painter known as Canaletto was born Giovanni Antonio Canal in Venice, Italy, in 1697. His father was

a painter of theatrical scenery, who taught him the basics of art and perspective. He first served in his father's workshop painting backdrops for opera productions. In early 1720, they completed a major commission in Rome; while there, Canaletto was exposed to ancient Roman, Renaissance, and contemporary art and architecture. When he returned home to Venice later the same year, Canaletto joined the Venetian painters' guild and began his career painting landscapes.

Canaletto specialized in [urban scenes](#), which he rendered with extreme precision; the buildings in his images appear [sharp and almost photographic](#). It is possible Canaletto used a portable optical device to help him produce on-the-spot drawings of the relative position and main features of buildings. He would then work these into finished images, adding groups of figures to create narrative interest. In his work after 1730, as seen in *The Square of St. Mark's, Venice*, he developed a “calligraphic shorthand of blobs, curves, and rigid short lines” to quickly evoke human figures.⁹⁴ Between 1725 and 1740, Canaletto built a reputation for these highly realistic views embellished with vignettes of human interest to give them more liveliness and variety.

Starting in the late 1720s, Canaletto developed a lucrative business relationship with British banker and diplomat Joseph Smith. Smith introduced Canaletto to prospective clients and brokered deals between the painter and English-speaking travelers who came to Venice. These “*milordi inglesi*” or English gentlemen, were enthusiastic consumers of his *vedute*. Canaletto then spent nine years in London (1746–55) working for wealthy patrons and producing views of the [River Thames](#) and other [London landmarks](#). He came back to Venice in 1756 and passed away there in 1768. Canaletto spawned many Venetian imitators, including [Bernardo Bellotto](#) and [Francesco Guardi](#). While Venice is considered the birthplace of the genre, *vedute* paintings were also common in other major tourist spots in Italy. [Giovanni Paolo Panini](#), Canaletto's contemporary in Rome, painted “views” for wealthy English clients, many of whom were visiting Italy as part of what became known as the **Grand Tour**.⁹⁵

The first use of the term “Grand Tour” in English was in Richard Lassels's 1670 book *Voyage of Italy*. Generally, historians and art historians use the phrase “Grand Tour” to describe a fashion common among elite, educated men during the late seventeenth through nineteenth centuries: an extended tour through France and Italy studying classics, history, language, art, and architecture. While we might think of a “tour” as lasting just a few weeks, Grand Tours usually lasted at least six months and usually closer to a year or more.

By the early eighteenth century, taking a Grand Tour was seen as a rite of passage for young British aristocrats. As a shared, social activity, it helped solidify elite class consciousness in a period when the British class system was starting to erode due to the Industrial Revolution. It also promoted very particular ideas about aesthetics. Accompanied by tutors who helped them interpret the art and architecture they saw, Grand Tourists were expected to develop an informed artistic eye and taste driven by the art that was most admired at that time:



Canaletto, as shown in Antonio Maria Visentini's double portrait of Canaletto and himself, 1735 (detail).

Metropolitan Museum of Art, Gift of David and Elizabeth Tunick, 1991

ancient Greek and Roman sculpture and architecture, and Italian Renaissance and Baroque painting.

Among the British aristocracy, the Grand Tour was seen as the finishing touch to a young man's education. In addition to study, it was often an opportunity to purchase historical and contemporary art. Because of its status as an isolated island nation, Britain had a relatively modest art history of its own. But mainland Europe seemed to possess an almost endless supply of antiquities and paintings that wealthy tourists could bring home with them. Grand Tourists used their voyages to stock their ancestral homes with classical statuary fragments and Renaissance paintings. They also flocked to commission portraits of themselves by popular contemporary artists like [Pompeo Batoni](#) or [Rosalba Carriera](#) and actively collected modern "view" paintings, not so much for their artistic worth, but for their

value as symbols of a successfully completed tour: a shared experience they could reminisce over with fellow aristocrats once they were back home in England.⁹⁶

Venice was a necessary stop on most Grand Tours beginning in the late seventeenth century. Though it didn't boast the classical remnants of Rome or the Renaissance legacy of Florence, this city on the Adriatic drew English visitors because of its distinctive entertainments and its labyrinthine networks of canals snaking through 118 manmade islands. Its colorful and intricate architecture was a focus of much touristic enjoyment. In *The Square of St. Mark's, Venice*, Canaletto carefully detailed the splendid pink marble edifice of the ducal palace, with its pointed Gothic arches and quatrefoil stone tracery. Next door, he painted the elaborate mosaic-encrusted façade and bulbous domes of the eleventh-century St. Mark's Basilica.

At the right of the image, the winged lion of St. Mark, elevated on a column above the square, and the piazza's frontage onto the Grand Canal stress Venice's unique setting and civic pride. At the market stalls in the foreground, shoppers browse a distinctively Venetian product: brocade textiles. Along with its art and architecture, Venice's performative culture drew many British tourists. Ducal ceremonies, annual festivals, and dramatic masquerades turned the whole city into a stage, a vibe that appealed to British travelers,

who saw Venice as a romantic site of intrigue and freedom from social constraints.⁹⁷ Though this atmosphere is less evident in *The Square of St. Mark's, Venice*, Canaletto's training as a dramatic scenery painter was apparent in his many renderings of regattas and masked carnival-goers, such as [A Regatta on the Grand Canal](#) (c. 1740).

The Square of St. Mark's, Venice was purchased as a souvenir by an English Grand Tourist, probably Henry Howard, the 4th Earl of Carlisle. Both Henry and his son Frederick, who became the 5th Earl of Carlisle in 1758, completed a Grand Tour of Italy, and both brought back large picture collections. At least ten Canaletto paintings were on display in their family seat, Castle Howard, by 1745, where



Katherine Read, *British Gentlemen in Rome*, c. 1750.

Yale Center for British Art, Paul Mellon Collection



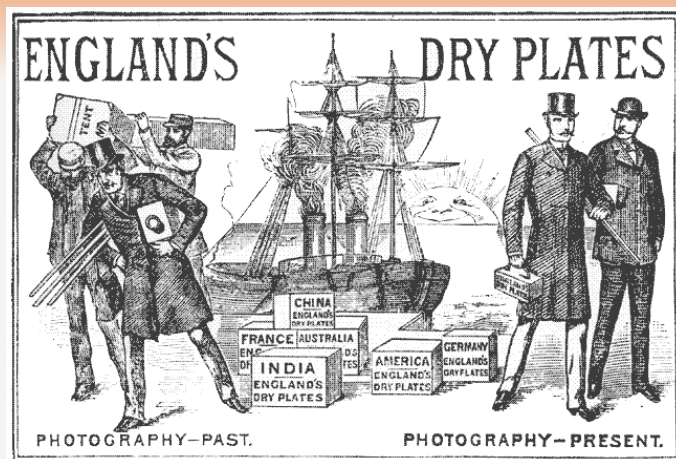
Canaletto, *The Grand Canal, Venice, Looking Southeast, with the Campo della Carità to the Right*, 1730s.

Metropolitan Museum of Art, Bequest of Mrs. Charles Wrightsman, 2019

an acquaintance, Lady Oxford, mentioned seeing them in her journal. A later catalog of the paintings in Castle Howard noted English collectors' particular affinity for the Venetian's works, describing Canaletto as "the master, whose extraordinary merit can only be appreciated in England."⁹⁸ Hanging on the walls of Castle Howard, *The Square of St. Mark's, Venice* surely reminded the earls and their guests, many of whom would have been on travels of their own, of the sights, sounds, and experiences of visiting Venice and the intellectual, personal, and cultural growth they experienced while participating in the Grand Tour.

SELECTED WORK: Frederick F. Church, *George Eastman on board the S.S. Gallia*, 1890

For most of the modern period, high-quality souvenir images were large and expensive, marketed to elite consumers. This changed after the invention of photography in the late 1830s and transformed again, even more radically, with the invention and marketing of small, portable cameras that used pre-rolled film, first marketed in 1888 by the Kodak Company in the United States. George Eastman, founder of the Kodak Company, was responsible for many photographic innovations, but one of his most impactful for the everyday experience of travelers across different social classes was the Kodak "hand camera" known as the [No. 1](#) and its successors. Frederick F. Church's photograph, which the Eastman Museum has titled *George Eastman on board the S.S. Gallia*, shows Eastman on his way to Europe holding the small Kodak camera he was responsible for developing. The Kodak company helped shape the twentieth- and twenty-first-century media landscape by turning photographic images into easy-to-access commodities that allowed ordinary people all over the world to document their travels.



Advertisement for pre-made dry plates, 1883. This advertisement stresses the convenience of dry plate glass negatives. Kodak would shortly market even more convenient rolled film on flexible plastic strips.

The first widely used photographic process emerged around 1839 and was simultaneously developed by inventors in France and England. The earliest photographs to reach a mass market, **daguerreotypes**, were small, single images on metal. The process for making daguerreotypes was not particularly difficult to learn, but it required the purchase of specialty chemicals that were best processed in an enclosed lab-like environment. Most of all, the process was not very portable since the wooden cameras were large and heavy and the materials, including mercury, were not easy to transport. This meant that while some photographers used the daguerreotype process to take [travel photographs](#), it was not a convenient method for a casual traveler to take with them. By far the most frequent genre of daguerreotype photographs were [portraits](#), made in a studio.

Other early methods, including the **salted paper print** process, which usually used paper negatives soaked in salt water and silver halides, and the **wet plate collodion process**, which involved smearing a mixture of tarlike substance onto a glass plate to produce a negative, were a little more convenient for producing images of travel. However, they still required an elementary knowledge of chemistry and were time-consuming to set up. Wet plate collodion negatives had to be developed right after exposure, so each photograph took about twenty minutes from start to finish. Additionally, the plate glass negatives were fragile and had to be well-protected when traveling on rough terrain.

Some photographers still braved these conditions to produce impressive portfolios of work. French photographer [Maxime du Camp](#) accompanied his friend, the writer Gustave Flaubert, through Egypt and the Middle East in 1849, producing the first photographic record of the remains of ancient Egyptian civilization; he used paper negatives and the salted paper printing method to produce his 1852 book *Egypte, Nubie, Palestine et Syrie* (*Egypt, Nubia, Palestine, and Syria*). Artists who used the wet plate collodion negative process were U.S. survey photographer [Timothy H. O'Sullivan](#) and [Carleton Watkins](#), who was hired by transport companies to document the landscape of the Pacific Northwest. While not all these photographers were professionals (Du Camp was a journalist), they all had either substantial monetary support or government sponsorship for their documentary projects. Some hobbyists enjoyed bringing the materials and equipment needed for photographic documentation on their personal vacations, but until the 1890s this hobby was mostly limited to those with extensive financial means. Ordinary travelers still had little opportunity to document their voyages.



Uriah Hunt Painter, photograph of two women in Washington, D.C., c. 1889. The image's round format is due to the framing mats used on early Kodak models.

Library of Congress Prints and Photographs Division

Two further innovations were needed to make amateur travel photography a reality. Both were invented and successfully marketed in the late 1880s. The first was pre-made gelatin-based film. Compared with the collodion plates of the previous generation, which had to be prepared and processed by the photographer while on location, gelatin-based film could be prepared ahead of time and pre-packaged. Early gelatin negatives were glass, but soon manufacturers transitioned to paper and shortly afterward to thin strips of flexible, transparent plastic. The second necessary innovation was the production of a smaller, more lightweight camera. Typical large-format box cameras of the nineteenth century were made mostly of wood and could weigh several pounds. On the other hand, a portable camera loaded with rolled film would allow a traveler to go almost anywhere and be able to document their travels easily at the push of a button. *George Eastman on board the S.S. Gallia* shows a traveler making use of these new technologies. Although, it is not just any traveler, it is the inventor of the Kodak portable camera himself, off to test his invention on a European trip.⁹⁹

George Eastman was born in upstate New York in 1854. He left school at age fourteen to support his widowed mother and went to work first as a messenger boy and later as a bank clerk. He first learned photography in his early twenties and then, using ideas he read about in a European photographic journal, he developed a process for manufacturing gelatin plates on glass. In 1881 he founded the Eastman company, later Eastman Kodak, and became one of the most important photographic innovators of the late nineteenth century. His company, based in Rochester, New York, was the foremost American developer of camera and film technologies. After Eastman's death, the company would go on to market the first successful color film, Kodachrome, in 1935 and the first handheld digital cameras in 1975.¹⁰⁰

Eastman developed the first model of portable camera, called the Kodak No. 1, in 1888. It cost \$25 (still quite expensive at that time), but with each new model, the price point came down significantly. By 1900 the newest model Brownie camera cost only \$1, making it accessible to most middle-class consumers. By 1905, Kodak had

sold around 1.2 million units across their different models of snapshot cameras. Their size and weight added to their portability, and both were reduced with each successive model. In *George Eastman on board the S.S. Gallia* it is easy to see how the small size allowed a photographer to stabilize the camera in one hand while releasing the shutter with the other. By the turn of the century, folding models were slim enough to carry in a coat pocket. Within a decade, the cameras' weight also decreased: a Kodak No. 1 weighed two pounds (about the same as a modern laptop computer), but by 1898, the Folding No. 1 weighed less than eight ounces (or only slightly more than a large-format smartphone).¹⁰¹

In addition to portability, early Kodaks prioritized basic functionality. The Kodak No. 1 manual stated that a new user could learn the controls and start taking quality pictures within twenty minutes. These cameras operated like any simple analog camera of the twentieth century: a continuous roll of film was stretched between two spools behind the lens. When the user wound a small wheel (or pulled a string, on the earliest model), it turned the spools and advanced the film, so a new exposure could be taken. The early Kodak models came pre-loaded with enough film for one hundred shots. A simple button mechanism opened a flap called the shutter for a fraction of a second, allowing light to pass through the lens and hit the light-sensitive film stretched across the back of the camera.

The Kodak No. 2 and later models came equipped with a small window on top that would give the user a preview of their finished image. Without including the complicated aperture settings or focal controls needed in professional cameras, the earliest versions were simple to use and cheap to manufacture. Kodak also used inexpensive lenses (another way to cut down costs). These were prone to blurring around the corners of an image, so early cameras also contained a circular mat that masked the edges, leading to the distinctive round shape of the final images.

Most importantly, Kodak removed the need for the user to learn any chemistry: their mail-order processing service would develop your film and return your printed images, along with a new roll of film. "We will relieve you of the burden of completing them [the prints] and fill the Kodak with another band of sensitized film, to be repeated as often as you like," Kodak boasted.¹⁰² This meant photographers didn't need any technical expertise or knowledge of chemistry, which were prerequisites for all earlier iterations of photography. "You press the button, we do the rest," Kodak's ads trumpeted.

Anyone who could "point and shoot" the camera could make their own holiday mementos. This led to the rise of what was, at first derisively, called "snapshot" photography. In the early days of portable cameras, this term implied that a photographer paid little attention to setting up the perfect shot—a necessity in the days when each frame was a significant investment in time and materials—and just pointed their cameras



"The Kodak Girl," 1909.

Library of Congress Prints and Photographs Division

at whatever they found interesting. But snapshots also represented a new informality that travelers craved and the flexibility to photograph anytime, anywhere. The Kodak “craze is spreading ... Kodakers were out in droves” all around the city, reported the *Chicago Tribune* newspaper in 1891.¹⁰³ A new age of souvenir images had begun.

Nineteenth-century travelers using a Kodak No. 1 still had to be more mindful about the number and quality of images they made than casual photographers of the twenty-first century. With cloud-based storage and a theoretically infinite number of images, today it is easy to take a hundred pictures in a day. Earlier travelers would only be able take a hundred pictures over the course of an entire trip. But the technology still represented the opportunity to frame their own memories—and to have [pictures of themselves and their friends](#) and traveling companions at the site of the exciting places they visited—rather than paying an artist like Canaletto to do it for them. Photo albums were used to curate and collect the images, creating a user-generated travelogue that might be imperfect and sometimes blurry but would certainly be personal. Kodak allowed amateur photographers to frame their own memories in an almost effortless way.

Not much is known about Fred Church, who used his own Kodak No. 2 camera to document George Eastman taking photos on the deck of the *S.S. Gallia* on their way to London. Church, whom Eastman nicknamed “Chappie,” worked for the Eastman company as a patent lawyer. Their 1890 trip was business-related, but it appears the two men were also close personal friends. Photos by both Eastman and Church in the Eastman archive show them as part of a large group of male friends who enjoyed camping, [fishing](#), and hiking together.¹⁰⁴ Church was not a professional artist, unlike the other creators in this resource guide. But in this, he is a perfect representative of the new possibilities for amateur travel photography that emerged with the release of the Kodak No. 1 and its successors.

George Eastman on board the S.S. Gallia is a document of the early years of snapshot photography. In the next decades, the company had great success with its “Take a Kodak with You” marketing campaign. These advertisements imagined a wide variety of users—from young cosmopolitan women to grizzled old fishermen—taking cameras on American road trips and European vacations, to world’s fairs, beaches, historical landmarks, sporting events, campsites, and more. The implication was that anyone who traveled should go armed with their own memory maker: a portable, lightweight camera that was easy for any user to operate.



“If You Want It – Take It – With a Kodak” advertising poster, c. 1900.

New York Public Library, Miriam and Ira D. Wallach Division of Art, Prints and Photographs

SECTION IV SUMMARY

Modern Nature Tourism

- ◆ As the world grew more urban and industrialized after the mid-1700s, nature was seen as rejuvenating to mind, body, and spirit. Nature tourism increasingly allowed people “to get away from it all.”

SELECTED WORK: Utagawa Hiroshige, *New Fuji, Meguro*, from *One Hundred Famous Views of Edo*, 1857

- ◆ Utagawa Hiroshige, usually just referred to as Hiroshige, was one of the best-known artists of the Edo period (1603–1868) in Japan. He made an estimated eight thousand images over the course of his thirty-year career. Most of his images were colored prints.
- ◆ Hiroshige worked in the genre of *ukiyo-e*, images showing subject matter popular with an educated, urban audience in late Edo-era Japan. These included entertainments and celebrations, popular celebrities, and national landmarks.
- ◆ *New Fuji, Meguro* is a woodblock print. Its medium is known in Japan as *nishiki-e*, multi-colored prints made using multiple carved blocks. *Nishiki-e* were popular with consumers in the Edo period and were printed in runs of up to ten or fifteen thousand copies.
- ◆ *New Fuji, Meguro* shows the increasing Japanese interest in nature tourism in the mid-nineteenth century. Mount Fuji was transitioning from a site of religious pilgrimage into a national symbol of Japan and a site of recreation and leisure.
- ◆ The image shows a viewing platform, or “mini-Fuji,” that mimics the iconic shape of Fuji’s volcanic cone. Numerous mini-Fujis were built in the Edo suburbs starting in 1779. They allowed tourists to view Mount Fuji without making the difficult trip to the summit.
- ◆ Those visiting the mini-Fujis on festival days could buy snacks and souvenirs and enjoy views of Mount Fuji in their everyday garments.

SELECTED WORK: Charles Whittlesey, *El Tovar Hotel*, South Rim of the Grand Canyon, Arizona, 1905

- ◆ Nineteenth-century artists framed American scenery as capable of inspiring intense emotional responses in viewers. They helped spur the creation of a tourist infrastructure based around appreciating the landscape.
- ◆ This expanded with the completion of the Transcontinental Railroad in 1869, making it easier for travelers to visit remote regions in the West and Southwest. Railway companies expanded their networks to include transportation, lodging, and food.
- ◆ Fred Harvey partnered with the Atchison, Topeka & Santa Fe Railroad, gaining an exclusive license to develop hotels along their popular rail line from the Midwest to New Mexico. By 1901, Harvey had opened more than forty hotels and restaurants.
- ◆ His hotels used eclectic historic references in their architecture, presenting a vision of the American Southwest as rustic and exotic while also offering travelers convenience and predictability.
- ◆ El Tovar, arguably the company’s most spectacular investment, was built on a spur line overlooking the majestic views of the Grand Canyon. It was designed by in-house architect Charles Whittlesey and cost \$250,000.
- ◆ Its exterior resembled a rugged hunting lodge or log cabin. Its interior was luxurious and contained many state-of-the-art amenities for the time.
- ◆ El Tovar capitalized on its proximity to the Grand Canyon, a growing area of nature tourism. The Grand Canyon was made a National Monument in 1908 and a National Park in 1919. Today, around 4.5 million people visit Grand Canyon National Park each year.

Images as Souvenirs of Travel: From the Elite to the Everyday

- ◆ Travelers have long enjoyed bringing home a souvenir to remind them of their trips.

- ◆ Changes in recording media—from painting to photography—allowed greater numbers of travelers to make their own images of their voyages.

SELECTED WORK: Canaletto, *The Square of Saint Mark's, Venice*, 1742/44

- ◆ *The Square of Saint Mark's, Venice* is one of around five hundred *vedute*, or “views,” made by the Venetian painter Canaletto, which were marketed as souvenirs for wealthy tourists in the eighteenth century.
- ◆ Trained as a theatrical scene painter, Canaletto developed a reputation for highly realistic views of Venice, Italy, which may have been sketched with the use of an optical device.
- ◆ Canaletto and other artists in Venice and Rome, painted “views” for wealthy English clients, many of whom were visiting Italy as part of what became known as the Grand Tour.
- ◆ Grand Tours usually lasted at least six months and were usually closer to a year or more. They were seen as a rite of passage for young British aristocrats and the finishing touch to a young man’s education. Accompanied by tutors, Grand Tourists were expected to develop an informed artistic eye and often brought home souvenirs in the form of classical statuary fragments, Renaissance paintings, and modern “views.”
- ◆ Venice was a stop on most Grand Tours. It drew English visitors because of its distinctive entertainments, unique architecture, and labyrinthine networks of canals. British travelers saw Venice as a romantic site of intrigue and freedom from social constraints.
- ◆ *The Square of St. Mark's, Venice* was purchased as a souvenir, either by Henry Howard, the 4th Earl of Carlisle, or his son Frederick. Like many aristocrats of the period,

the Howards displayed the piece in a picture gallery at their home, Castle Howard.

SELECTED WORK: Frederick F. Church, *George Eastman on board the S.S. Gallia*, 1890

- ◆ The first widely used photographic process emerged around 1839 and was simultaneously developed by inventors in France and England. The earliest photographs required the purchase of specialty chemicals that were best processed in an enclosed lab-like environment. This made travel images difficult to produce.
- ◆ Early photographs also required large, heavy equipment and fragile glass negatives. This meant that travel images were mostly limited to professionals or wealthy amateurs.
- ◆ In the 1880s, American inventor George Eastman came up with methods for producing pre-prepared negatives, flexible rolled film, and lightweight portable cameras. These made it easier for non-specialist photographers to make images on the go.
- ◆ Eastman’s Kodak No. 1 camera, produced in 1888, originally cost \$25 and came with a pre-loaded roll of film capable of taking one hundred exposures. By 1900, the cost came down to just \$1, making the technology accessible to most middle-class consumers.
- ◆ These cameras were referred to as “snapshot” cameras, meaning that users could make an image just by pushing a button. They required no technical skill or knowledge of chemistry.
- ◆ *George Eastman on board the S.S. Gallia* shows Eastman on a trip to Europe accompanied by his friend and colleague Fred Church, who took the photo. Like most users of the new snapshot cameras, Church was not a professional artist.

Transportation and Technology

REPRESENTING MODERN FORMS OF TRAVEL IN MODERN STYLES

The century between the 1830s and the 1930s saw not only the spread of several new forms of transportation, but also the explosion of modern artistic styles and movements that pushed the boundaries of representation. In movements such as Impressionism and Cubism, artists broke down traditional representations of space and volume, focusing on visual elements such as color, brushstroke, and shape. **Abstraction**, or the simplification of visually recognizable forms, drove artistic developments in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.

In the same years, the development and expansion of the railway network (starting on a large scale in the 1830s) and then the invention of the automobile (1880s) and airplane (1900s) overlapped chronologically with some of the most exciting developments in modern art. By the 1930s, the transportation landscape appeared transformed from what it had been a hundred years before, when horse-drawn and water-borne travel were the primary ways of getting from place to place. And these new modes of transportation didn't just offer speed; they also framed new ways of seeing. Modern artists increasingly used the innovative developments of abstraction to represent—and even attempt to reproduce—the thrilling experience of riding in a train, car, or airplane.

SELECTED WORK: Claude Monet, *Arrival of the Normandy Train, Gare Saint-Lazare*, 1877

Claude Monet's name today is almost synonymous with the art movement he was a part of, Impressionism. Born to a middle-class family in Paris in 1840, Monet grew up in Le Havre, an important port in Normandy, where his father was a grocer. In 1862, after a brief period of military service in the French colony of Algeria, Monet went to Paris to study art under the Academic painter [Charles Gleyre](#). In Paris during the 1850s and 1860s, tensions were mounting between the Academic faction, who privileged linear perspective, sharp focus, and high finish, and younger painters who mounted their own alternative exhibitions.

Monet at first was allied with the traditionalists, showing his landscape paintings at the Salon, or state-sponsored art exhibition, in [1865](#), 1866, and 1868. However, meeting fellow painters [Alfred Sisley](#) and [Pierre-Auguste Renoir](#) in the late 1860s pushed Monet toward more abstract representations of the landscape. These works stressed spontaneity, the application of saturated, often unmixed, colors, and a focus on brushwork and experimental techniques over detailed naturalism. Monet was known, as many of his contemporaries were, for [painting outdoors](#), known in French as painting *en plein air*. This was made possible by new developments in painting supplies, including oil paint in pre-filled metal tubes, which made painting a more portable and flexible occupation.

Today their work is well-loved and recognizable around the world, but in their own time the Impressionists were seen as upstart radicals, like the Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood in England. Their head-on challenge to traditional French Academic painting began in 1874 when Monet, [Gustave Caillebotte](#), [Edgar Degas](#), and others formed what they called a “société anonyme,” a French legal term for a corporation owned by stockholders.

Their first group exhibition the same year was made up of artists whose work had been rejected by the official Salon. In response to this show, where Monet exhibited a work titled [Impression, Sunrise](#), art critic Louis Leroy dubbed the group “Impressionists,” a title that has stuck for more than 150 years. Though the artists of the group pursued different subjects, they shared a rejection of the detailed, highly finished naturalism seen in Academic and Orientalist paintings. Instead, they focused on brushwork and color to produce works that appeared to be momentary “impressions.” Their most typical subject matter included [natural landscapes](#), activities associated with [middle-class leisure time](#), and the [changing city of Paris](#).

After a turbulent period of revolutions (in 1789, 1814, 1830, and 1848), Paris underwent a major urban renewal project that included widening main streets, installing public amenities such as parks and gardens, and constructing iconic buildings, such as the [Printemps department store](#) (1865) and the [Opéra](#) (1875), that contributed to a new culture of leisure, consumption, and entertainment. Along with this expansion of the urban fabric, seven new railroad stations were built through 1900 to connect the capital city to nearly all regions of France via an easy rail journey. With its original location dating to 1835, the [Gare Saint-Lazare](#) was the first of these stations. Located in central Paris, just a ten-minute walk from the main shopping district, the station connected the capital first with its suburbs to the northwest and later to regions farther afield, such as Normandy, the coastal region in northwestern France where Monet grew up.

While the first tracks were hidden in tunnels under a plaza, an 1853 redevelopment opened up the approach to the station and necessitated the construction of the [Pont de l'Europe](#) to allow pedestrians to cross. Both the bridge and the station were symbols of a new, evolving Paris that was slowly demolishing medieval buildings and streets to make way for a fresh vision of the city. The architecture of the train hall, which used an iron and glass roof structure to span the large area and to bring in natural light, was also an emblem of France's modernity.¹⁰⁵

Monet was not the first modern French artist to represent the newly expanding railway network. Before him, the printmaker Honoré Daumier had produced cartoons for the humor periodical *Le Charivari*, including a satirical series titled [On the Train](#) (first published in the 1850s, released as stand-alone prints in 1864). Monet was also not the first to focus on the clouds of steam and smoke emitted by the coal-burning locomotives: Édouard Manet painted [The Railway](#) (1873), which shows a governess and young child looking through railings onto a train line suffused with fluffy white steam. Nor was Monet the only Impressionist to focus on the industrial and architectural apparatus of the railway network: his close friend Caillebotte showed the new iron truss bridge that spanned the tracks of Saint-Lazare train station in [Le Pont de l'Europe](#) (1876). But Monet's growing interest in technology, particularly the new railway infrastructure, led him to paint at least a dozen images in the *Gare Saint-Lazare* series, making him perhaps the most persistent fine artist to



Auguste Renoir, Portrait of Claude Monet, 1872.

National Gallery of Art, Collection of Mr. and Mrs. Paul Mellon

tackle the topic of the railway. His focus was on the industrial architecture of the station as it interfaced with the effects of light, weather, and atmosphere.

Monet's home between 1871 and 1877 was in Argenteuil, a northwestern suburb of Paris directly on the line from Saint-Lazare. Many of his works from these years show [his family](#) enjoying an idyllic space of flowers and fresh air, away from the city. However, during the 1870s the idea of Argenteuil as a countryside retreat was slowly giving way, replaced by its new role as a "suburban village neither city nor country."¹⁰⁶ Monet's work also began gravitating toward urban-industrial themes in the 1870s. Starting in 1877, he rented a studio space near the Gare Saint-Lazare and began working on paintings that directly showed urban buildings and activities. That year, Monet painted twelve scenes in and around the Saint-Lazare station, most looking out from the train platforms toward the Pont de l'Europe and the city beyond. The artist had to receive special permission to work inside the station.



Auguste Renoir, Pont Neuf, Paris, 1872.

National Gallery of Art, Ailsa Mellon Bruce Collection

Arrival of the Normandy Train shows the oldest set of tracks in the station. The locomotive has stopped at a buffer just inside the glass-roofed train hall, while we can see the newer tracks extend further into the space, to the rear of where the artist would have stood. The low iron form of the Pont de l'Europe is partly visible, crossing the vast number of tracks and appearing to disappear in a haze of smoke at the left of the image. Compared to other of Monet's works—even those in the same series, such as those at Harvard University's [Fogg Museum](#) and the [Musée d'Orsay](#) in Paris—the *Arrival of the Normandy Train* is rather monochrome. The foreground, representing about a quarter of the painting, is rendered in pale greenish-brown, while the rest is created in tones of black to bluish gray.

Monet strikingly uses several different gestural brushmarks—including small, feathery strokes, larger blotches, and quick scribbles—to evoke the quickly-moving character of the steam coming from the locomotive's smokestack as it blends with the smoke from other trains and with the clouds and hazy pale sky of an overcast day. Throughout the series of images, Monet focuses equally on the [architecture of the station](#) itself, stressing its modernity through the details of the cast iron pillars and large glass roofing panes, and on the way the steam from this new mode of transportation seems to dematerialize the architecture and the people, giving way to brushy "impressions" of the space. While Impressionism as a movement and Monet specifically sought to give the viewer a sense of momentary, quick observation, his notebooks show extensive sketches of the station and the surrounding neighborhood, which he used as preparatory materials for the finished paintings.¹⁰⁷

Seven of Monet's Saint-Lazare paintings, including *Arrival of the Normandy Train*, were shown at the third Impressionist exhibition in 1877, alongside Caillebotte's *Le Pont de l'Europe*. The novelist Emile Zola wrote enthusiastically of Monet's "terrific views of train stations. You can hear the trains rumbling in, see the smoke billow up under the huge roofs. ... That is where painting is today... Our artists have to find the poetry in train stations, the way their fathers found the poetry in forests and rivers."¹⁰⁸ This quotation shows how thinkers in the nineteenth century were already connecting modern forms of transportation and technology to new developments in painting.

Not everyone was so complimentary, though. One critic's response shows how, even twenty years later,

some viewers still regarded Impressionism with suspicion: claiming that while “a railway station was as worthy of being represented as the ruins” of ancient Rome, “modernists have not been able to make a picture out of it except on the condition of jumbling up all its lines beneath floods of luminous vapor...”¹⁰⁹ This criticism shows that the writer understood, but still rejected, Monet’s goal of rendering modern subjects in an abstracted style that focused on light and color, rather than precise and sharp naturalism. It was not until the mid-twentieth century that Impressionism was more universally regarded as an important step in modernist experimentation.



Claude Monet's painting The Railway Bridge at Argenteuil (1873) shows the train line expansion into the small town of Argenteuil, where Monet lived with his family.

Monet’s twelve paintings of the Saint-Lazare train station were the first example of the artist making a group of works meant to be viewed as a series.¹¹⁰ Later in his career, up until his death in 1926, Monet became well known for serial images showing his chosen subjects in a variety of weathers and times of day: subjects included rural haystacks, waterlilies in his garden, the Houses of Parliament in London, and the cathedral in Rouen, Normandy. It is fitting that for his first experiment with a series, Monet chose a modern form of transportation. The trains and people coming and going, and the ever-shifting clouds of smoke and steam, meant that the view in a station was always changing, allowing the artist to capture both the feeling of movement and dynamism associated with rail travel and the sense of a momentary glimpse so central to Impressionism. In the twentieth century, artists would become increasingly interested in how abstract techniques could be mobilized to stress the speed and thrill of new modes of transportation.

SELECTED WORK: Robert Delaunay, *Homage to Blériot*, 1914

In the first decade of manned motorized flight (initiated in 1903 when Orville and Wilbur Wright completed the first successful flight at Kitty Hawk, North Carolina), not many artists attempted to represent the airplane as a form of transportation. Unlike trains, airplanes were not yet a practical method for moving large numbers of people from place to place, and they did not saturate the public consciousness and daily life in the way railways had done six decades earlier. Airfields were usually located far from city centers—unlike train stations, whose core functionality required them to be easily accessible by the largest number of people possible—and airplanes remained the reserve of stunt people and specialized fliers.

However, around 1913, artists in at least four separate countries—Britain, France, Italy, and Russia—independently and almost simultaneously began to think about how abstract art could render

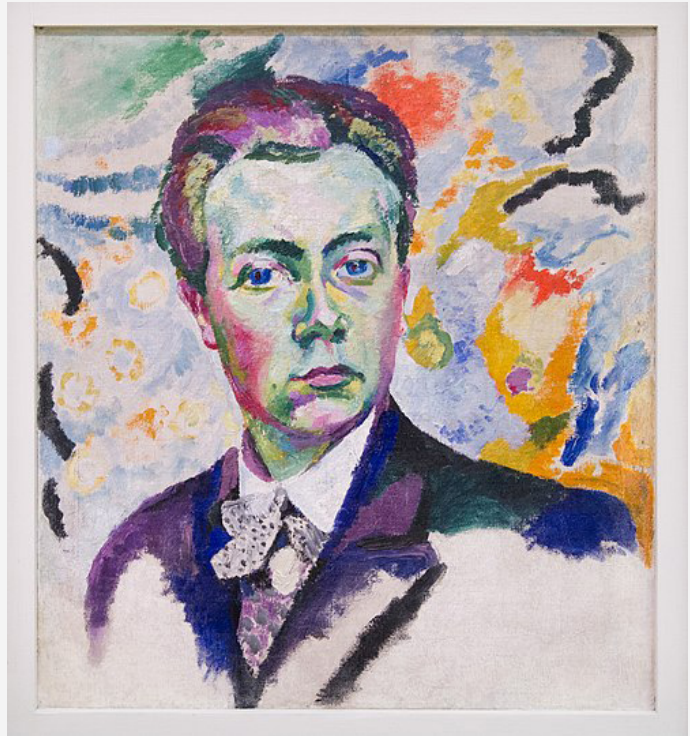


Stunt flyer Mabel Cody, with daredevils “Bugs” McGowan and Sig Haugdahl, performing feats of aerial acrobatics in Pablo Beach, California, 1921.

Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division

the new form of flight. One of these artists was Robert Delaunay, a French painter associated with the movement known as Orphism. Delaunay's *Homage to Blériot* combines his application of scientific color theory and his celebration of modern technology in its praise of aviator and airplane manufacturer Louis Blériot.

French artist Robert Delaunay was born in Paris in 1885. As a teenager, he apprenticed as a painter of theatrical backdrops, but he had no official training in painting as a “fine art.” Inspired by viewing the works of [Paul Gauguin](#) and [Paul Cezanne](#), who were both about a generation older than he was, Delaunay became interested in abstraction and color theory. He experimented with styles ranging from Impressionism to [Fauvism](#) before becoming associated with [Cubism](#) in 1909. One of Cubism's key innovations was to break down painting's traditional reliance on an illusion of three-dimensional space, which artists usually created using linear perspective and shading. Instead, Cubist artists recognized and embraced the essential flatness of the canvas (or other 2D painting surface) and represented space as fragmented, built up out of overlapping shapes, as if their subjects were seen from multiple perspectives simultaneously.



Robert Delaunay, Self-Portrait, 1905–06.

Centre Pompidou, Paris

Delaunay experimented with these techniques from 1909 to 1912, creating a series of images showing the [city of Paris](#) and the [Eiffel Tower](#) in a [Cubist style](#). But Pablo Picasso and Georges Braque, leaders of the movement, increasingly felt that color was a distraction from their strict analysis of space and perspective. Their works in this period were increasingly monochromatic. Delaunay, who was interested in the psychology and optics of color, left the group, later remembering: “I was the heretic of Cubism. I had great arguments with my comrades who banned color from their palette, depriving it of all elemental mobility. I was accused of ... making decorative paintings.”¹¹¹ He and his wife [Sonia Terk](#), a Russian painter and textile designer, split from the group in 1912.

As a couple, Delaunay and Delaunay-Terk did not explicitly collaborate on paintings, but from roughly 1911 through the early 1920s, their style was very similar: almost fully abstract arrangements of brightly colored patterns and shapes, with a distinct trend toward circular or [disc-like forms](#). Their friend, the poet Guillaume Apollinaire, called the style **Orphism**, inspired by the ancient Greek legend of the musician Orpheus. For Apollinaire, Orpheus embodied art-making that was deeply emotional and often spiritual, while Cubism was intellectual and detached itself from anything that might feel mystical.

Along with the Delaunays, Apollinaire grouped [Fernand Léger](#), [Francis Picabia](#), and sometimes Marcel Duchamp (better known today as a Dada artist) as the other members of Orphism. Orphism had only a brief period of notoriety, but Delaunay received many public mural commissions into the late 1930s before passing away in 1941. His work, which blended the intellectual rigor of chromatic theory with an instinctual understanding of the emotive power of color, influenced his contemporaries, including the Expressionists [Wassily Kandinsky](#) and Paul Klee, the Bauhaus teacher and theorist [Josef Albers](#), and American hard-edge abstraction painters of the 1960s and 1970s such as [Kenneth Nolan](#).¹¹²

Homage to Blériot was from this early Orphist period in Delaunay's career. He made several versions of the painting, as he often did, working through a theme by using different color combinations to see which created the most effective optical vibrations—an idea Delaunay learned from studying nineteenth-century color theory, which posited that placing complementary colors together caused each to appear brighter and more dynamic. Multiple nested disc shapes in almost every color create a sensation of whirling movement across the center of the canvas. The artist cryptically described the painting as showing “multiple disk prisms that flood the earth, from which airplanes depart” and wrote of the “Constructive mobility of the solar spectrum; birth, flame, flight of airplanes. ... The motor in the picture.”¹¹³

Though most of the image is fully nonrepresentational, there are at least four recognizable forms: the nose of an airplane with a large propeller; the Eiffel Tower, a common motif in Delaunay's paintings from this period; and two airplanes: an orange plane seen from below, outlined in Kelly green, and a maroon and white biplane, seen from an angle and outlined in concentric rings of peach, yellow orange, purple-brown, and pale pinkish-purple. The painting not only shows Delaunay's experimentation with color, but also his passion for aeronautics, which was a common theme in his works, including [The Cardiff Team](#) (several versions, 1912–14) and *Propeller*. At the base of the painting, Delaunay wrote an inscription that can be translated as “the ‘first simultaneous solar discs’ to the great constructor Blériot.”



Robert Delaunay, *Propeller*, 1926.

Louis Blériot is not well known today, but during the 1910s his name would have been familiar to any aviation-minded viewer. In addition to being an inventor and manufacturer of airplanes, Blériot was a celebrity aviator of the day. He was the first to fly across the English Channel in 1909, winning a prize of £1000 sponsored by the *Daily Mail* newspaper. French aviators were at this time considered the best in the world, as British novelist and painter Wyndham Lewis spitefully responded by complaining: “The French Press gushes sentimentally every day about their ‘hommes-oiseaux’ [bird-men].”¹¹⁴ Delaunay, who was fascinated by aviation, attended the parade in Blériot's honor on his return to Paris after the channel crossing and wrote the famous aviator a fan letter shortly afterward. The Delaunays often took the train out to the Buc airfield, near Versailles, to watch the planes; Sonia recalled that Robert “watched the take-offs with joyous eyes.”¹¹⁵

Homage to Blériot was a culmination of Delaunay's interest in showing multiple views at once. In his *Simultaneous Windows* series, which he developed just before *Homage to Blériot*, the artist produced paintings of Paris that combined a street-level view of buildings and landmarks with a map-like perspective that sees the same places from above. In several documented instances, Delaunay used aerial photographs of Paris printed in newspapers and on postcards to compose his paintings.¹¹⁶ [Simultaneous Windows](#) oscillates between ground and sky, forcing a viewer to experience both perspectives simultaneously. When we view

a scene from above, our brains have to do extra work to make sense of the unfamiliar perspective. When we add motion to this experience, as when the landscape is seen from a flying airplane, the viewpoints multiply and fragment even further, an experience many modern artists tried to make sense of through visual means.

At almost the exact same time as Delaunay, the Briton Edward Wadsworth ([A Short Flight](#), 1914), the Russians Kazimir Malevich ([Airplane Flying](#), 1914–15) and Natalia Goncharova ([Airplane Flying Over Train](#), 1913), and the Italian Gino Severini ([Flying over Rheims](#), 1915) used similar techniques

of multiple perspectives and fragmentation to represent flying planes. All were members of avant-

garde artistic movements, and all imagined either the dynamic experience of viewing the world from an airplane or thematically presented planes as exemplars of modern speed and technology. The simultaneous debut of these works appears to be entirely coincidental. There was something about the spirit of modern art just before the First World War that seemed to inspire painters to represent the dynamism of flight. As [Wyndham Lewis](#) wrote in 1914, “All revolutionary painting to-day has in common the rigid reflections of steel ... in the spirit of the artist.”¹¹⁷ In their attempts to translate the magic of flight to the 2D surface of the canvas, painters had to transmute that “steel” into an image that conveyed the thrill, energy, and speed of an early airplane flight, often to viewers who had not experienced it.



Louis Blériot in his monoplane, c. 1909–25.

Library of Congress, George Grantham Bain Collection

SELECTED WORK: Tamara De Lempicka, *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)*, 1929

While flying in an airplane in the early twentieth century was still a novelty reserved for wealthy hobbyists or professional aviators, riding in a car was becoming a more common experience in the same years. Like the artists who represented early flight, those who chose automobiles as their subject matter tended to use dynamic and abstract forms to represent the unprecedented feeling of speed and freedom given by this rapidly expanding form of transportation. The American painter John Sloan's [Gray and Brass](#) (1907) may be the earliest image of a flashy car driving through a city. By the 1910s and 1920s, many more artists were experimenting with how best to evoke the rapidity and new sensations of automobile travel. Our next selected work engages with elements of technology, gender, and mass media as it shows the artist, Tamara de Lempicka, represented as a powerful modern woman behind the wheel of a luxury automobile.

The artist Tamara de Lempicka is difficult to pin down: her birth name, place of birth, and the year she was born are all uncertain, partly because of attempts by the artist herself to obscure information about her early origins by cultivating an air of mystery. She was born to a wealthy Polish family, probably in Moscow, around 1894. (The artist claimed to have been born in both Warsaw and St. Petersburg, anywhere from 1898 to 1905.) Her family, Catholics who had converted from Judaism, were known alternately by the surnames Gurska and Hurwitz. In 1916, she married Count Tadeusz de Lempicki, a Polish aristocrat and lawyer. She began artistic studies in St. Petersburg, but Tadeusz was imprisoned as a suspected tsarist spy during the Russian Revolution, and Tamara and their infant daughter Kizette fled to Paris. (Tadeusz joined them in Paris later, after his release.)

In Paris, de Lempicka continued her interrupted artistic education, studying under the Cubist painter [André Lhote](#). Her first major exhibition was at the Bottega di Poesia gallery in Milan, Italy, in 1925. This introduced her to an audience of wealthy patrons and collectors, many of whom commissioned portraits from her. In 1928, Tamara and Tadeusz divorced, and she married her second husband, Baron Raoul Kuffner, in 1933. By the mid-1930s, portrait commissions were drying up due to the global economic crisis and the darkening political mood in Europe. After a period of treatment for clinical depression when she completed relatively little artistic work, de Lempicka and Kuffner immigrated to the United States in 1939. While she continued to paint throughout the rest of her life, her work never regained the notoriety it had in the 1920s, when she so successfully captured the zeitgeist of interwar life. De Lempicka retired to Cuernavaca, Mexico, in 1978 and died there two years later.¹¹⁸

Whereas Delaunay's art was unabashedly experimental, de Lempicka's was more commercially successful, though it incorporates elements from avant-garde movements of the period. De Lempicka combined Cubism's faceted shapes and analysis of space with a sensuousness and sense of luxury associated with the [Art Deco](#) movement. This style in art, architecture, and [design](#), lasting from around 1924 to 1930, was known for its focus on brilliant colors, [angular shapes](#), [expensive materials](#), and motifs relating to modern life.

Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti) is one of the artist's most iconic images, showing de Lempicka at the wheel of a luxury automobile wearing leather driving gloves and a helmet, staring out at the viewer with a look of hauteur. The painting's tight cropping does not focus on the body of the car or its mechanical features, but rather the expression of cool-headedness, power, and control in de Lempicka's body language and facial expression. The L-shape created by the bright green intersection of the hood with the driver's side door work to frame de Lempicka's face, which appears nestled in a swirling cloud of silver fabric (a silk scarf, provided to the artist by the luxury brand [Hermès](#)). The windshield also offers a second frame, focusing on the driver's exaggeratedly elongated hand gripping the steering wheel. Wearing bright red lipstick, with her bobbed blond hair just peeking out of the driving helmet, de Lempicka's sidelong gaze is nonchalant but also vibrates with glamour and confidence. She shows herself as a woman absolutely in control of her speeding automobile. The painting proposes that women, too, possess the focus and surehandedness required to power a beautiful and sleek machine.

By the time this painting was made, automobiles had become an inescapable part of life in the modern West. First developed in Germany around 1885, internal-combustion-engine-powered vehicles remained a luxury item for the first fifteen to twenty years of their existence. But around the turn of the twentieth century,



Thérèse Bonney, Tamara de Lempicka working on "Portrait of a Man (Thadeusz Lempicki)," c. 1929.

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University of California, Berkeley

automobile ownership began to creep up. Though Europe adopted cars less enthusiastically than the more sprawling United States, by 1927 there was one car for every forty-four people in France, de Lempicka's adopted country. Uptake was similar in other Western European countries.¹¹⁹ France dominated European car production in the interwar period, with Bugatti (a company based in Alsace, formerly in Germany) known for their success with racing cars. (When challenged on the quality of the brakes in some of his cars, Ettore Bugatti supposedly quipped "I make cars to go, not to stop."¹²⁰) The Bugatti in *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)* resembles a [Type 43 Roadster](#), a fast and sleek consumer model.



Luigi Russolo, *Dynamism of an Automobile*, 1912–13.

Centre Pompidou, Paris

Like *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)*, other artistic representations of cars from the period between the two World Wars tried to evoke the special properties of the automobile. These can be divided into two general groups: those that show cars in relation to the humans who operate them, and those that use dramatic abstraction to suggest the speed of a fast-moving vehicle. In both cases, unlike *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)*, cars were generally presented as masculine. Fernand Leger's [The Mechanic](#) (1920) is a great example of the former. Instead of a driver behind the wheel, it focuses on a man in a sleeveless shirt smoking a cigarette. A tattoo on his bicep suggests he is a working-class person, possibly a former sailor. This is the masculine alternative to de Lempicka's cultured, wealthy, and feminine appearance.

Earlier works that show how artists used radical abstraction to replicate the exciting feeling of a fast car are Italian Futurist paintings [Speeding Automobile](#) (1912) by Giacomo Balla and *Dynamism of an Automobile* by Luigi Russolo. The Futurists were interested in harnessing "masculine" experiences (such as flying airplanes, riding in cars, and fighting with modern weapons) as inspiration for their art and were known for their glorification of speed and technology in work that appears fragmented and dynamic. *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)* goes against the grain of these hypermasculine representations and instead shows automotive technology as accessible to, and enjoyable for, modern women.

Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti) is also different from these other automotive images of the period because it was made specifically to be reproduced. In 1927 de Lempicka was approached by the editor of *Die Dame (The Lady)*, a German style magazine, that commissioned her to design several covers. Along with German Dada artist Hannah Höch, de Lempicka was just one of many contemporary female artists to work for *Die Dame*, whose "target reader was the modern career woman."¹²¹ Published between 1912 and 1943, *Die Dame* had a circulation of around 60,000 copies per issue.

Over the next three years, De Lempicka's paintings, including *The Orange Scarf* (1927), *High Summer* (1928), *St. Moritz* (1929), and *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)*, appeared as [covers for Die Dame](#), helping spread the image of a glamorous and modern "new woman" archetype in interwar Europe. In *St. Moritz*, set in the Swiss Alps resort town and location of the 1928 Winter Olympic Games, an active woman prepares to ski down a slope. In *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)*, the artist pilots a luxury car. But as with all fashion magazines, *Die Dame*'s cover also sold readers a fantasy: Tamara de Lempicka drove a small yellow Renault (an economy car), not the exclusive Bugatti she imagined for herself.¹²² Marketing less to traditional housewives than to new career women, *Die Dame* contained articles on sports, celebrities, and cosmetics, but it was also surprisingly auto-minded. An annual "car issue" showed photographs of female

celebrities with their favorite cars, articles on new, popular car models, and instructions on driving-related tasks like how to change a tire.¹²³

The issue of *Die Dame* that featured *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)* hit German newsstands just days after the adventurous socialite Clärenore Stinnes arrived in Berlin, completing the final leg of a twenty-seven-month tour and becoming one of the first people to circumnavigate the world by car (with her soon-to-be-husband, photojournalist Carl-Axel Söderström).¹²⁴ *Die Dame*, and other cultural productions of the interwar period such as advertisements and novels, presented the car as an engine of women's liberation, arguing that women should be out on the road, enjoying themselves just as much as male drivers.



Clärenore Stinnes, one of the first people to circumnavigate the globe by car, in 1926.

INNOVATIVE TECHNOLOGIES AND MEDIA

In addition to paintings, artists also used architecture and new media to celebrate modern forms of travel. While abstract painting could thematize flight and speed through its use of fragmented perspectives, some artists and architects worked in more innovative forms to capture the dynamism of flight or to produce works that did not represent, but instead thematized, ideas about travel. In this final section,

we examine two pieces that pushed beyond the boundaries of two-dimensional artworks to express the technological potential, futurism, and emotive power of the quintessential twentieth-century modes of transportation: the passenger plane and the superhighway. In both cases, the finished artworks not only use innovative new technologies and materials, but also demonstrate how these forms of travel—
invented less than a century earlier—were integrated into daily life more than ever before.

SELECTED WORK: Eero Saarinen, TWA Flight Center, John F. Kennedy International Airport, New York, New York, 1959–62

When Eero Saarinen was commissioned to design a new terminal for Idlewild Airport in Queens, New York, most airport buildings in the United States were low, shed-like, and functional. Few were designed by big-name architectural firms, as they were considered utilitarian structures that performed a basic function: sheltering passengers from the elements while they checked into and waited for their flights. This began to change in the 1950s as passengers started to view commercial air travel as luxurious and sophisticated and airlines marketed themselves as providing a full experience that started long before travelers walked up the steps to board their plane. The architecture of air terminals had to shift to keep up with this evolution, and one of the earliest and most noteworthy examples was the Trans World Airlines (TWA) Flight Center at Idlewild (renamed John F. Kennedy Airport in 1963, in honor of the recently assassinated president). Architect Eero Saarinen produced the first “star” airline terminal, paving the way for many later “starchitects” to re-imagine how function could be wedded to groundbreaking visual and aesthetic experiences.

Eero Saarinen was born in a suburb of Helsinki, Finland, in 1910. His birthplace, [Hvitträsk](#), was an architectural complex designed by three major architects of the period, Herman Gesellius, Armas Lindgren,

and Eero's father, Eliel Saarinen. The designers envisioned it as an art colony where they and their families would live and work together. Hvitträsk was built in the romantic nationalist style, which featured traditional building materials and historical references to prehistoric, Viking, and medieval Scandinavian forms. One of Eliel Saarinen's most important buildings was the [central train station in Helsinki](#) (opened 1919), which combined romantic nationalist elements with modern technology.

When Eero was thirteen, the family immigrated to the United States, settling in Michigan, where Eliel took a job as director of the Cranbrook Academy of Art. Cranbrook's curriculum focused on architecture and applied arts, including furniture, industrial design, and textiles. Eero took classes at Cranbrook in his teens, but his primary architectural education took place in Paris and at Yale University. After graduating in 1934, he traveled for nearly two years before coming home to take a job at his father's architectural firm. In 1948 Eero gained national recognition when his design for the Jefferson National Expansion Memorial in St. Louis, Missouri, was selected in a national competition, famously beating out his own father's submission.

Eero's design, now known as the [Gateway Arch](#), was a 630-foot-tall catenary arch sheathed in panels of stainless steel. It shows all the elements he would use in the TWA terminal and in the rest of his architectural practice: a dedication to modern materials used in an innovative way, an embrace of organic lines and shapes, and the ability to use expressive form to communicate with audiences. Saarinen's other noteworthy designs include [Washington Dulles International Airport](#), the [Kresge Auditorium](#) at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, two overseas American embassies, and many designs for domestic and office furniture. Saarinen passed away in 1961, at the age of just fifty-one, and the TWA terminal was completed the following year.

From the street, the TWA Flight Center looks like a giant white bird crouching to take off, wings outstretched. Two huge overhanging arches extend to either side, with glass curtain walls descending from them. The massive supports come down at dizzying angles and anchor the structure to the ground, but they also resemble the legs in a bird of prey's ready stance. On the inside, the vast open space is filled with curving forms, such as two staircases that swoop and intertwine, echoing the dramatic lines of the façade. The high ceiling follows the winglike curves visible from outside, making interior and exterior into a cohesive whole: a thin, sculpted shell. Even the sofas, the information desk, and the huge, bulbous flight status monitor have curved edges, repeating similar shapes across the entire space.

At the rear of the terminal building, floor-to-ceiling windows frame a view of the runway, allowing passengers to watch planes taking off and landing. The symmetry continues with two long hallways, carpeted in "TWA red," leading off the main space at forty-five-degree angles, which led passengers to the



Balthazar Korab, photo of Eero Saarinen, c. 1955–56.

Library of Congress, Balthazar Korab Collection, Prints and Photographs Division

seventeen original departure gates. (Today, one of these “flight tubes” connects to JFK’s Terminal 5, while the other gives visitors access to a small museum.) Built at the dawn of the jet age for one of the most prominent airlines in the world, the terminal represented what its architect described as “the excitement of travel.” TWA’s president at the time of the commission, Ralph Damon, requested “a building that starts your flight with your first glimpse of it” and would communicate “the spirit of flight, inside and out.”¹²⁵ Saarinen delivered on both these requests with his unorthodox but expressive design.

It may not appear so at first glance, but the TWA Flight Center was deeply indebted to Saarinen’s father Eliel and the tenets of Finnish romantic architecture. Both father and son were dedicated to the philosophy that materials affect a building’s expressive character. This means that the textures, colors, and other inherent qualities of materials are an important starting point for a design. Rather than designing a building first and sourcing appropriate materials later, both Saarinens believed in letting the materials guide the design. While in much of Eliel’s early work his chosen materials were local Finnish stone and timber, to express national pride and sense of place, the materials Eero worked with were associated with machine age modernism.

In the St. Louis arch, the stainless-steel cladding produced a sleek, dynamic surface; in the TWA terminal, the primary material of concrete over flexible metal mesh allowed him to shape and sculpt the building into its exaggerated, winglike forms. The lightweight shell roof, in places only seven inches thick, is made up of four wedge-shaped segments. Where the four sections meet, instead of solid weight-bearing ribs as in a traditional vaulted roof, Saarinen inserted glass skylights, further enhancing the building’s feeling of upward momentum and airiness. In the shell roof, a feature he repeated at Dulles Airport, Saarinen used reinforced concrete’s malleable properties to create the dynamic and symbolic forms the client had requested.

Saarinen believed that organic architectural forms—those resembling shapes found in nature—would be more welcoming, visually interesting, and psychologically nurturing to users than the rigid steel and glass skyscrapers designed by modern architects like [Ludwig Mies van der Rohe](#). By the late 1950s, this “International Modernist” style had become stale and repetitive: “uniform, boxlike buildings with transparent curtain walls ... regardless of the specific character of the time, place or program” (**program** is an architectural term for a building’s function).¹²⁶ The swooping, symmetrical forms of the TWA terminal express mankind’s soaring aspirations of flight. “Architecture must make a strong emotional impact,” Saarinen said, “wherever you are, inside or outside, the building sings with the same message.”¹²⁷ In the TWA terminal, this message is the beauty, thrill, and glamor of flight, especially the luxury amenities marketed by Trans World Airlines in the jet age. In this, the building was also a highly visible piece of advertising for the airline itself.



Eero Saarinen, “Tulip” chair, designed 1956, manufactured c. 1970.

Brooklyn Museum, Gift of Knoll International, Inc. Photo: Brooklyn Museum

TWA was formed in 1930. While it ran limited passenger routes in the 1930s, its most prominent client during its first decade was the United States Postal Service. After the Second World War, under the leadership of the eccentric aviator Howard Hughes, TWA acquired a New York to Paris passenger route and began rebranding itself as a luxury airline. Prior to this, only Pan American Airways had offered international passenger services. To expand their clientele, Pan Am and TWA marketed air travel as an aspirational part of the postwar “American Dream.” Stressing comfort, safety, and convenience, the airlines succeeded in almost tripling their business in just five years. Between 1945 and 1950, the number of annual air passengers increased from six million to seventeen million. In the same years, TWA successfully



The interior of the TWA terminal before its recent renovation, c. 2015.

Photo by Huanhai777



David Klein, TWA “Paris” advertising poster, 1964.

increased its global market share to 25 percent of all international flights.

The tipping point for international travel came in 1959 when, for the first time, a majority of Americans traveling overseas went by plane (rather than boat).¹²⁸ This was also the year Saarinen was commissioned to build the TWA terminal. At the dawn of what became known as the jet age, after the new, faster, and more efficient engines that increasingly powered passenger planes, TWA was using its New York Flight Center as a form of advertising that stressed the glamor and speed of commercial flight. The terminal also included new amenities we have come to associate with air travel, including exclusive lounges, a choice of restaurants, automated baggage return, and covered jetways (rather than stairs that rolled up to the plane).

TWA was just one of Saarinen’s many corporate clients. He also designed campuses and headquarters for Bell (the largest telecom company in the United States at the time), [General Motors](#), and John Deere. Saarinen was skilled at corporate branding via architecture, and none of his projects was a more visible architect-company partnership than the TWA terminal. He harnessed a growing dissatisfaction among architects with the “one size fits all” approach of towering glass boxes, adopting a more organic, expressive style that came to be

associated with modernists of the 1950s and 1960s. In the TWA Flight Center, Saarinen's dedication to emotional resonance and sculptural form matched with the aspirational vision of passenger air travel desired by his corporate client. While TWA went out of business in 2001, Saarinen's building was saved due to its architectural and historical importance. After a massive renovation restoring its eggshell white and TWA red color scheme and repairing the roof, the terminal building reopened as part of a hotel complex attached to JFK's Terminal 5 in 2019.¹²⁹

SELECTED WORK: Nam June Paik, *Electronic Superhighway: Continental U.S., Alaska, Hawaii*, 1995

Nam June Paik was born in Seoul in 1932, when what became the modern nation of South Korea was still under the control of the Japanese Empire. Paik was born into an elite family that highly prized education and introduced him to European music and literature at a young age. In 1952, Paik left Korea for Japan, where he studied aesthetics and music theory at the University of Tokyo. After graduating, he went to Munich, at that time in West Germany, where he became connected with a multimedia avant-garde art scene that encompassed music, performance, and conceptual art. Paik began working in performance and installation in the late 1950s, using an approach informed by ideas from Buddhism and by the American popular culture that had saturated Korea and Japan during his youth. (Paik claimed the American child star Shirley Temple was the first person—including members of his own family—whose full name he was aware of.¹³⁰) Some of his earliest works show this collision of influences, such as his performances that meditated on emptiness and silence (*Hommage à John Cage*, 1959) and TV sets whose output had been manipulated or distorted (*Zen for TV*, 1963).



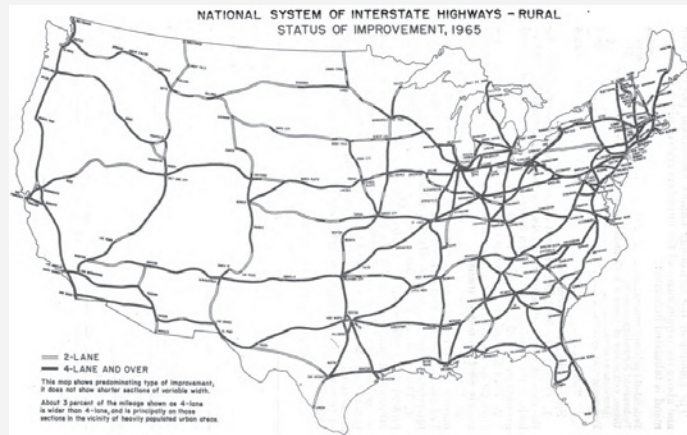
Nam June Paik, photographed in 1959.

In the early 1960s Paik became connected with the international avant-garde movement **Fluxus**, an experimental group of artists, musicians, and performers whose conceptual art focused on breaking down barriers between art and everyday life. Participatory, performative, immersive, and collaborative multimedia work characterized Fluxus practice. Loosely associated members of the group included [George Maciunas](#), [Alison Knowles](#), [Yoko Ono](#), and [Joseph Beuys](#). Paik also began teaching himself about electronics and collaborated with Japanese engineer Abe Shuya to help him realize technically complex artworks that included responsive feedback, pre-recorded and live footage, and various forms of sonic and visual distortion. In 1964 Paik relocated to New York, where he spent most of the rest of his career.

Paik's work is difficult to characterize succinctly. It ranged from "scores" (instructions for performances that

could be followed by anyone, a common Fluxus strategy) to musical notations using [unconventional instruments](#), performances, sculptures, video pieces, [robots](#), public television broadcasts, and [large-scale installations](#) incorporating screens and digital data. Considered one of the most influential “new media” artists of the twentieth century, Paik passed away in 2006.¹³¹

Electronic Superhighway, which has a permanent home in the Smithsonian American Art Museum in Washington, D.C., is one of Paik’s most monumental constructions. Consisting of more than three hundred stacked and nested TV screens, the piece is around forty feet long and fifteen feet tall. It is also a visually compelling work of art, drawing the eye using neon tubing and constantly changing images. Stepping back, it is easy to see that the conglomeration of screens represents a map of the United States (Alaska and Hawaii are installed off to the side, like in printed map insets). Each state’s border is outlined in brightly colored neon lights, and a few bodies of water, including the Mississippi River and the Great Lakes, are also highlighted.



Map of proposed interstate highway expansion, President’s Advisory Committee on a National Highway Program, 1955.

Appearing to hover behind this glowing map, but supported by a substantial armature of wooden framing, TV screens of various sizes are fit together in a puzzle-like configuration. Each state’s outline contains one or more screens, all looping clips of film or TV footage related to that state. For instance, the outline of the state of Kansas shows clips from the 1939 movie *The Wizard of Oz*, where its heroine Dorothy Gale lives on her family’s farm (before being whisked to the magical land of Oz).

Paik was reportedly fascinated by the U.S. highway system that linked the continental United States in a web of multi-lane freeways. This network was implemented during President Dwight Eisenhower’s administration under the Interstate Highway Act of 1956. The interstate system made it easier and faster for travelers to travel across the country. Though earlier projects established major highways, this expansion created a more intentionally integrated network that used consistent construction principles, numbering, and signage. Along with the aggressive marketing of the family automobile in the postwar era, the completion of the interstate system encouraged Americans to take to the roads during their leisure time.

Paik marveled at how the interstate highway system, spanning disparate regions of the country, contributed to processes of American cultural unification in the postwar years, connecting people, expanding product distribution networks, and facilitating the spread of nationally recognizable chain stores and restaurants. *Electronic Superhighway* presents the physical network of the interstate highways as a unifying force, along with another element of American cultural hegemony: TV.¹³²

Paik, sometimes called the “father of video art,” was also one of the first people to create viewer-responsive artworks, seen particularly in his use of televisual technology. In 1969, he participated in a group exhibition in New York, “[TV as a Creative Medium](#),” where he exhibited a TV that was programmed to respond to the sounds visitors made into a microphone. Attempts to “humanize the technology” by adding these participatory elements, the *Village Voice* critic Stephanie Harrington wrote, were interesting but ultimately “off-putting” and lacked a “unifying” idea.¹³³

For Paik, questions about machine learning, feedback, and other networked systems were driven by the theory of [cybernetics](#) popularized by the computer scientist Norbert Wiener in an influential 1948 book.

Conceptual artists like [Dan Graham](#), [Hans Haacke](#), and Paik adopted Wiener's theories in artworks that analyzed and presented datasets, responded to viewer actions, or addressed human-machine relationships. For Paik, cybernetics also had a spiritual dimension: he wrote that: "Cybernetics", as the science of pure relations ... has its origin in 'Karma' in Buddhism [*sic*]."¹³⁴

One of the most interesting things about Paik's interest in cybernetics and systems theory was how it allowed him to thematize the possibilities of the internet as a potential replacement for travel. In *Electronic Superhighway* he references not only the physical travel from place to place that was made possible by the expansion of the interstate highway system in the 1950s, but also the possibility that

a user might soon be able to "travel" virtually using a telecommunications network. Already in 1974, twenty years before making *Electronic Superhighway*, Paik wrote: "Transportation and communication are considered generally as two separate issues ... What we need is an Ersatz (substitute) technology to travel, and broadband communication is the strongest candidate for it."¹³⁵

Paik imagined a user who had, at their fingertips, all fifty of the state "channels" seen in the installation and could access them on demand. Around the same time, Paik argued for the coming importance of dematerialized information over physical experience: "Information is no longer a means to get something live and concrete, but has become an end in itself."¹³⁶ Combining the artwork's title and Paik's focus on information, it's important to note that in the 1980s and early 1990s, the phrase "information superhighway" was a nickname for the [internet](#).

Paik successfully predicted many things about the twenty-first century, including, apparently, the smartwatch, writing in 1965: "Some day every high-brows will have laser-phone number ... which enables to communicate everyone everywhere wirelessly and simultaneously. ... to send much more information ... [for instance] audio, video, pulse, temperature, moisture, pressure, movements of your body."¹³⁷ However, several elements hinted at in *Electronic Superhighway* turned out to be incorrect. The piece imagines a new generation of users staying home and accessing information via TV, satellite, and broadband instead of "pleasure driving," as they had in the postwar interstate era.¹³⁸ If the same "information" could be communicated without people needing to physically travel to sites, then Paik suggested, "the frequency of travel will reduce" and "it will cut down air travel."¹³⁹ Obviously, these claims have been proved wrong. Around 1.3 billion passengers traveled by air in 1995, while thirty years later there were more than 4.46 billion airplane passengers annually.¹⁴⁰ As it turns out, virtual worlds have not, and cannot fully, replace the experience of traveling somewhere in person. The aspect of adventure and the wonder of travel are still going strong today.



Ford Mercury advertisement, 1962. Marketing the family automobile using the iconography of the interstate highway system: the multi-lane road and red, white, and blue shield-shaped sign still used for interstates today.

SECTION V SUMMARY

Representing Modern Forms of Travel in Modern Styles

- The century between the 1830s and the 1930s saw the spread of several new forms of transportation and the explosion of modern artistic movements.
- Modern artists increasingly used abstraction to represent—and even attempt to reproduce—the thrilling experience of riding in a train, car, or airplane.

SELECTED WORK: Claude Monet, *Arrival of the Normandy Train, Gare Saint-Lazare*, 1877

- Claude Monet was an Impressionist painter. He was known for painting outdoors and for the appearance of spontaneity—a momentary “impression”—in his work.
- The Impressionists were rejected by the French art establishment and put on alternate exhibitions to challenge the official Salons. Typical subjects included natural landscapes, activities associated with middle-class leisure time, and the changing city of Paris.
- Paris underwent a major urban renewal project in the 1860s and 1870s. As part of this expansion, seven new rail stations were built.
- The *Gare Saint-Lazare* was the earliest of the major stations and connected the capital with northwestern suburbs, including Argenteuil, where the Monet family lived.
- The architecture of the train hall, which used an iron and glass roof structure to span the large area and to bring in natural light, was an emblem of France’s modernity.
- Monet painted at least a dozen images in the *Gare Saint-Lazare* series. His focus was on the architecture of the station as it interfaced with effects of light, weather, and atmosphere.
- The Saint-Lazare paintings were Monet’s first recorded attempt to make a group of works meant to be viewed as a series. He later applied this idea to some of his more famous series, such as his haystacks and waterlilies.

SELECTED WORK: Robert Delaunay, *Homage to Blériot*, 1914

- Manned motorized flight was initiated by Orville and Wilbur Wright in 1903. Unlike trains, airplanes were not a practical method for moving large numbers of people until decades later.
- French painter Robert Delaunay was associated with Cubism, but his growing interest in color theory resulted in his rejection from the group in 1912.
- Delaunay and his wife, Sonia Delaunay-Terk, were associated with the Orphism movement. Their approach was deeply emotional and spiritual, in opposition to Cubism’s more rigid intellectual approach.
- Delaunay made several versions of *Homage to Blériot*, trying different color combinations to see which created the most effective optical vibrations. The version in your Art Reproductions Booklet shows several recognizable motifs, including multiple airplanes and the Eiffel Tower.
- *Homage to Blériot* celebrates Louis Blériot, a celebrity aviator who was the first person to fly across the English Channel in 1909. Delaunay was a fan of Blériot’s and attended the celebratory parade in Paris after the channel crossing.
- Delaunay experimented with showing multiple views at once, including aerial views, perhaps trying to simulate the experience of flying.
- Delaunay was one of several modern artists who experimented with how to render flight in a painting. Around the same time, artists from England, Russia, and Italy used similar techniques of multiple perspectives and fragmentation to represent flying planes.

SELECTED WORK: Tamara de Lempicka, *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)*, 1929

- Tamara de Lempicka was a Polish artist who worked in Paris in the 1920s. She was known for her portraits of wealthy clients.
- De Lempicka combined Cubism’s faceted shapes and analysis of space with a sense of

luxury associated with the Art Déco style. Lasting from around 1924 to 1930, Art Déco was known for its focus on brilliant colors, angular shapes, expensive materials, and motifs relating to modern life.

- ◆ *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)* shows de Lempicka wearing leather driving gloves and a helmet at the wheel of a luxury automobile. Vibrating with glamour and confidence, the artist presents herself as a woman in control of her speeding automobile.
- ◆ First developed in Germany around 1885, internal-combustion-engine-powered vehicles were a luxury item at first. But by 1927 there was one car for every forty-four people in France, where de Lempicka was living.
- ◆ Other artists of the time tended to show cars as “masculine” items. *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)* instead shows automotive technology as accessible to and enjoyable for modern women.
- ◆ *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)* was one of several covers de Lempicka made for *Die Dame (The Lady)*, a German style magazine with a large circulation. These covers helped spread the image of a glamorous and modern “new woman” archetype in interwar Europe. *Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)* and *Die Dame* presented the car as an engine of women’s liberation.

Innovative Technologies and Media

- ◆ Later twentieth-century artists used architecture and new media to celebrate modern travel. Their innovative forms capture the dynamism of flight or thematize more conceptual ideas about travel.

Selected Work: Eero Saarinen, TWA Flight Center, John F. Kennedy International Airport, New York, New York, 1959–62

- ◆ Eero Saarinen was a Finnish American architect. His first major design was for the Gateway Arch in St. Louis, Missouri. This project shows his dedication to modern materials used in an innovative way, embrace of organic lines and shapes, and ability to

use expressive form to communicate with audiences.

- ◆ In the early twentieth century, most airport buildings were utilitarian structures with a low, shed-like appearance. However, when Trans World Airlines (TWA) commissioned its New York Flight Center from Saarinen, it envisioned the building as a symbol of flight and a form of advertising in a new age of transatlantic air travel.
- ◆ From the street, the TWA Flight Center looks like a giant white bird with wings outstretched. The vast interior space is filled with curving forms. Interior and exterior form a cohesive whole that Saarinen described as representing “the excitement of travel.”
- ◆ The primary material of concrete over flexible metal mesh allowed Saarinen to shape and sculpt the building into its exaggerated, winglike forms. The lightweight shell roof incorporates multiple skylights, enhancing the building’s feeling of upward momentum and airiness.
- ◆ Saarinen believed that organic architectural forms—those resembling shapes found in nature—would be welcoming, visually interesting, and psychologically nurturing to users. The swooping, symmetrical forms of the TWA terminal express mankind’s soaring aspirations of flight.
- ◆ TWA marketed air travel as an aspirational yet accessible part of the postwar “American Dream.” In 1959, for the first time in history, the majority of Americans traveling overseas went by plane (rather than boat). TWA was one of only two airlines offering transatlantic commercial passenger flights in these years.
- ◆ Saarinen’s design included new amenities we have come to associate with air travel, including exclusive lounges, a choice of restaurants, automated baggage return, and covered jetways (rather than stairs that rolled up to the plane).
- ◆ When TWA went out of business in 2001, the building was saved due to its architectural importance. It is now part of a hotel complex.

SELECTED WORK: Nam June Paik, *Electronic Superhighway: Continental U.S., Alaska, Hawaii*, 1995

- ◆ Nam June Paik was a South Korean multimedia and performance artist. Growing up in Seoul, he embraced both American popular culture and ideas from Buddhism, which he would combine in much of his work.
- ◆ In the early 1960s, Paik became connected to Fluxus, a movement characterized by participatory, performative, immersive, and collaborative multimedia work.
- ◆ Shortly before moving to New York in 1964, Paik began to create technically complex artworks that included responsive feedback, pre-recorded and live footage, and various forms of sonic and visual distortion.
- ◆ *Electronic Superhighway* consists of more than three hundred stacked and nested TV screens representing a map of the United States, with each state's border rimmed by glowing neon tubing. Within each state's outline, looped clips of film or TV footage play, with imagery related to the specific state.
- ◆ One of Paik's inspirations was the U.S. highway system. This network was implemented under the Interstate Highway Act of 1956 and made it easier and faster for travelers to travel across the country. The highway system also created new distribution networks and facilitated the spread of nationally recognizable chain stores and restaurants.
- ◆ Paik's work was influenced by theories of cybernetics introduced in the 1940s. He was one of many artists inspired by cybernetic theory to incorporate machine learning, feedback, and systems into art.
- ◆ In addition to real highways, *Electronic Superhighway* references the possibility that a user might "travel" virtually using a telecommunications network. Paik believed the nascent internet had the potential to completely replace travel in the future. *Electronic Superhighway* foresaw how important virtual communication and networked computing would be to ideas about travel in the twenty-first century.

Conclusion

This resource guide has interpreted this year's theme, *Journeys of Transformation: An Exploration of Travel and Transportation*, through an expansive lens. It has provided a survey of how artists from different cultures and time periods reflected on experiences of travel in the modern era. This conclusion briefly points to three larger themes that have emerged over the course of this resource guide: technologies of travel, cultural exchanges, and the way images contribute to memory-making.

There are many techniques we use to move from place to place, some enhanced by new technologies and others as old as humankind itself. From walking and sailing to driving and flying, the examples in this guide help us consider how crucial the simple experience of moving through space has been to people in different places and time. Deep dives into the history and context around each selected work demonstrate that that experience—navigating from place to place—can be vastly different depending on where, when, and how you are making your way. As you move through your day-to-day life, think about the many forms of transport you encounter. What bodily sensations or cultural references do those modes of transportation evoke for you? How would you go about representing those sensations or experiences in art, as many of the artists in our resource guide did? What new transportation technologies do you anticipate arising in the future, or will you only travel virtually, as Nam June Paik envisioned?

This guide has also considered processes of cultural exchange. When we travel, we not only learn about new cultures and ideas, but we bring with us materials, techniques, or perspectives that alter the people and places we encounter. Cultures and traditions do not remain static; they are formed and modified through

contact with new people and ideas. These cultural exchanges can be fraught and complex, as many artists who deal with legacies of colonialism suggest in their works. But they can also be enriching and empowering. Experiences of diaspora or displacement produce both resistance and pride. Techniques learned from other cultures can be used to challenge preconceived ideas. In contrast with appropriation, the uncredited use of another's images or traditions, many of the works discussed in this guide suggest processes of appreciation, remixing, and renegotiation. Artists use experiences of travel to enrich their work by considering perspectives that might not have occurred to them if they had stayed home.

Finally, images are crucial to forming both individual and cultural memory. Images can be used explicitly to create and shore up narratives, whether those are personal or national. Maps may encourage us to explore, but they can also prompt us to remember, to reflect on the processes of claiming and naming that shaped the language we use in the present. Personal souvenirs of travel solidify the idea that "I was there" and provide a touchpoint that enables travelers to relive or recount their experiences. Whispered imprints of feet on the grass recall our passing. Repeated instructions for navigating by water or land begin to form collective memories that allow travelers to get where they are headed, in safety. The artistic and material objects that result from experiences of travel can serve as powerful aids to remembering, whether the memory is particular to a certain individual or shared by a group. Inspired by influences from at home and abroad, created by a diverse group of artists, the works in this resource guide have given you a brief look at how artists have dealt with the theme of travel and transportation.

Timeline

c. 1300 BCE –	The Marshall Islands are settled.
c. 1200–1300 –	The Māori people settle in New Zealand.
1492 –	Christopher Columbus lands in the Americas.
1603–1868 –	The Edo period in Japan, a stable era under the rule of the Tokugawa family
1670 –	The first printed use of the phrase “Grand Tour” to describe a period of European travel and study for wealthy young men
1707 –	The last eruption of Mount Fuji
1742–44 –	SELECTED WORK: Canaletto, <i>The Square of Saint Mark’s, Venice</i>
1746–55 –	Canaletto is in London, painting landscapes for wealthy English clients.
1779 –	British explorer Captain James Cook is killed by native Hawaiians. The first “mini-Fuji” is constructed.
1805 –	The French company Dufour produces <i>Les sauvages de la mer Pacifique</i> wallpaper, later the inspiration for <i>in Pursuit of Venus [infected]</i> .
1819 –	The “Mini-Fuji” in Meguro is constructed.
1825 –	The first railway passenger line opens in England.
1830s –	The Hudson River School’s approach to painting popularizes landscape art and tourism in the United States.
1835 –	The Gare Saint-Lazare opens in Paris and is the city’s first major train station.
1839 –	The invention of photography is officially announced to the scientific and artistic communities.
1845 –	Sir John Franklin’s expedition leaves England to search for the Northwest Passage.
1848 –	The Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood is founded in London; it includes John Everett Millais.
1850 –	The Fugitive Slave Act is passed in the United States.
1857 –	SELECTED WORK: Utagawa Hiroshige, <i>New Fuji, Meguro</i>
1860s –	Urban redevelopment of the city of Paris, including expansion of rail network and construction of new bridges
1869 –	Completion of the Transcontinental Railroad in the United States

1871 –	Ferdinand V. Hayden leads the first United States Geological Survey party to the American West.
1874 –	SELECTED WORK: Sir John Everett Millais, <i>The North-West Passage</i> The first Impressionist exhibit opens in Paris.
1876 –	Fred Harvey opens the first “Harvey House” restaurant in Kansas.
1877 –	SELECTED WORK: Claude Monet, <i>Arrival of the Normandy Train, Gare Saint-Lazare</i> Osman Hamdi Bey is named the founding director of the Imperial Museum of Antiquities in Istanbul. James Tissot paints <i>Portsmouth Dockyard</i> , later the inspiration for <i>Between the Two my Heart is Balanced</i> .
1880 –	SELECTED WORK: Osman Hamdi Bey, <i>Young Woman Reading</i>
1885 –	The internal combustion engine is successfully used in the first passenger automobiles in Germany.
1888 –	George Eastman markets the first portable camera, the Kodak No. 1.
1890 –	SELECTED WORK: Frederick F. Church, <i>George Eastman on board the S.S. Gallia</i>
1892 –	SELECTED WORK: The Rebbelib Navigation Chart is collected by Admiral Davis (original creation date unknown).
1900 –	Kodak introduces the Brownie camera, which costs only \$1.
1901 –	The Atchison, Topeka & Santa Fe Railroad completes the Grand Canyon spur, making the site more easily accessible to tourists.
1903 –	Orville and Wilbur Wright complete the first manned, powered airplane flight at Kitty Hawk, North Carolina.
1905 –	SELECTED WORK: Charles Wittlesey, <i>El Tovar Hotel completed</i> Norwegian explorer Roald Amundsen becomes the first non-Inuit person to navigate the Northwest Passage.
1908 –	Theodore Roosevelt creates the Grand Canyon National Monument.
1909 –	Louis Blériot becomes the first aviator to fly across the English Channel.
1912 –	Robert and Sonia Delaunay break away from Cubism, declaring a new movement, Orphism.
1914 –	SELECTED WORK: Robert Delaunay, <i>Homage to Blériot</i>
1917 –	The Russian Revolution forces Tamara de Lempicka to flee to Paris.
1919 –	Congress creates Grand Canyon National Park.
1924–30 –	The Art Déco movement is popular in Europe and the United States.
1929 –	SELECTED WORK: Tamara de Lempicka, <i>Self-Portrait (Tamara in a Green Bugatti)</i> Clärenore Stinnes and Carl-Axel Söderström complete their circumnavigation of the world by car.
1930 –	TWA (later renamed Trans World Airlines) is founded.

1931–33 –	Diego Rivera and Frida Kahlo are living in the United States.
1932 –	SELECTED WORK: Frida Kahlo, <i>Self-Portrait on the Borderline between Mexico and the United States</i>
1938 –	Frida Kahlo has her first solo show in New York City.
1945–59 –	Expansion of commercial air travel after World War II
1946 –	TWA acquires its first international passenger route: New York to Paris.
1948 –	The SS <i>Empire Windrush</i> arrives in Britain, beginning the era of Caribbean immigration to the United Kingdom. Eero Saarinen comes to fame after winning the Jefferson National Expansion Memorial competition for his Gateway Arch design. Norbert Wiener publishes his book <i>Cybernetics</i> , which influences Nam June Paik.
1956 –	Congress passes the Interstate Highway Act, creating the national highway system.
1962 –	SELECTED WORK: Eero Saarinen, TWA Flight Center completed
1967 –	SELECTED WORK: Richard Long, <i>A Line Made by Walking</i>
1969 –	“TV as a Creative Medium” exhibition in New York, one of the first exhibitions to feature new media
1979 –	The Republic of the Marshall Islands gains independence. UNESCO declares the Grand Canyon a World Heritage Site.
1986–90 –	Lubaina Himid opens The Elbow Room in London, the first gallery dedicated to exhibiting work by British artists of African and Asian descent.
1989 –	Richard Long wins the Turner Prize.
1991 –	SELECTED WORK: Lubaina Himid, <i>Between the Two my Heart is Balanced</i>
1992 –	Jaune Quick-to-See Smith curates <i>Submuloc Show – Columbus Wohs</i> to mark the anniversary of Columbus’s first voyage to the Americas.
1995 –	SELECTED WORK: Nam June Paik, <i>Electronic Superhighway: Continental U.S., Alaska, Hawaii</i>
2000 –	SELECTED WORK: Jaune Quick-to-See Smith, <i>State Names</i>
2001 –	TWA airlines goes bankrupt, and the JFK Flight Center is disused until 2019.
2003 –	UNESCO defines and calls for the protection of “intangible cultural heritage.”
2013 –	UNESCO declares Mount Fuji a World Heritage Site.
2015 –	SELECTED WORK: Lisa Reihana, <i>in Pursuit of Venus [infected]</i>
2017 –	SELECTED WORK: Dawoud Bey, <i>Untitled #13 (Trees and Reflections)</i> Dawoud Bey wins a Macarthur Fellowship (aka “Genius Grant”). Lisa Reihana represents New Zealand at the Venice Biennale with <i>in Pursuit of Venus [infected]</i> . Lubaina Himid wins the Turner Prize.

2019 –	The former TWA Flight Center reopens as part of a hotel complex.
2024 –	Local authorities create restrictions for tourists wishing to climb Mount Fuji.

Glossary

abolitionists – activists who sought to outlaw slavery

abstraction – in art, the simplification of visually recognizable forms

Art Deco – 1920s movement with an opulent and colorful visual style featuring repeating patterns and intricate geometric shapes

Bey – honorific title of the Ottoman Empire, referring to a high-ranking official

cartography – another word for mapmaking

conceptual art – 1960s–70s movement, in which the finished artwork is less important than the idea or “concept”

cybernetics – a theory popularized by computer scientist Norbert Wiener and adopted by artists who used machine learning, feedback, and other networked systems

daguerreotype – one of the earliest photographic processes, a small, single image on metal

diasporas – communities of people from particular countries, ethnic groups, or religious backgrounds who have left a homeland and settled all over the world

dunung – a Marshallese term for ocean swell patterns used for navigation

en plein air – a French term for the practice of painting outdoors, often used by Impressionists

Fluxus – an experimental 1960s movement, focusing on participatory, performative, immersive, and collaborative multimedia work

gelatin silver printing – an analog photographic process using silver halides suspended in gelatin to create a light-sensitive surface

Grand Tour – an extended trip through Italy and France to study classics, history, language, art, and

architecture; seen as a rite of passage for young British aristocrats in the eighteenth century

hadith – a collection of sayings attributed to the Prophet Muhammad, containing a proscription on images of holy figures and living beings; it was not followed strictly in the Ottoman Empire.

harem – in many Muslim cultures, the female-only part of a private household

idealizing or **idealization** – in art, representing things not as they truly appear but as perfect, ideal forms

indigenismo – a Spanish term for the new interest in Indigenous life and heritage that emerged during the Mexican Revolution

Land art – 1960s–70s movement in which artists made physical interventions into the natural environment

mana – a term used by the Māori people for the sacred power that inheres in objects

mattang chart – a Marshallese diagram used to teach navigators how swell patterns radiate out from islands

meddo chart – a Marshallese diagram representing small clusters of islands, used for local navigation

mestizaje – a Spanish term for the experience of being a mixed-race person

Mexican muralism – an artistic movement featuring large-scale wall paintings stressing Indigenous heritage and narratives as part of a new national history in postrevolutionary Mexico

nishiki-e – Japanese multi-colored woodblock prints of the Edo period, usually showing *ukiyo-e* subjects

Orientalism – a genre of European painting that represented an imagined view of the customs, people, and places of North Africa and the Middle East

Orphism – a French painting movement of the 1910s,

focusing on a combination of abstraction and color theory; the artistic approach was deeply emotional and often spiritual.

panorama – painted scenes displayed in a large-scale horizontal format, often representing faraway destinations as a form of vicarious travel; popular in Europe in the eighteenth century

pilot vessel – in Marshallese navigation, a canoe that leads the way for other boats in a flotilla

Portolan chart – a navigational guide for sailors mapping the outline of a coastal area

Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood – a group of progressive English artists in the 1840s and 1850s, whose name referred to their desire to return art to a time “before” the High Renaissance

program – in architecture, another word for a building’s function

rebbelib chart – a Marshallese diagram representing a large area, often used to navigate the entire Marshall archipelago

retablo – a small religious image or altarpiece, mainly made for personal or household devotional use in Mexico and the U.S. Southwest

Salon – French state-sponsored art exhibition, often known for showing more conservative or academic work

salted paper print – an early photographic process, usually made with paper negatives soaked in salt water and silver halides, then exposed to light

street photography – genre of informal unposed images taken in public places

sublime – an aesthetic term stressing human insignificance when compared with the vastness of nature, often used to describe nineteenth-century landscape painting; sublime elements include sensations of great height, impressions of loud sound, or the general feeling of awe in response to nature.

taonga – means “prized possession” in the Māori language; can refer to physical objects and practices that hold important personal and cultural value

toponym – another word for a place name

ukiyo-e – a genre popular with educated, urban audiences in late Edo-era Japan, with subject matter of popular entertainments, celebrities, festivals, and scenic views; translating to “pictures of the floating world,” *ukiyo-e* images were made by drawing, painting, or printing.

Underground Railroad – a network that assisted enslaved people in their escape to free states or to Canada

vedute – Italian word meaning “views,” usually refers to paintings of local landmarks made to sell as souvenirs for wealthy tourists in the eighteenth century

wet plate collodion process – an early photographic process that involved smearing a mixture of tarlike substance onto a glass plate and then exposing it to light to produce a negative

woodblock – a relief printing process made using a wooden block, in which areas the artist does not want printed are cut away, leaving a raised design that can be inked (like a rubber stamp)

yashmak – a gauzy head and face covering for women, popular in the late Ottoman period

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